

From the Linear to the Circular:

Re-thinking Operational Depth

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Cover: The term imtzu'a (אימצוע), seen on the cover, is a Hebrew word that, in the context of Israeli Operational Art, refers to the manipulative operationalisation of the middle ground—between oppositions—to exploit the potential presumed to exist there.

The image was generated using ChatGPT-4. Prompt: "A background image of the Middle East region map, with Israel placed at the center of the image. The map includes visible neighboring regions such as Syria, Lebanon, Jordan, and Sinai, slightly desaturated. The provided symbol (triangle with PROJECT, MANOEUVRE, ABSORB, DEPTH, and the red Hebrew word) is overlaid in the exact center of the image."

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Abstract

This is an exploratory, concept-developing compilation thesis focusing on Operational Art, particularly Depth. It is a fieldwork-oriented project using Israel as a case study to examine how a deficiency in physical Depth can be effectively managed in relation to an adversary, while challenging the common assumption that a lack of physical space inevitably leads to military defeat. The thesis utilises a theoretical foundation of manoeuvre theory (MT) and systemic operational design (SOD), and two specific approaches: first, it broadens the concept of Depth to include a cognitive element alongside its usual physical and temporal dimensions; second, it challenges the linear, reverse-engineered approach to Operational Art often seen in Western contexts by adopting a nonlinear perspective that emphasises anticipation and the cunning exploitation of emerging potential. Research was conducted in Israel across five periods, including interviews with a comprehensive group of seasoned generals and insightful others, field excursions, training in Operational Art, and case studies of previous engagements by the Israel Defence Forces. Three main contributions are presented: firstly, it offers hard-to-access insights into Israeli operational thinking; secondly, it demonstrates how Depth can be expanded cognitively even when physical resources are limited; thirdly, it introduces and develops a circular model that can generate Depth in new ways by leveraging existing resources rather than focusing on what is missing. The thesis highlights a strong interest in Depth-related activity within Israeli operational thinking due to its limited geography and predominantly hostile neighbourhood. Consistent with the nonlinear approach, it concludes that Depth is best understood as the unrestricted freedom of manoeuvre available to the operational commander when engaging the enemy. Although operating in Depth is often regarded as more effective because it offers significantly greater freedom compared to the front, the main obstacle to achieving this freedom is created by friendly forces through doctrine, tradition, and the prevailing paradigm—obstacles that require active manipulation to secure sufficient operational freedom to act in new ways from one operation to another.

Keywords: Strategy, Operational Art, Operational Depth, Manoeuvre thinking, Operational Design, Nonlinear.

Sammanfattning

Detta är en konceptutvecklande sammanläggningsavhandling om operationskonst och dess centrala parameter, Djup. Det är ett explorativt, fältstudie fokuserat projekt där Israel används för att studera hur avsaknad av fysiskt Djup kan hanteras effektivt relativt en väpnad motståndare. Genom sin litenhet i relation till sitt operativa CV, sätter Israel en egen standard och utmanar den förutfattade meningen att avsaknad av fysiskt territorium leder till militärt nederlag. Med konceptutvecklande ambitioner, breddas Djup till att även betraktas kognitivt utöver dess fysiska och temporala aspekter. Dessutom utmanas den linjäritet och det fokus vid ”reverse-engineering” som återkommande kan observeras i västliga operativa kontexter. Härvid antas en icke-linjär utgångspunkt med fokus vid förändring och exploatering av den potential som kan identifieras under ett pågående skeende, vilket korrelerar väl med den operativa filosofi som återfinns i Israel. Inhämtningsarbetet har utförts i Israel vid fem separata vistelser då en grupp erfarna generaler och en rad andra med avgörande insikter har intervjuats, vid sidan av exkursioner i den operativa miljön, träning i operationskonst, samt fallstudier av operationer där Israels Försvarsmakt, IDF har deltagit. Vid dessa studier noteras ett stort intresse för djupoperationer och att Djup med fördel kan förstås som det oinskränkta handlingsutrymme den operativa befälhavaren åtnjuter i kampen mot motståndaren. De största hindren för att möjliggöra oförutsägbart agerande utgörs den egna sidans doktriner, traditioner och organisatoriska strukturer vilka fordrar aktiv manipulation till förmån för maximal operativ effekt. Som konceptuellt stöd när begränsningar av fysiskt Djup råder, framhålls vikten av ett kognitivt angreppssätt vilket kompletteras med en cirkulär modell för att hjälpa oss använda de verktyg vi faktiskt har, i stället för att fokusera på vad vi saknar. Avhandlingen försöker varken förstå eller förklara det pågående kriget i regionen, eller den större frågan som berör Israel och Palestina.

Nyckelord: Strategi, Operationskonst, Operativt Djup, Manövertänkande, Operationsdesign, Ickelinjär

Acknowledgements

This manuscript represents the culmination of knowledge and insights accumulated over more than five years of research for this thesis. While it would be impossible to thank everyone who has contributed to this project without the risk of inadvertently omitting someone, I am nonetheless willing to take that risk.

Although my name is the only one on the cover page, this has not been a one-man enterprise in its entirety. Many people to whom I am grateful and indebted are involved, and I would like to mention some of the more significant contributors here. That said, none of the others are forgotten!

Perhaps it goes without saying, but first and foremost, I would like to express my deepest gratitude to my wife and best friend, Maria, and to our sons, Lukas, Jakob, and Oskar. Without your endless patience, support, and coaching, this would not have been possible. Thank you also for accepting being implicitly put on display, given the recurring media engagements this project has brought on me regarding the ongoing war in the Levantine region.

Regarding the research project itself, I would like to begin by expressing my deepest appreciation to Shimon Naveh and Ofra Graicer of the IDF's Generals Course, Strategema. Your tireless efforts to enhance my understanding of Operational Arts and, ultimately, this dissertation, have been truly outstanding. The dedication you have shown, especially during my fieldwork periods in Israel, is truly remarkable. The same can be said of your ongoing support, projected from afar, including our continuous discussions and your feedback on my ideas and article drafts.

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Last but not least, I also extend a big thank you to Jonny Trinh at the Anna Lindh Library for his exceptional efforts in helping me with the final layout.

Dedication

To my beloved sons, Lukas, Jakob, and Oskar:

With will and determination, anything is possible; it might just take a little longer…

// Dad.

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List of Articles

This dissertation is based on the following papers:

Paper I

Ekholm, Anders. 'Re-Thinking Operational Depth- a Source of Power'. Comparative Strategy 40, no. 4 (2021): 387–406. https://doi.org/10.1080/01495933.2021.1939615

Paper II

Ekholm, Anders. 'Wizards of Depth-Israel's Area of Operations and Lessons Learned from Its Depth Dimension'. Defence Studies 24, no. 1 (2024): 1–24. https://doi.org/10.1080/14702436.2023.2288117

Paper III

Ekholm, Anders. 'From the Linear towards the Circular: Strategy, Operational Art and Israeli Perceptions of Depth'. Unpublished manuscript (2025). (Under review at the European Journal of International Security; EJIS-2025-0127.)

Paper IV

Ekholm, Anders. 'Between Depth and Takhbulah — Learning to Exploit Cunning Intelligence in Future Strategy and Operations'. Comparative Strategy 43, no. 5 (2024): 500-523. https://doi.org/10.1080/01495933.2024.2383149

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Introduction

'The theater of operations of an army embraces all the territory it may desire to invade and all that it may be necessary to defend'.[1]

The epigraph at the beginning of this chapter, attributed to the renowned general and military theorist Baron de Jomini, provides a fitting starting point for analysing depth in military operations, which is the central theme of this thesis. It emphasises the extensive scope of military operations, encompassing both offensive and defensive strategies.

When a military actor engaged in armed conflict, finds itself lacking the physical conditions necessary for effective competition against its adversary, there is a problem. This situation refers to a deficiency in operational depth, which involves the essential elements needed to withstand hostile power projection through defensive manoeuvres,[2] as well as to conduct offensive operations beyond friendly territories. As a vital aspect of Operational Art, i.e., the means of converting strategic solutions, a cognitive product, into actionable plans through operations,[3] depth is closely tied to the fundamental nature of warfare: the enduring balance between offence and defence.[4]

As signposted by the opening words, depth related to military operations is typically understood in physical and linear terms 'between fighting front and deep supporting rear',[5] where the argument that '…operational action always develops from the rear, i.e., depth, towards the front, in an interdependent sequential mode…' is illustrative

During the preparation and writing of this thesis, Grammarly PRO was used, which includes generative AI features. All content has been carefully reviewed, edited, and validated by the author, who accepts full responsibility for the final form and content of the work. Additional AI tools include Otter.ai for transcribing interviews and ChatGPT to create the cover page. Since this is a compilation thesis where the main body ("Kappa") aims to synthesise findings from four research articles, there are natural similarities and some overlaps between the main text and the articles. All material in this thesis, including the main body and the four articles, is the author's original work.

[1] An early expression of depth, reflecting the interplay between offence/ defence and forward/ rearward. See Antoine Henri de Jomini, *The Art of War* (London: Greenhill Books, Lionel Leventhal Limited, 1996). p 75.

[2] Absent space for defensive manoeuvring, see Meir Finkel, *On Flexibility - Recovery from Technological and Doctrinal Surprise on the Battlefield* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2011). p 64; See also Stephen Biddle, *Military Power: Explaining Victory and Defeat in Modern Battle* (Princeton University Press, 2004). p 49; For further elaboration on the issue, see space-force & space-time ratio in Milan Vego, *Joint Operational Warfare: Theory and Practice*, 2nd ed. (Rhode Island: U.S. Naval War College, 2007). p III-52-58.

[3] In this regard, see V.K. Triandafillov, *The Nature of the Operations of Modern Armies*, ed. Jacob W. Kipp (Abingdon: Routledge, 1994). *xv;* see also: Colin S Gray, *The Future of Strategy* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2015). p 82.

[4] See Richard E Simpkin, *Race to the Swift* (London: Brassey's Defence Publishers, 1985). p 99.

[5] Bruce W Menning, 'Operational Art's Origins', in *Historical Perspectives on the Operational Art*, ed. Michael D Krause and Cody R Phillips (Center of Military History, United States Army, 2007). p 5; see also U.S. Army Combined Arms Doctrine Directorate, 'FM 100-5 Operations' (Washington, D.C., 1986). p 16; for additional Soviet- and American, resource-intensive theories such as Deep Operations, Active Defence and Airland Battle, see B.A. Friedman, *On Operations: Operational Art and Military Disciplines* (Annapolis: Naval Institute Press, 2021); and Charles C Krulak, 'Operational Maneuver from the Sea' (Washington, D.C., 1999).

for research on the subject.[6] Alternatively, as outlined in American military doctrine, 'Depth is the extension of operations in space, time, and resources. Through the use of depth, a commander obtains the necessary space to maneuver effectively; the necessary time to plan, arrange, and execute operations; and the necessary resources to win'.[7] Other researchers, such as G.S. Isserson and David Glantz, perceive operational depth with an implicit emphasis on forces at a certain level:[8] '…the depth, that is, at which a manoeuvre would force the enemy to react at the operational level'.[9]

While such linear and resource-intensive perceptions are clear and straightforward, making them easy to understand and incorporate into military doctrine,[10] they are not always favourable. Such concepts implicitly suggest a causal, or at least correlational, relationship between a lack of physical space [depth] and military defeat. This poses particular challenges to states that lack the necessary physical prerequisites, such as geography or weight in metal, to deter, compel, or contain enemy power projection.[11] However, the obvious question remains: if they do not possess these assets, how should they proceed?

Addressing this issue reveals a limitation in previous research on depth, which tends to focus primarily on large state entities and massive formations,[12] while implicitly overlooking the challenges faced by physically smaller groups.[13] However, there are many real-world examples of smaller states or weaker groups tackling this challenge in different ways, at least temporarily. Theoretically, this category can encompass both offensive and defensive enterprises, covering archaic examples like The Battle at Thermopylae (480 BC), where inferior Spartan forces held off invading Persians,[14] or The Battle of Cannae (216 BC), during which Hannibal and his Carthaginian troops defeated a much bigger Roman army,[15] and more contemporary ones like The

[6] Shimon Naveh concludes Soviet as well as American operational perceptions in: Shimon Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence* (Oxon: Frank Cass Publishers, 1997). p 17; see also Menning, 'Operational Art's Origins'. p 4-10; Ofra Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead*, Special Ed (Tel Aviv, SheNomad Ltd., 2015). p 53; Dima Adamsky, 'Through the Looking Glass: The Soviet Military-Technical Revolution and the American Revolution in Military Affairs', *Journal of Strategic Studies* 31, no. 2 (April 2008). p 267ff; and for logic countermeasures related to this reasoning, see Biddle, *Military Power: Explaining Victory and Defeat in Modern Battle.* p 62, 66ff; See also *Culmination and Reversal* in Edward N Luttwak, *Strategy: The Logic of War and Peace* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2001). p 17, 20-28.

[7] U.S. Army Combined Arms Doctrine Directorate, 'FM 100-5 Operations' (Washington, D.C., 1986). p 16; for related reasoning through an empiric scope, see Charles L Crow, 'Tactical and Operational Depth' (Fort Leavenworth, Kansas, 1986). p 5ff, 24f.

[8] Depth within the confinement of Operational Art, see, for example, G.S Isserson, *War of Future*. p 98; see David M Glantz, *Soviet Military Operational Art - In Pursuit of Deep Battle* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2021). p 10.

[9] Simpkin, *Race to the Swift*. p 40.

[10] See related arguments in Friedman, *On Operations.* p 55f.

[11] For resource-intense concepts, see, for example, the U.S. Doctrine of Overwhelming Force (Desert Storm) and Overmatching Power (Iraqi Freedom), as discussed about Mass-time and space in Graicer's *Two Steps Ahead*. p 49. As an additional contemporary example of such a concept, see U.S. Army TRADOC, 'The U.S. Army in Multi-Domain Operations 2028', 2018; For a resource-intense and expeditionary concept related to Operational depth, see Krulak, 'Operational Maneuver from the Sea'. p 83.

[12] See the previous note; see also G.S. Isserson, *The Evolution of Operational Art* (Fort Leavenworth, Kansas: Combat Studies Institute Press, n.d.). p 48, 55; Christopher Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2014). p 98; Bruce W Menning, 'The Imperial Russian Legacy of Operational Art, 1878-1914', in *Historical Perspectives on the Operational Art*, ed. Michael D Krause and Cody R Phillips (Center of Military History, United States Army, 2007). p 203ff; Vasiliy Yefisovich Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View* (Honolulu: University Press of the Pacific, 1972). p 119; Crow, 'Tactical and Operational Depth'. *Abstract.*

[13] A key feature addressed in the thesis is a lack of space for defensive manoeuvring as manifested by the Israeli case.

[14] J.F.C. Fuller, *De Avgörande Slagen [The Decisive Battles of the Western World]* (Lund: Historiska Media, 2003). p 57-67.

[15] See Fuller, *De Avgörande Slagen [The Decisive Battles of the Western World].* p 136f.

Battle of Dien Bien Phu (1954), where Vietnamese troops triumphed over a larger French army. We must also consider the formidable defence-in-depth presented to the invading Soviets by the Finnish defenders during the Winter War of 1939-40, or the highly effective expeditionary Falklands War, where British expeditionary troops defeated a numerically superior Argentine defence despite being 12,000 km from their base. These cases illustrate how operational or strategic depth can be achieved through innovative tactics, terrain exploitation, or force employment, even in the absence of conventional resources.

In this thesis, the capitalised term 'Depth' is used purposefully to differentiate it from standard interpretations. Usually, in Operational Art and military operations, 'Depth' follows the prefix 'Operational-', which denotes the practical application of coercive resources against an adversary. Nevertheless, in this thesis (despite the title), this prefix is intentionally omitted to encompass a wider scope, including cognitive solutions *and* their practical applications.[16] In this context, Operational Art functions as the means to translate the idea of strategy into action: *the operation.*

Moreover, regarding prefixes, we are better off without them, at least in this thesis. Thus, as William Lind implicitly suggests, additional conceptual divisions or boundaries will only necessitate human coordination, thereby giving a cunning adversary more weaknesses to exploit.[17]

Problem, scope and relevance

This thesis explores the concept of Depth from a contemporary standpoint, emphasising Israel as a paradigmatic case study of a geographically limited actor with a significant operational history (for further details regarding the research design, see the Methodology chapter).[18]

The analysis relies primarily on approximately fifty interviews with seasoned generals, admirals, and a few prominent others who were active during key periods in Israel's timeline, supplemented by various on-site fieldwork efforts to grasp its intricate operational landscape fully. Essentially, Israel stands out as an example that could be placed alongside the ones mentioned above. Not only does it lack the physical (spatial) Depth needed relative to a traditionally hostile region,[19] but it has

[16] In this thesis, the cognitive solution to the military problem is referred to as 'Strategy'. In this sense, it is a short-dated product that requires constant reframing due to the evolving character of a reality characterised by complex human interaction. This perception somewhat contrasts with the prevailing idea of strategy as a more long-term endeavor: 'the art of distributing and applying military means to fulfill the ends of policy', as seen in Basil Henry Liddell Hart, *Strategy*, 2nd ed. (New York: Meridian, 1967). p 321f.

[17] Gaps are weak points that can be exploited; see William S Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook* (New York: Routledge, 1985). p 73ff.

[18] *A case of*, see Bent Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research', *Qualitative Inquiry* 12, no. 2 (2006). p 238f.

[19] Israeli lack of depth, see Shmuel Bar, 'Israeli Strategic Deterrence Doctrine and Practice'. *Comparative Strategy* 39, no. 4 (2020): 321–353; see also Dag Henriksen, 'Deterrence by Default? Israel's Military Strategy in the 2006 War against Hizballah'. *Journal of Strategic Studies* 35, no. 1 (2012). p 102f. In this regard, it is also important to mention the 2020 Abraham Accords treaty, an important step in

also demonstrated the capacity to succeed in military operations repeatedly, *despite* its limited size.[20] Even when caught unprepared, blinded by its own ignorance,[21] it has turned disadvantages into to success.[22]

Israel's relationship with its limited physical space, recurring hostile threats, and its ability to succeed highlights a significant feature of Depth, namely, '…that material factors alone cannot explain capability…'[23] Drawing on this insight while challenging the foregone conclusion that spatial constraints lead to defeat, Israel is a paradigmatic example —a laboratory for exploring and developing the concept of Depth in a nonlinear manner.[24] Thus, by leveraging knowledge, theory, experience, and intuition,[25] it is argued that valuable insights into the development of Depth can be gained by examining contemporary Israeli Operational Art beyond its traditional security concept and inclination for preemptive measures, [26] transferring the fighting to enemy territory.[27] Shmuel Bar explains:

> *'In Israeli defense doctrine, "decision" cannot be achieved by fighting on Israeli territory but only by carrying the war into the territory of the enemy […] This is not only due to Israel's lack of strategic depth, but because the subsequent deterrent effect on the enemy of the humiliation of having been defeated on its own territory is far greater…'*[28]

normalising relations between old foes in the region. See Abraham Accords, Peace Institute, https://www.aapeaceinstitute.org/; for additional elaboration on Israeli Depth, see Ariel Levite, *Offence and Defense in Israeli Military Doctrine* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1989). p 55 (words of Yigal Allon), 66f, 70f.

[20] Israel ended up victorious in 5 out of 6 interstate wars conducted during the state's existence. See David Rodman, *Combined Arms Warfare in Israeli Military History* (Eastbourne: Sussex Academic Press, 2019). p 109f.

[21] Just weeks before the Yom Kippur War of 1973, Israel received a secret warning from the Jordan King, Hussein, but failed to act accordingly. See Simon Dunstan, *The Yom Kippur War 1973* (Oxford: Osprey Publishing Ltd., 2003). p 21f; related to ignorance, see also John A English and Bruce I Gudmundsson, *On Infantry*, Rev. ed. (Westport: Praeger Publishers, 1994). p 171f; to ignore things that contradict your established perceptions, see David J Lonsdale, *The Nature of War in the Information Age: Clausewitzian Future* (London: Frank Cass, 2004). p 188.

[22] On the progression from disadvantage to success, see Kenneth M Pollack, *Arabs at War: Military Effectiveness, 1948-1991* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2004). p 1f, 122

[23] Biddle, *Military Power.* p 190; see also Morris, who elaborates on how strengths and weaknesses are found beyond narrow aspects of military formations and available weapons: Benny Morris, *1948: The First Arab-Israeli War* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2008). p 398.

[24] The Paradigmatic case, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 232f.

[25] On the need for intuition and experience to categorise a case as paradigmatic, see Ibid. p 233. Moreover, the characteristics of the two theoretical points of departure and the case itself have contributed to the case selection and its categorisation.

[26] See Meir Finkel, 'Preventive War: Its Disappearance from Israel's Security Toolbox and the Need for Its Return', *BESA Center Perspectives Paper*, no. 2270 (2024); see also Dima Adamsky, *The Culture of Military Innovation* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2010). p 112.

[27] On transferring the war to enemy territory, see Eran Ortal, 'The Fly on the Elephant's Back: The Campaign between Wars in Israel's Security Doctrine'. Strategic Assessment - A Multidisciplinary Journal on National Security 24, no. 2 (2021): 1–16; see also Meir Finkel, 'The Occupation of Territory in War: A Diplomatic and Strategic Achievement for Israel', *BESA Center Perspectives Paper*, no. 2263 (2024).

[28] Bar, 'Israeli Strategic Deterrence Doctrine and Practice'. p 336; in this regard, see also Dmitry Adamsky, 'From Israel with Deterrence: Strategic Culture, Intra-War Coercion and Brute Force'. *Security Studies* 26, no. 1 (2017): 165ff.

Originally, this security concept comprised three pillars: Deterrence, Early Warning, and the ability to win decisively.[29] More recently, a fourth pillar — active defence — was added to complement the concept.[30] Moreover, without doubt, Israel's long history of persecution, catastrophes, and a collective fear of new Holocausts may help explain the high level of motivation and perhaps some unique abilities as well.[31] That said, Israel's alliance with the US remains a significant factor in its power. While the exact impact is uncertain, a well-founded assumption based on Israel's operational track record motivates an on-site study of Israeli operational thinking.

Thus, the fact remains: the modern battlefield is constantly growing;[32] and the already tiny swath of land that constitutes the state of Israel becomes even smaller in relation to the regional threats it faces. This evolution blurs and renders obsolete the physical, linear approach to Depth and operations that dominate previous research on the subject.[33] Moreover, since actors committed to war or armed conflict typically can reach and engage the entire disposition of their adversaries,[34] physical [linear] divisions and categorisations of physical theatres of operation have become increasingly irrelevant, even for larger actors. Simultaneously, a growing array of alternative means is included in the coercive toolbox, rendering the operational reality even more complex with higher demands for coordination and speed, which is yet another incentive to study the Operational Art of this rare single-service actor '[with] "jointness" built in...'[35]

Consequently, this thesis marks a shift away from linearity by exploring and developing a nonlinear approach to Operational Art. It involves moving beyond the characteristics typically associated with major powers that possess extensive geographical Depth and instead focuses on change and adaptability.[36] This shift exceeds doctrinal conformity and reverse engineering to maximise the potential arising from developments.[37] This approach addresses a gap in previous research

[29] Adamsky, *The Culture of Military Innovation.* p 112; see also Shay Shabtai, 'Updating the "Security Concept"'. *Infinity Journal* 4, no. 2 (2014): 4–11.

[30] Extending the Israeli security concept, See Udi Dekel and Omer Einav, 'Revising the National Security Concept: The Need for a Strategy of Multidisciplinary Impact'. *INSS Insight*, no. 733 (2015); see also Meir Finkel, Yaniv Friedman, and Dana Preisler-Swery, 'Active Defense as the Fourth Pillar of the Israeli Security Concept'. *IDF Dado Center Journal* 4 (2022).

[31] See Morris, *1948.* p 399; in this regard, see also Christine Sylvester, *War as Experience: Contributions from International Relations and Feminist Analysis* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2013). p 27f.

[32] For the notion of growing battlefield, see Triandafillov, *The Nature of the Operations of Modern Armies*. p *xxxviii.*

[33] See Ben-Hador, Eran-Jona, and Dandeker, 'Perceptions of the Future Battlefield in Israel vs. Western Countries'. p 710, 723; see also: Biddle, *Military Power.* p 66f; Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View*. p 113f.

[34] A fact elaborated by Adamsky in 'Through the Looking Glass'; considering means available for long-range engagements, both sides generally have the option of conducting operations deep in the adversary's disposition, see also Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 158f; and Azar Gat, 'The Changing Character of War', in *The Changing Character of War*, ed. Hew Strachan and Sibylle Scheipers (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011). p 39f; For a real-time example, see Tamir Hayman, 'Operation Rising Lion: Achievements, Open Questions, and Future Scenarios', *INSS Insight*, no. 2007 (2025).

[35] Edward N Luttwak and Eitan Shamir, *The Art of Military Innovation: Lessons from the Israel Defense Forces* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 2023). p 12.

[36] Major actors with physical resources and substantial reserves can potentially absorb an adversary while preparing for counteraction. See Biddle, *Military Power.* p 70f; for further discussion on robust reserves as a depth provider, see Rex C. McMillan, 'Ready to Go-Now: *Marine Forces Reserve Stands Ready to Meet Unpredictable Threats'. The Officer,* Winter 2016. p 42-45.

[37] For closely related reasoning, see Ben Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2023). 8f; for additional thoughts on exploiting the potential in the situation, see Francois Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy : Between Western and Chinese Thinking* (University of Hawai'i Press, 2004). p 26, 33, 189.

related to Depth, namely, the focus or preponderance towards vast geography and massive military formations, which renders it problematic and sometimes even irrelevant to less significant actors. In this regard, the notions 'less significant' and 'limited resources' are labels recurrently employed to frame and describe the main audience, that is, the universe of cases the thesis speaks to, in this instance, those without the geographical Depth needed to resist an aggressor through defensive manoeuvring.[38]

Considering the current research landscape and the limited attention to this specific case, this thesis utilises manoeuvre theory (MT) and systemic operational design (SOD) as relevant starting points to potentially develop a Depth-concept accessible to those who are physically smaller. Doing so also aids fieldwork by narrowing the focus to exploring aspects that have been previously deemed both tangible and relevant.[39] Although they are assumed to be effective individually, the basic logic of these perspectives is closely aligned. Therefore, they appear particularly suited to be used together to make up for the lack of Depth and physical resources compared to an opponent or group of opponents.[40]

MT proposes a formula for enhancing strength through cognitive-centred manoeuvres, characterised by minimal investments yielding high returns.[41] As Francois Jullien puts it, '"with very little effort," one can produce "great effects."'[42] This concept simplifies the process of amplifying strength by acting indirectly against weaknesses. In doing so, it emphasises the use of cunning brainpower to enhance physical power while undermining the adversary's resolve.[43] In close alignment with the concepts of manoeuvre and mission command, we see the SOD approach to military operations. Developed within the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) in the late 1990s, SOD offers an alternative to more linear planning models and predictable behaviour.[44] SOD focuses on actor deconstruction, relationships, and the cunning disruption of vital links. Like MT, it primarily emphasises indirectness, minimal input, and multiplied outputs. SOD offers a unique [nonlinear] view on warfare and military operations, contrasting with what Zweibelson describes as traditional Newtonian linearity.[45] As this brief overview demonstrates, these

[38] In this thesis, '*the physically less fortunate'*, *'the one without physical prerequisites'* or *'the less significant'* refers to a lack of strength in relative terms given the contextual adversary- or a coalition of adversaries.

[39] The relevance of these theoretical points is confirmed by extensive personal training in Operational Art with the head of the IDF Generals Course, conducted on-site in Israel on multiple occasions.

[40] For related reasoning, see Marc D Jessup, 'Systems Competition: The Unifying Thread and Theme of Maneuver Warfare'. *Marine Corps Gazette*, no. June 2020 (2020). p 58.

[41] MT signature characteristics, see Jan Angstrom and J.J. Widen, *Contemporary Military Theory* (New York: Routledge, 2015). p 84f, 113-119; Robert R Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver: Maneuver-Warfare Theory and AirLand Battle* (New York: The Ballantine Publishing Group, 1991). p 27-31.

[42] Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 19.

[43] Alex Danchev, 'Liddell Hart and Manoeuvre'. *RUSI Journal*, no. December (1998). p 34; see also Robert Fry, 'The Meaning of Manoeuvre'. *RUSI Journal*, no. December (1998): 41–44; In this regard, see also War on the mind in Justin Kelly and Mike Brennan, *ALIEN: How Operational Art Devoured Strategy* (Carlisle: Strategic Studies Institute, 2009). p 53-58.

[44] SOD; mission command, deep systemic understanding- to embrace emergence and thrive in chaos, see Eitan Shamir, *Transforming Command* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2011). p 124ff; see also Adamsky, *The Culture of Military Innovation.* p 104ff.

[45] Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 114-143, 180f.

perspectives concentrate on the cognitive aspects of Operational Art, which further underpins the importance and relevance of the cognitive conceptual extension and the subsequent insights contained in the accompanying articles.

Research Questions

Concerned with the issue of adopting traditional, linear methods and philosophies when physical prerequisites are limited or absent, the thesis examines the concept of Depth through a case study of Israel. It aims to identify alternative approaches to Depth to facilitate concept development for actors who lack Depth in the traditional physical sense. To achieve this effectively, the following research questions are formulated.

How has the lack of depth affected Israeli Operational Art and operational thinking?

This overarching question will be divided into two sub-questions:

How is the lack of depth reflected in Israeli Operational Art?

How has it been resolved in IDF operational thinking?

These questions are primarily explored by analysing the operational thinking of a group of experienced Israeli generals. This qualitative approach emphasises conducting in-country interviews and discussions, supplemented by diverse fieldwork activities to gain a comprehensive understanding of the contextual factors that shape the observed operational logic.

Ambition, Purpose, and Approach

This thesis aims to provide three main contributions. Firstly, starting from an understanding of the operational environment as a dynamic entity that extends beyond its physical prerequisites, the main aim of this thesis is to contribute to developing a nonlinear approach to Operational Depth that considers cognitive factors while challenging traditional thinking.[46] This is done with the help of an in-

[46] For example, more or less predictable time-space-force estimates and sequenced reverse engineering of actions and effects along predetermined lines of operation.

depth empirical [paradigmatic] case study of operational thinking in the IDF.[47] In support of this overarching aim, Depth is regarded from a comprehensive perspective rather than a traditional and strictly military [physical] perspective.[48] This is not an attempt to give Depth a 'catch-all tag' that includes everything. Instead, it is a conscious move to promote creativity while critically reflecting on your thinking and ability to '…bring something new into existence […] [and to] properly evaluate and present already existing ideas or processes in a different way'.[49] Drawing on John Fuller, the logic behind this approach is evident, especially considering the ambiguous character of contemporary wars where '…physical blows are but the left-hand punches which culminate in this right-hand blow to the jaw, and the jaw may not necessarily be a military one'.[50] Although from a period predating Fuller, Jomini provides further support for this view, recognising that: 'The results of a battle generally depend upon a union of causes which are not always within the scope of the military art'.[51] Standing on the shoulders of these influential soldier-scholars, Depth is thus treated comprehensively, constructed with *whatever resources are available,* regardless of tradition, level of warfare, or origin. Thus, the incitement to treat Depth with a capital D but without prefixes.[52]

The second contribution is the provision of meaningful and rare empirical insights derived from a complex and dynamic operational landscape. This unique material, collected from a difficult-to-access environment during recurring periods, offers new perspectives on Operational Art, which may be more accessible for physically smaller states.

Aside from these scientific contributions, a significant third contribution lies in offering knowledge, insights, and perspectives for practical application within the military profession. This initiative also challenges the conventional linear approach to Depth and Operational Art.[53] Not only because it requires physical resources to an extent not readily available to all actors,[54] but it also seeks to address the challenge of predictability, often accompanied by ignorance and the use of ideal models, as noted by the phrase, '…blinded by prejudice and shackled by

[47] The paradigmatic case, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 232f.

[48] The ability to project power, absorb power and to maintain the ability to maneuver available coercive tools- or assets along physical- or cognitive, offensive- and defensive lines of operation.

[49] Vego, 'On Military Creativity'. p 83; in this regard, thinking about thinking constitutes a closely related way of ensuring that we do not become a victim of our own ignorance, see Ofra Graicer, Philippe Dufort, and Oliver Jones, 'What Is Strategic Design? Cultivating Cognitive Agility for the Craft of Generalship'. *The Journal of Design, Economics, and Innovation* 8, no. 3 (2022). p 353f; also Alex Ryan, 'A Theory of Systemic Design', in *Relating Systems Thinking and Design 2013 Symposium Proceedings* (Oslo: OCAD University Open Research Repository, 2013). p 3f; and Zweibelson, 'One Piece at a Time'. p 361.

[50] J.F.C. Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*, 2021st ed. (Hassell Street Press, 1926). p 316; regarding this widened perception of Operational Art, see also Tarak Barkawi and Shane Brighton, 'Powers of War: Fighting, Knowledge, and Critique', *International Political Sociology*, no. 5 (2011). p 136f.

[51] Jomini, *The Art of War*. p 178.

[52] See Friedman raising caution against simplifying war using artificial linearity by dividing the matter into tactical-operational-strategic spheres, in Friedman, *On Operations.* p 54f.

[53] To employ ideal models and linear planning, see Francois Jullien's *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 189ff; see also Ben Zweibelson, 'One Piece at a Time: Why Linear Planning and Institutionalism Promote Military Campaign Failures', *Defence Studies* 15, no. 4 (October 2015). p 361ff.

[54] In this respect, we lean on Steven Biddle's claim that material inferiority is nevertheless a poor indicator of military outcomes. Biddle, *Military Power.* p 193.

tradition…'.[55] In doing so, it serves as a wake-up call, potentially leading to more effective and less narrow-minded military planners and practitioners.[56] Bill Owens expands on this warning, emphasising how ignorant forces can stifle imagination while increasing operational predictability:

> '…there are common causes for military disasters, and at the heart of them lie dangerous smugness, institutional constraints on innovation, and the tendency to avoid questioning conventional wisdom. And the side that is the most smug, the most convinced that its interpretation of the past is the best guide for the future, often turns out to be the loser in the next war'.[57]

Attached articles

In pursuit of answers to the questions, with a developing ambition and an explorative mindset, a compilation format is utilised to qualitatively examine the subject across four levels of abstraction, each culminating in a research article. Consistent with the purpose, previous research, and the two theoretical perspectives employed, these articles incorporate the cognitive dimension of Depth as an indirect auxiliary to conventional physical and temporal perceptions, while aiming to shift the understanding of Depth towards a nonlinear interpretation. Brett Friedman provides additional support for this logic:

'If the tactics work, then operations will work; if the operations work, then the strategy will work. This is very easy to teach in professional-military education courses and easy to depict in doctrine. It is also easy for commanders to fall back on such training when confronted with the inherent complexity and non-linearity of war outside the class room. But it is not only wrong—it cannot succeed in the real world'. [58]

Starting the first article at a basic level of abstraction, Depth is examined broadly. This sets a foundational understanding by outlining the main directions in existing research and enhances the review chapter of this compilation. Next, the focus shifts from desk research to fieldwork, moving from general prior studies to how the

[55] Fuller, J.F.C. *The Reformation of War* (London: Hutchinson & CO., 1923). p 38.

[56] Threats to creativity in military organisations, see Milan Vego, 'On Military Creativity', *JFQ*, no. 70 (2013). p 84ff.

[57] Bill Owens, *Lifting the Fog of War*, 1st ed. (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2000). p 20; in the same context, B.A. Friedman elaborates on the problem of teaching the adversary how to win, a side-effect of victory if you stick to the ideal model while declining to re-evaluate the emerging situation that follows. See Friedman, *On Operations.* p 19; addressing the same obstacle to creativity, see Colin S Gray, 'Irregular Warfare: One Nature, Many Characters', *Strategic Studies Quarterly* 1, no. 2 (2007). p 51.

[58] For a deeper understanding of the nonlinear turn and its incentives, consult the works of Friedman, *On Operations.* p 55; and Alan Beyerchen's, 'Clausewitz, Nonlinearity, and the Unpredictability of War', *International Security* 17, no. 3 (1993): 59–90.

subject is addressed in the challenging Israeli operational environment. This transition results in three more articles that explore Depth at different levels of abstraction. Overall, the approach to the subject evolves from broad and superficial to focused and detailed, concluding with an article that offers a practical way to develop Depth along cognitive lines. The introduction to Chapter 4 of this compilation provides further details about the relationship between the articles.

The alteration of abstraction is simply a way of examining the subject from different perspectives. Doing so ensures a thorough understanding of how Depth relates to existing research and the empirical case, all guided by the research question. As a result, the audience gains a clear and comprehensive understanding of the topic.[59]

To further enhance research efficiency and sense-making, the altered abstraction level is employed in conjunction with two contrasting outlooks on Operational Art, derived from previous research. On the one hand, there is the linear and conforming '*Forward/Rearward' approach*.[60] On the other hand, the nonlinear and evolving '*Project-Absorb-Manoeuvre*' approach developed in this thesis.[61] The outlooks and their functioning logic are further elaborated in the summary related to the review of previous research in this compilation, alongside the contents of the third article.

Organisation of the compilation chapter

Following this introduction, attention shifts to previous research. First, I offer a broad overview of the wider topic of Operational Art, followed by sections examining how Depth has been perceived or measured in prior studies. This approach effectively establishes the research framework within which this thesis demonstrates its relevance and contribution to the academic field. After the review, the focus moves to theory and methodology. When doing so, the key starting points are outlined, followed by questions about research design, methods used, empirical cases, information collection, and ethical considerations.

Following the methodology, the attached articles and their contributions are presented, effectively demonstrating the report and the actual findings of the thesis.[62] This presentation emphasises the practical implications of the research, allowing the audience to understand the relevance and real-world application of the findings to military strategy and Operational Art. It begins by explaining the relationship between the articles and their interconnected logic, which together

[59] Jonathan W Moses and Torbjörn Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing: Competing Methodologies in Social and Political Science*, 2nd ed. (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012). p 132f; for more related to triangulation in this regard, see Staffan Larsson, 'Om Kvalitetskriterier i Kvalitativa Studier [About Quality Criteria in Qualitative Studies]', in *Kvalitativa Metoder [Qualitative Methods]*, ed. Gunilla Klingberg and Ulrika Hallberg (Lund: Studentlitteratur AB, Lund, 2021). p 350f.

[60] See Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 81f; Jomini, *The Art of War*, 1996. p 75.

[61] Initially introduced in the first article of this compilation: Ekholm, 'Re-Thinking Operational Depth- a Source of Power'.

[62] The report. see the divided logic presented by Pat Thomson and Barbara Kamler in *Writing for Peer Reviewed Journals- Strategies for Getting Published* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2013).

offer more significance than each part alone. An informative diagram supports this second step. Finally, the thesis findings are discussed, summarised, and developed into more specific responses to the research question, which are then presented considering the scope of the research and prior studies. Lastly, a discussion regarding potential shortcomings is provided, along with implicit proposals for future research.

Previous Research

This second chapter offers a comprehensive review of previous research in the field of attention, covering Operational Art generally and the specific sub-branch focused on Depth in more detail. It not only highlights the gap or limitation in existing studies that this thesis aims to address but also emphasises its unique contributions. It is important to note that the review goes beyond traditional academic research, incorporating insights from professional military thinkers across various historical contexts. Additionally, it includes insights from military doctrine, providing valuable perspectives on Operational Art and Depth, thus ensuring a well-rounded understanding of the subject. Overall, this approach presents the evidence that supports the thesis's relevance both internally and externally, while maintaining the reader's interest.[63] The general outline of the review is organised in order of abstraction, with the parts moving from the broad to the more specific.

The review starts with Operational Art, an aspect of warfare understood here as the coordination of coercive assets that embody a strategy, meaning an idea and an outlined solution to mitigate a problematic situation or to preserve a desired one.[64] Representing the broader context, the first part of the review presents a mosaic of perceptions and understandings of Operational Art, within which the sub-branch and main subject [Depth] is situated. This demonstrates how Operational Art is primarily characterised by linear coordination (cause-and-effect, sequential) of significant physical resources. However, other, less linear viewpoints (focused on emergence and evolution) are exposed too.[65]

The second central part of the review concentrates on Depth itself. Divided into three subsections, it shows how research on this topic is dominated by linear, resource-heavy approaches that are accessible to major actors with extensive geographic and military capabilities. In doing so, the first subsection reveals how previous research views Depth more broadly by exposing different trajectories of the subject. The second subsection focuses on momentum and culmination, an operational duality that we must understand within this context. The third subsection offers greater detail and a deeper engagement with the subject of Depth. Collectively, the main section on Operational Art and the three subsections about Depth highlight *the gap*—a problematic state of research for less geographically

[63] For related reasoning regarding the semi-structured review, see Hannah Snyder, 'Literature Review as a Research Methodology: An Overview and Guidelines', Journal of Business Research 104, no. November (n.d.). p 335; regarding relevance, see Laurens K Hessels, Harro van Lente, and Ruud Smits, 'In Search of Relevance: The Changing Contract between Science and Society', Science and Public Policy 36, no. 5 (2009): 387–401.

[64] In this regard, it should be noted that the cognitive solution, strategy, and its practical manifestation- the operation ideally expresses the same, although in different languages.

[65] Linear (from one to another), predictable, cause and effect (positivism), see Aaron P Jackson, *Military Design Thinking: An Historical and Paradigmatic Analysis* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2025). p 7, 162f; Nonlinear, context in emergence, see Ibid. p 81, 119; see also Ben Zweibelson, 'Linear and Non-Linear Thinking: Beyond Reverse-Engineering', *Canadian Military Journal* 16, no. 2 (2016). p 31.

significant actors, namely, those without the physical space needed for defensive manoeuvring.[66] Beyond exposing the gap, it provides a relevant reference point, namely, the cognitive space occupied when the Depth subject is studied and discussed.[67] The third role of these parts is to provide the extra effort expected of a compilation text compared to each part individually. This comprehensive approach ensures that the audience gains a clear understanding of the research.

The final section offers a summary divided into two parts: the first discusses and elaborates on linearity and nonlinearity, features that are evident in research on Operational Art. The second part summarises specific elements from previous research that are crucial for this project.

Ideally, the review chapter presented here is intended to function in concert with the four articles, particularly the first, making it the compilation it is designed to be. The associated articles themselves represent the actual 'report section'- *i.e. the findings*,[68] while the compilation text provides the sense-making framework that draws conclusions and makes arguments beyond the separate parts alone.

Now, let us turn to the next section discussing features and perceptions of Operational Art, outlining the broader research area in which the subject of particular focus (Depth) is situated.

Operational Art

> 'Operational art encompasses the theory and practice of preparing for and conducting combined and independent operations by large units (fronts, armies) of the armed forces'.[69]

As we are about to see, there are slight differences in perceptions of this subject, making it accessible to different audiences, ranging from the resource-intensive, physically focused understanding described above to approaches that rely on minimal input and generate higher revenues. Regardless, as the label indicates, Operational Art is just that —an art form with the cunning objective of outmanoeuvring the adversary while reflecting a practical echo of the strategic (cognitive) solution to the problem.[70] Moreover, as described in the opening

[66] In this regard, it is also essential to view the case study regarding its historical coalition of antagonists. Both in terms of geography (space) and military resources, as they have shaped the magnitude of forces available.

[67] Occupying the research space. See Thomson and Kamler, *Writing for Peer Reviewed Journals.* p 98, for more related information.

[68] See Tiny Texts and the four (five) moves in Thomson and Kamler, *Writing for Peer Reviewed Journals.* p 59-77.

[69] A Soviet early 20th perception centred on magnitudes of forces, see Glantz, *Soviet Military Operational Art.* p 10.

[70] Cunning – shrewd, crafty. In this context, it means *the opportunity to kill while being exposed to the smallest possible risk*. See Fuller, *The Reformation of War*. p 42; for more related to cunning, see Carl von. Clausewitz, *On War*, ed. Michael Howard and Peter Paret (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1989). p 202f.

paragraphs of this thesis, drawing on previous research, Operational Art can be categorised into two broad approaches with different logics. We refer to them as linear and nonlinear.[71] The former is associated with conformity and the *projection* of possible future developments into a preconstructed ideal-model frame, while the latter is associated with *anticipation* and the exploitation of potential emerging from the situation.[72] Reminded of these contrasting outlooks, we carry them forward; not as features structuring the review practically, but as perspectives to boost creative thinking.

That said, let us continue exploring available research and perceptions of Operational Art by first stepping back in history.

As Jonathan House points out, 'Operational' warfare emerged when the Napoleonic battle of decision lost its relevance as ***the*** victory-producing activity.[73] Soviet General and theorist Isserson agrees and argues that the modern operation ceased to constitute 'a one-act operational effort in a single locale'.[74] As the 20th century began with this knowledge, the acting commanders were unsure how to handle this fact while still achieving success. Consequently, Operational Art and the operational level of war emerged as methods for coordinating and sequencing battles and actions to support strategic goals and objectives.[75] Put differently, 'Operational art transformed classical strategy and the hand of man. It opened up the "fist" of annihilation into the more sophisticated and designed articulation of distributed force in depth'.[76]

This historical emergence of Operational Art provides a natural bridge to examining the foundational thinkers who shaped its development. In this thesis, Operational Art is understood and treated as the translating medium, branding the cognitive solution to a problem, namely, *Strategy*, into its practical manifestation —*the operation*. With this understanding established, we now turn to Soviet Generals Triandafillov and Isserson, two prominent soldier-scholars alongside Tukhachevski, in the context of Soviet Operational Art that emerged at the beginning of the 20th century. Although active nearly a century ago, Triandafillov emphasises this timeless relationship and elaborates:

[71] See Zweibelson, 'Linear and Non-Linear Thinking: Beyond Reverse-Engineering'; see also Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 7, 82f, 118f; These points of departure are further elaborated and discussed in the theory chapter, while practically employed in three out of four articles.

[72] Differing outlooks, Projecting vs. Anticipation. See Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead*. p 27f; for additional background, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 189-192; See also Shimon Naveh, Jim Schneider, and Timothy Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution - A Prolegomena* (Booz Allen Hamilton Inc., 2009). p 8, 30; see paradigm vs. context in emergence in Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement.* p 168; This duality is elaborated further in the third attached article: *From the linear towards the circular.*

[73] Jonathan M House, *Combined Arms Warfare in the Twentieth Century* (Lawrence, Kansas: University Press of Kansas, 2001) p 5; see also the Soviet perception based on the rejection of the single battle of annihilation in Glantz, *Soviet Military Operational Art.* p 69; in this regard, see also The expansion of war and the birth of operational art in Kelly and Brennan, *ALIEN: How Operational Art Devoured Strategy.* p 17-21.

[74] Isserson, *The Evolution of Operational Art.* p 48.

[75] House, *Combined Arms Warfare in the Twentieth Century*. p 5.

[76] Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution - A Prolegomena.* p 47.

'…battle is the means of the operation. Tactics are the material of operational art. The operation is the means of strategy, and operational art is the material of strategy…'[77]

Later, the compatriot Isserson continues to emphasise smooth cooperation among diversities, not only on the front line but especially in depth.[78] From a context centred on coordinating large formations, these ideas from half a century ago undoubtedly hold wisdom but are mostly irrelevant to the main audience of this thesis, simply because their concepts presuppose large-scale formations and extensive depth. At the same time, the citation explicitly emphasises cooperation between diversities, between front and depth, and doing so makes it timeless and, therefore, important to more than this thesis.

Not only a matter of sequencing

In more contemporary terminology, what we discuss here is essentially manoeuvre warfare (and thinking (MT)) - a complex and challenging human activity that extends far beyond mere cooperation and sequencing, and the cognitive effort and cunning required are apparent.[79] Especially when resources are scarce. In that sense, MT is often cited as the 'go-to' perspective on effective Operational Art, ensuring that revenues justify the investments.

Theoretically, it is quite straightforward; however, its practical application on larger scales should not be underestimated, as it will require open minds, agile troops (doers), and skilled formations.[80] Often referred to as synonymous with the indirect approach, MT's main characteristic is applying available strength wisely against the adversary's weak points while conversely avoiding heavy opposition.[81] From ancient theorist Sun Zi, we learned that the most effective and sensible strategy is to sabotage the enemy's plans, while the worst is to attack cities fortified with walls.[82] Alternatively, as argued by Robert Leonhard, if you cannot disarm the adversary before the fight (preempt), you should attempt to dislocate his forces, i.e., rendering them irrelevant.[83]

[77] Triandafillov, *The Nature of the Operations of Modern Armies*. p *xv.*

[78] Isserson, *War of the Future*. p 98.

[79] An operational avenue of approach substantially elaborated in this regard is available in the final article of this compilation; see Anders Ekholm, 'Between Depth and Takhbulah — Learning to Exploit Cunning Intelligence in Future Strategy and Operations', Comparative Strategy 43, no. 5 (2024).

[80] For related information, see Luttwak and Shamir, *The Art of Military Innovation*. p 97-103, see also Shamir, *Transforming Command*. p 89 regarding the *bitsuism* culture in the IDF.

[81] see Van Creveld, *Airpower and Maneuver Warfare.* p 1-19.

[82] Sun Zi, *Krigskonst [The Art of War]*, ed. Bengt Petterson and Ooi Kee Beng (Stockholm, 1997). p 25; for more, closely related reasoning dedicated to the indirect approach, see Liddell Hart, *Strategy.* p *xx,* 321-333, 346.

[83] See Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 19f.

Building on the same ideas, we can conclude that the person who starts an aggressive move always risks exhausting themselves in their effort to advance. Conversely, the follower doesn't need to explore unknown territory, and the more defensive measures they take, the more vulnerable they become. However, the less visible they are, the more effective they can be.[84] What is implied here (although implicitly) is the connection between momentum and culmination, which are essential elements of Operational Art and Depth, topics we will revisit later.[85]

That said, a slightly different yet closely related perception defines Operational Art as '…the only means of orchestrating and tying together tactical actions within a larger design that directly contributes to the objectives set by strategy'.[86] From the perspective of this thesis, this offers a highly practical definition of lesser linearity. It is neither overly rigid nor idealistic, as it does not mandate the inclusion of forces from different services or forces of a certain magnitude, as sometimes suggested.[87] Instead, it manifests the precious relationship between the cognitive solution (Strategy) and its practical manifestation, essentially (as Luttwak explains) focusing on the multiplying character that may provide a sum higher than a combination of the tactical activities included.[88] In this regard, a key proposal of this thesis is to broaden the range of means and activities beyond the traditional, which is framed and depicted by the current paradigm —a move supported by the theoretical foundations used in this thesis.

Building on this idea, it can be argued that Operational Art aims to improve the ability and freedom of friendly forces to shift quickly and smoothly between engaging in combat and choosing refusal, ensuring maximum gains relative to the effort invested. Furthermore, speed is emphasised to manage better unforeseen changes than the opponent, which is fundamentally a key aspect of manoeuvre thinking.[89] Thus, 'Determining when and where to fight so a tactical victory has a strategic result is the operational art'.[90]

However, it is also essential to recognise that Operational Art is not merely a matter of manoeuvring, in the sense of physically arranging, concentrating, or dispersing forces —or coercive means —areas where Napoleon could be considered *the* grand master.[91] If so, the operational movements would resemble what Van Creveld calls

[84] In this regard see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 142f, 163; for more related reasoning, see Biddle, *Military Power.* p 47; and Luttwak, *Strategy.* p 20f, 147ff.

[85] An implication of Duration, see Robert R Leonhard, *Fighting by Minutes: Time and The Art of War*, 2nd ed. (Coppell: Robert R Leonhard, 2017). p 81ff; or, stretching too far, see Luttwak, *Strategy.* p 88f, 148ff, 159f, 215f,

[86] See Vego, *Joint Operational Warfare.* p I-11; see also Friedman, *On Operations*. p 5.

[87] The often-used distinction between levels of war is typically associated with an increasing scale in terms of volumes and variety of means. See Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 112f

[88] See Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 112f

[89] In this regard, see Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook*. p 4-8, 24.

[90] Ibid. p 24.

[91] See Biddle, *Military Power.* p 40-71.

contactless shadowboxing without clash and bloodshed.[92] Moving further in the multiplying (manoeuvring) direction, it can thus be argued that Operational Art is more '…about amplifying the force which a small mass is capable of exerting; it is synonymous with the indirect approach'.[93] Alternatively, in terms of agility to harness the potential of the situation and achieve significant effects with minimal effort.[94] Suddenly, wording and messages that could include valuable tips for the physically less fortunate as well.

The translating medium of strategy

Following a nonlinear perception of strategy and Operational Art, it has also been suggested that strategy should not be regarded merely as a means of action, but rather as a means of thought. In this context, an operational commander constantly strives to gain a deeper understanding of the world surrounding them by exposing it to action. Ofra Graicer explains:

> '…generals […] create new patterns of understanding and acting in the world, and they concern themselves with their correlation. Operations are the mechanism of mediation between them and parallel spheres of function (strategy and tactics, corresponding to the dialectics of logic and form)'.[95]

Building on this logic, Operational Art enables the transformation of ideas into practical action, serving as a link that encourages mediation between opposing or dialectical extremes. According to this reasoning, the operation provides a flexible and permissive space for experimentation and error.[96] Furthermore, within this context, operational harmony presents itself as a valuable perspective on Operational Art: sufficiently abstract to encourage creativity and applicability even when resources are scarce, it signifies more than mere cooperation among all involved parts while remaining strongly focused on the objective.[97]

Expanding on the reasoning behind mediating extremes from an operational viewpoint, we turn to Milan Vego. He challenges conformity and the rigid,

[92] Martin Van Creveld, *Airpower and Maneuver Warfare* (Alabama: Air University Press, 1994). p 1f; for related reasoning, see also B. H. Liddell Hart, 'The "Man-in-the-Dark" Theory of Infantry Tactics and the "Expanding Torrent" System of Attack', *The Journal of the Royal United Services Institution.* 66, no. 461 (1921): 1–22.

[93] Simpkin, *Race to the Swift*. p 133; Vvital for the small force is to opt for battle sparsely. For more regarding the logic link between manoeuvre and Operational Art, in Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook*. p 24.

[94] Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 19; for more regarding agility in the operational sense, see Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution - A Prolegomena.* p 72, 120.

[95] See Ofra Graicer, 'Self Disruption: Seizing the High Ground of Systemic Operational Design (SOD)'. *Journal of Military and Strategic Studies* 17, no. 4 (2017). p 29.

[96] For more information, see Ofra Graicer's 'Between Teaching and Learning'. *EXPERTICIA MILITAR*, July-October (2017). p 26; see also Graicer, 'Self Disruption'. p 10.

[97] Operational harmony, see Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence.* p 21f; for more related to harmony, see also John R Boyd, *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*, ed. Grant T Hammond (Maxwell: Air University Press, 2018). p 9; Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution - A Prolegomena.* p 96f.

traditionalist (parochialist) atmosphere often present in military organisations and elaborates its negative effects on creative force employment. Therefore, mediation and exploitation of the middle ground, as opposed to conformity and rigid adherence to prevailing and traditionalist methods, constitute essential coordinates to be able to generate something new and avoid being surprised.[98] However, with this insight, it is also essential to acknowledge that, for some, Operational Art *is* exactly that- an art. Conversely, for others, it may reflect more of a scientific cause-and-effect (linear) formula, depicting how forces should be arranged or what constitutes a proper magnitude of forces when discussing Operational Art or level.[99] Regarding this thesis's problem, purpose, and primary audience, a perception based on the range of services included—or the size of forces employed—is more or less irrelevant. At the same time, the U.S. has adopted a more specific meaning of the notion of '*operational*' as connected to a particular geographic scope and command level.[100] That said, what remains essential and highly relevant from this thesis perspective is the non-repetitive employment of force enabled through smooth cooperation and orchestration of required means and measures, given a presumed total dominance of the strategic solution.[101]

A cognitive exercise for maximum revenue

Recurring in the debate is also an implicit focus on the cognitive dimensions of Operational Art. To learn from mistakes, mediate extreme views, and capitalise on emerging potential, one must rely not solely on brainpower instead of muscle power, but at least use it to enhance or compensate for limited physical strength relative to an adversary. Furthermore, if one lacks sufficient space or weight in steel, the desired effect becomes far more significant than the means and methods used to attain it. In that sense, the aim of Operational Art can be seen as denying the adversary harmony among its coordinating parts to encourage systemic collapse or paralysis, thus emphasising the core features of the systemic approach to Operational Art.[102]

In this context, it is worth noting that a recurring discussion exists on what constitutes proper targets and how desired outcomes should be pursued. In this discussion, the 'centre of gravity' notion assumes centre stage as the target- or the feature upon which the adversary's ability to fight relies. In this debate, different

[98] For more on the issue of parochialist militaries choking creativity, see Milan Vego, 'On Military Creativity', JFQ, no. 70 (2013).

[99] See Ibid; for more reasoning closely related to linearity, see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking.* p 7, 11, 163.

[100] In this regard, see Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare.* p 97f; see also Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 8f; and Simpkin, *Race to the Swift.* p 23f.

[101] Non-repetitive force employment, a key feature of Israeli Operational Art, as reflected in the latter three of the attached articles. See also Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook*. p 9.

[102] See Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence.* p 17.

perceptions of the notion represent different ideas of how to collapse the competing system.

> *'…there are two ways of taking down a building: "destroying each brick or destroying the foundation; it is a question of what […] to cause collapse […] to bring the system down."'*[103]

To understand the implied difference, Robert Leonhard explains: 'The enemy's center of gravity is not his source of strength; it is his critical vulnerability. […] There are those, including many in the U.S. Army, who cling to […] that the center of gravity is the enemy's source of strength'.[104] In light of the problem discussed in this thesis and the purpose of this review, it is reasonable to conclude that these perceptions vary depending on your available resources.

Therefore, for an actor lacking sufficient physical prerequisites, such as physical space or military hardware, a reasonable objective will be reflected in a favourable outcome by exploiting the critical vulnerabilities of the adversary. On the other hand, a significant actor can afford a direct engagement with its adversary's power sources, regardless of whether it involves a brick-by-brick, cause-and-effect, linear operation, *or* a nonlinear attack focused on ruining the foundation by depriving the adversary system of its operational harmony, by attacking the weak links that enable the system to function.[105] The latter may be the only feasible option for the primary audience of this thesis, considering the assumed limited physical resources available. However, to be effective, a comprehensive [iterative] mapping of the adversary's drivers, self-image, and operational incentives is necessary, as these are central elements of the Systemic Approach to Operational Art (SOD), further detailed in this thesis.[106] Thus, uncovering and leveraging connections in both adversary and friendly systems, one can either disrupt or enhance their harmony and functioning logic.[107] Drawing on Marc Jessup, it is reasonable to argue that SOD is a more refined version of MT; however, this thesis prefers to see them as interconnected companions, with MT representing the broader principle or philosophy of operation.[108] Meanwhile, SOD can assist in identifying the most effective targets or

[103] David E Johnson, *Hard Fighting: Israel in Lebanon and Gaza* (Santa Monica: RAND Corporation, 2011). p 33, 34.

[104] Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 20, 21; for more related to *center of gravity*, see Clausewitz, *On War*. p 486f; see also the concept of *schwerpunkt* as described by Lind in *Maneuver Warfare Handbook.* p 18; and elaborated by Boyd in *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 96.

[105] Brick-by-brick or the foundation, See Johnson, *Hard Fighting*. p 33f; see also Kings and Queens in Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 20ff.

[106] Systemic inquiry- mapping unchartered territories, see Graicer, 'Self Disruption'. p 36; see also cultural analysis in Adamsky, *The Culture of Military Innovation.* p 139f.

[107] SOD birth and characteristics, see Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement.* p 114ff; see also Adamsky, *The Culture of Military Innovation.* p 105f, 139f.

[108] For similar reasoning, see Jessup, 'Systems Competition'. p 56ff.

barriers to engage for optimal results, considering the given objective and available resources.

While SOD and MT are dynamic concepts especially suited for resource-effective exploitation of emerging opportunities in rapidly changing circumstances, it should be noted that SOD contrasts with and should not be confused with Effects-Based Operations (EBO/EBAO) or the Comprehensive Approach (CA), which are mainly centralised concepts aimed at synchronising extensive resources to achieve objective and measurable results.[109] While similarities exist, such as a focus on systems and the development of knowledge, the main feature that sets the latter apart from SOD is its more linear nature, characterised by extensive scientific and systematic planning regime.[110] At a glance, these operational concepts can appear very similar: '[EBAO] focuses on disrupting nodes and relationships, SOD attempts to transform the relationships and interactions between entities within a system'.[111] However, upon closer examination, the linear nature of EBAO, which concentrates on disrupting nodes and relationships (cause-and-effect), becomes clearer, as does the emphasis of SOD, which highlights transforming interactions, requiring a deep systemic understanding of *all* the actors within the system.

Returning to the diverse and often resource-intensive meaning of Operational Art, there are expressions more in tune with the central problem of this thesis, *the lack of physical prerequisites*. Vego elaborates: 'Operational art is the only means of orchestrating and tying together tactical actions within a larger design that directly contributes to the objectives set by policy and strategy. […] Generally, the smaller the one's forces, the more critical is to properly apply operational art'.[112]

Going further emphasises the logical link between Operational Art and Manoeuvre warfare: here, Willam Lind explains:

> *'Why is the operational art important if you are to do maneuvre warfare? Because it is through excellence in the operational art more than through maneuvre in tactical battle […] that a smaller force can defeat a larger one'.*[113]

[109] EBAO and CA, tools of the alliance: '…both EBAO and CA aim to strengthen the effectiveness and efficiency of NATO's planning and conduct of crisis management operations through the greater consonance or "joining up" of military and civilian efforts, both within the Alliance and in its relations with outside actors'. See Brooke Smith-Windsor, 'Hasten Slowly: NATO's Effects Based and Comprehensive Approach to Operations', *Nato Research Paper*, no. 38 (2008). p 1.

[110] See Ibid; see also Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 145f.

[111] See Milan Vego, 'A Case Against Systemic Operational Design', *JFQ*, no. 53 (2009). p 73.

[112] Milan Vego, 'On Operational Art', Strategos 2, no. 1 (2017). p 35.

[113] Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook*. p 24; in this regard see also Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution - A Prolegomena.* p 33.

However, in the same context, the matter is referred to as 'the art of winning campaigns'.[114] Obviously, the searched-for multiplier resides in there, although implicitly. On the other hand, yet another ambivalent and implicit dedication to massive formations, especially manifested through the notion of 'campaigns'.

Summary on Operational Art - the bridge to theory

This brief review of previous research and understandings of Operational Art shows that many perceptions are closely linked to conceptual linearity and the management of large physical assets across extensive geographical regions, at least implicitly. Nevertheless, common themes and valuable insights emerge that bolster this thesis's nonlinear pursuit, such as *small investments yielding significant returns, potential, amplifying small masses or existing forces, establishing or preventing harmony and cooperation,* etc.

Such viewpoints not only inspire hope for the physically less fortunate, who are the primary audience of this thesis, but also serve as operational superlatives of great value when addressing its core issue—namely, a shortage of physical Depth that impairs effective competition with an adversary, especially through defensive manoeuvring. These notions are more aligned with the Luttwakian view, which refers to 'a higher combination that is more than the sum of its tactical parts […] [a] struggle between the directing minds on both sides […] [at] the level at which overall methods of war are applied'.[115]

A closer look at this message reveals a perspective that distinctly aligns with the dual-sided understanding of Depth discussed in this thesis. It functions both as a result, in relation to an adversary or potential threats, and as an analytical viewpoint that promotes perspectives beyond traditional and predictable frameworks, fostering metacognition and transforming one's thinking process.[116] This type of transformation involves a more nonlinear, cognitive approach, an exercise aimed at utilising available resources more effectively. It serves as an indirect method that can be used by those experiencing Depth shortages, as shown through the case study in this thesis. These features not only fit well with the specifics of the selected case, confirming its relevance, but also align with the theoretical foundations used for concept development, thereby confirming their suitability.

[114] Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook*. p 24.

[115] Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 112f.

[116] See Gracier, 'Beware of the Power of the Dark side', EXPERTICIA MILITAR July-Octob (2017): p 34; see also Dan Öberg, 'Warfare as Design: Transgressive Creativity and Reductive Operational Planning', Security Dialogue 49, no. 6 (December 2018): 493–509.

Returning to the beginning of this section, neither the aim of this thesis nor the theory to be elaborated in the next chapter intends to fit the operational reality into a prearranged, sequential (linear) framework, as implicitly suggested in several ideas discussed above. Instead, it emphasises anticipation and dynamic leveraging of opportunities that emerge, embodying a nonlinear approach.[117] By doing so, it implicitly questions several perspectives on Operational Art presented in this section. With this perspective in mind, we can now examine Operational Art through the lens of Depth.

Measures- perceptions and approaches to Depth

This subsection focuses on Depth and examines how previous research interprets the topic by outlining different pathways. Doing so shows that studies on Depth often prefer linear and resource-heavy perspectives, which are suitable for organisations with extensive geographical and military resources. However, given the issue at hand, this thesis argues that resource availability is only meaningful in context, that is, in relation to an aggressor or a coalition of aggressors.[118] Keeping this in consideration, let us begin by revisiting Napoleon from two centuries ago.

From Confined locales and Width to Depth and Massive formations

The shift towards emphasising space gained momentum during Napoleon's campaigns with his *Grande Armée*. Instead of limited wars characterised by rigid formations, mobility took precedence. Engberg-Pedersen notes: '"Large-scale warfare" or *[Les] grandes opérations [became]* the central elements in the new spatial order'.[119] Furthermore, these developments also transformed the character of warfare from confined locations marked by fortifications and their immediate surroundings to a focus on the natural terrain and its capacity to support or hinder military objectives. The physical space is described here as a form of currency, demanding careful analysis and potential utilisation to favour tactical and strategic enterprises.[120] In essence, this refers to available Depth and how we should utilise it: '…whether it is to serve me only as an arena and medium of movement, or as a defensive weapon against the crush of the enemy, as a hideout and disguise of my weaknesses and dispositions, or whether I need it primarily as a source of energy

[117] '…construct a comprehensive explanation of the complex emergence or *becoming…'* see Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution - A Prolegomena.* p 84. For more related to SOD vs. military planning and linearity, see Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement.* p 122ff; see also Matthew Lauder, 'Systemic Operational Design: Freeing Operational Planning from the Shackles of Linearity', *Canadian Military Journal* 9, no. 4 (2009). p 43ff; for more related reasoning regarding linearity vs. design thinking, see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 7, 82f, 118f, 161ff.

[118] For closely related reasoning regarding time in relation to the opponent, see Boyd, *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 97, 196f.

[119] Anders Engberg-Pedersen, *Empire of Chance: The Napoleonic Wars and the Disorder of Things* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2015). p 43.

[120] Engberg-Pedersen, *Empire of Chance.* p 45.

and recuperation, as the basis of my physical and economico- military existence"'.[121] Ultimately, this development signifies a major shift in which large areas of land were actively utilised, effectively transforming it into an activity mainly for resourceful military actors.

Many lessons can indeed be learnt from Napoleon's military operations. However, this thesis emphasises one particular insight expressed by John Boyd: He describes it as the 'shifting kaleidoscope'. This phrase illustrates Napoleon's continual adjustments in his use of diversions and manoeuvres, designed to cognitively disrupt the enemy's plans and keep them off balance.[122] Essentially, a nonlinear character trait centred on emergence and adaptation.

A century later, Soviet soldier-scholar Isserson explains how the frontage presented by Napoleon had become so broad that the flanks could no longer be turned. The front had become continuous, and attrition reigned.[123] Eventually, the lateral strategy was phased out, and it was recognised that an offensive focus deep within the enemy formation distinctly sets modern operations apart from their conservative predecessors.[124] Emphasising this linear and resource-intensive modus, applicable to major actors, Isserson elaborates:

> *'A modern operation is an operation in depth. It must be planned for the entire depth, and it must be prepared to overcome the entire depth. Moreover, it must be anticipated that the intensity of the resistance within this depth tends to increase and grow denser from front to rear'.*
> *125*

Christopher Tuck presents a related recipe for Depth from a Soviet Cold War perspective, emphasising air attacks and the swift manoeuvring of reserves deep into enemy territory, ensuring that tactical successes lead to decisive victory.[126] This focus on Depth's importance in modern operations underscores its crucial role in military strategy and Operational Art. Heavily influenced by the Soviet Deep Operations concept outlined earlier, the American AirLand Battle (ALB) doctrine developed as a strong response. In this context, Antulio Echevarria explains that the essence of Operational Art is essentially perceived as the 'identification of the

[121] Ibid.
[122] Boyd, *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 51.
[123] Isserson, *The Evolution of Operational Art*. p *ix, xv*.
[124] Ibid. p 38, 43, 48
[125] Ibid. p 55.
[126] See Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare*. p 98.

enemy's operational center of gravity and the concentration of superior combat power against that point to achieve decisive success'.[127]

As the operational concept employed during Operation Desert Storm against Saddam Hussein's Iraq, ALB is not merely a tangible example of a highly resource-intensive Depth concept; it also serves as a baseplate for succeeding effects-based concepts.[128] It further demonstrates an effective and practical illustration of the gaps and challenges addressed in this thesis — specifically, a research focus and perception of Depth mainly suitable for major actors with extensive geography and resources.

Depth in Temporal terms

This brief introduction highlights how prevailing interpretations and contemporary research on Depth (and Operational Art) are significantly shaped by linearity and physical dimensions.[129] However, Depth can also be viewed through a temporal lens, either directly or indirectly. In doing so, Robert Leonhard points out that military success can hinge on 'hours', even in the face of spatial constraints.[130] The temporal aspect of Depth is often implicitly analysed, particularly through the concepts of quick decision-making and actor resilience, both essential for maintaining momentum and preventing culmination.[131] Regarding culmination, Vego suggests: 'If the defender is not decisively beaten, he may retain sufficient space to withstand the enemy's attack until the attacking force reaches its culmination point'.[132]

A more detailed analysis uncovers additional, interconnected perspectives on inferiority related to resources (and, consequently, Depth). In this context, Colin Gray indicates that an opponent with a material disadvantage will probably try to win by lasting longer than their adversary. Essentially, this entails securing victory by avoiding defeat.[133] However, it is crucial to recognise that trading space for time is generally not an effective 'Depth approach' for smaller nations defending themselves.[134] This approach is generally more suitable for larger organisations, as Menning will discuss later. A closer examination and a deeper understanding of the

[127] Antulio J Echevarria II, 'American Strategic Culture: Problems and Prospects', in *The Changing Character of War*, ed. Hew Strachan and Sibylle Scheipers (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011). p 441.

[128] See related reasoning in Ibid.

[129] The relationship between offensive action and protection- movement forwards and backwards. See Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 82.

[130] 'From Thermopylae to Kuwait, the "Hours" have decided military victory, often in defiance of spatial conditions' see Leonhard, *Fighting by Minutes*. p 2.

[131] The relationship between mind/time/space arena; to manoeuvre more swiftly than the adversary represents an implicit but tangible reflection of temporal Depth, see Boyd, *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 9; and Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook*. p 5f; see also Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 85f, 92, 132, 136, 179f, 319; to plan and execute faster than the adversary, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 16; see also Simpkin, *Race to the Swift*. p 93-104, 183f; and Lonsdale, *The Nature of War in the Information Age*. p 6f.

[132] Another aspect concerns the trade of space for time, although a method generally not favourable for a small nation conducting defensive operations, see Vego, *Joint Operational Warfare.* p III-52—III-60

[133] Gray, 'Irregular Warfare: One Nature, Many Characters'. p 45.

[134] Again, see Vego, *Joint Operational Warfare.* p III-52—III-60; in this regard, see also how the value of time relative to reach and physical territory decreases and slowly loses relevance in Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View*. p 112ff.

temporal aspect reveal the concept of 'time flanks', offering an additional valuable perspective for those with limited physical resources. Leonhard clarifies the reasoning behind this and explains how these elements can be leveraged:

> *'An army's lines extend only so far to the right and left. It has a certain finite depth as well. But an army also has temporal limits that define its influence: an army is not always strong. There is a period of time before the army is ready to fight, and there is a period of time after it is no longer ready to fight. These boundaries in time represents the army's "time flanks."'*[135]

Although this perspective does not offer a magical solution to improve an actor's Depth despite physical limitations, it provides a mental shift: a way of thinking that can be advantageous when evaluating the use of limited resources or assessing strategy in their absence.

Furthermore, additional aspects must be considered regarding the temporal dimensions of Depth. A key element that arises in this context is *early warning*, as discussed by Van Creveld in relation to Israel, or through *detection*, as elaborated by Leonhard. Therefore, employing advanced technical solutions can greatly reduce the constraints imposed by limited physical space.[136] Essentially, when physical buffers are obsolete, effective early warning can stand in and strengthen the time flanks and ensure readiness to face emerging threats.

Conversely, identifying a temporal strategy for a dichotomous actor with substantial geographical and military assets is simple. Bruce Menning demonstrates, through a resource-heavy Soviet perspective from the early 20th century, how Depth can be used by trading extensive territories for time. In doing so, he shows how the Russians could adopt a Scythian strategy, utilising national resources and Depth to withstand their opponent: '"Time is the best ally of our armed forces…"'[137] This approach emphasises significant physical assets and represents research related to Depth that is primarily, though not solely, accessible to major powers.[138] Thus, it serves as a concrete example of the gap this thesis aims to address.

[135] Leonhard, *Fighting by Minutes.* p 8; see also preemptive withdrawal a defensive reflection on the issue, in House, *Combined Arms Warfare in the Twentieth Century*. p 163.

[136] For closely related reasoning, see Van Creveld, *The Sword and the Olive.* p 251, 322; see also Robert R Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age* (Novato, CA: Presidio Press, 1998). p 71f.

[137] Scythian tactics, a type of defence in depth combined with repeated counterattacks and withdrawals, see Menning, 'The Imperial Russian Legacy of Operational Art, 1878-1914'. p 203ff.

[138] An exemption to the rule, for example, the Winter War fought by Finland against Soviet aggression.

Depth in Cognitive terms

On rare occasions, at least in explicit terms, the cognitive aspect of Depth is explored. Jerrid Allen's 'Cognitive Depth and Hybrid Warfare' serves as an important example.[139] Moreover, while Depth and physical space are losing relevance due to the far-reaching capabilities of modern weaponry,[140] physical dispersion and Depth gain significance when viewed through a cognitive lens. Steven Biddle elaborates on its implications:

> *'Depth, for example, disperses troops, like dispersion on the attack, this complicates command and control, increases burdens on junior leaders, and challenges morale among troops who may feel dangerously isolated'.*[141]

An additional emerging effect related to the expanding battlefield and increasingly dispersed formations is the difficulty in locating tangible formations to engage when they remain hidden to avoid the lethal firepower of the adversary.[142] In this regard, Bill Owens provides a near-contemporary example illustrating the *frustrating effect* of remaining hidden and intangible for engagement: the Serbian forces' ability to endure hostile bombardment for 78 days during NATO Operation Allied Force. The desired effect was only achieved when a primitive ground force was used as a complement, making the Serbians tangible after being forced out of hiding.[143]

While focusing on the problem addressed by this thesis, it remains essential to consider the physical perspective of Depth. Many existing approaches and concepts are not accessible to the primary audience, especially those lacking the necessary physical resources to engage effectively with the adversary. However, a solid understanding of this field reveals pathways available to the adversary and ensures mastery of a functional logic that may have broader applications. With this entry point into the main subject, let us continue exploring previous research and the key

[139] A rare exception where cognitive depth is approached more explicitly, see Jerrid Allen, 'Cognitive Depth and Hybrid Warfare' (Fort Leavenworth, 2017); for more see Udi Dekel and Lia Moran-Gilad, 'Cognition: Combining Soft Power and Hard Power', in *The Cognitive Campaign: Strategic and Intelligence Perspectives*, ed. Yossi Kuperwasser and David Siman-Tov (Tel Aviv: The Institute for National Security Studies, INSS, 2019), 151–164.

[140] Distance becomes less relevant from the depth perspective due to the reach of modern militaries. See Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View*. p 117; and concerning the global reach of auxiliary measures and the subsequent declining importance of geography, see Lonsdale, *The Nature of War in the Information Age*. p 183.

[141] A cognitive consequence of depth and dispersion as discussed in Stephen Biddle's *Military Power*. p 48; for similar reasoning, see Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age.* p 113; and regarding the fear of being cut off, see Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare*. p 86.

[142] Growing battlefields and invisibility, see Menning, 'Operational Art's Origins'. p 5.

[143] For a profound elaboration on the subject, see Owens, *Lifting the Fog of War*. p 178-194.

directions it encompasses, establishing a framework for discussion while highlighting the relevance of this thesis.[144]

However, before we explore previous research specifically related to Depth, let us briefly consider momentum and culmination, a conceptual dichotomy of central importance to the wider context of Operational Art and, in particular, the specific topic of Depth.[145] Because many cognitive approaches to Depth hinge on timing, decision-making, and the resilience of systems, it is logical to examine the related concepts of momentum and culmination next — both are as much cognitive problems as physical ones.

Momentum and Culmination

Closely linked to the enduring relationship between offence and defence – or action and reaction – this dichotomy has significant relevance for research and practice related to Operational Art and Depth. A key aspect supporting the rationale behind this duality is the Clausewitzian belief that defence is a more effective form of warfare compared to offence. The Prussian explains: '…defense is simply the stronger form of war […] [but] the defense will be able to reap the benefits of the stronger form of war only if it is willing to be satisfied with [a] more modest goal'.[146] Conversely, he adds that during an attack, each move forward diminishes the strength of the attacker,[147] and somewhere along the road, Luttwak argues, lies the point of culmination beyond which strength fades faster than it can be replaced.[148] Therefore, as Biddle suggests, there is always a risk, because an attack in depth can become a denial of oneself, as the benefits will steadily decline over time.[149] What we discuss here is the attacker's momentum, a feature closely related to Depth. Viewed through a linear and resource-focused lens, although elaborated with a somewhat technical language, it can be understood as:

> '…momentum, which varies with tempo for a force of constant mass, represents resistance to change in speed or direction and thus the ability to gain **depth'**.[150]

[144] In the first article of this compilation, five main trajectories are presented, effectively augmenting this review. See Anders Ekholm, 'Re-Thinking Operational Depth- a Source of Power', Comparative Strategy 40, no. 4 (2021): 387–406.

[145] Relative to momentum and culmination, see offence and defence as mirror images in Simpkin's *Race to the Swift*. p 99.

[146] Clausewitz, On War. p 380.

[147] The Diminishing force of the attack, see Clausewitz, *On War*. p 527f.

[148] See Culmination and Reversal, in Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 20-28.

[149] See Biddle, *Military Power*. p 47.

[150] Simpkin, *Race to the Swift*. p 114. (emphasis in original).

These insights pose challenges for an actor with limited physical resources, which is the primary audience of this thesis. Nonetheless, this understanding might provide insights into effective strategies for dislocating a physically stronger opponent.[151]

Furthermore, it is traditionally believed that focusing on mass compensates for limited mobility and insufficient speed to manoeuvre 'around the enemy's flank'. Conversely, it is suggested that there is a point where a significant advantage in mobility or speed over the opponent reduces the need for mass.[152] Steven Biddle explains, while almost echoing Clausewitz:

'As attackers advance into depth, however, formations begin to break down; units move onto unfamiliar, unscouted terrain; contact with supporting artillery tends to loosen…'[153]

He refers to this phenomenon as the entropic effect of Depth, which ultimately enables the defenders' reserve formations to halt the attack.[154] Furthermore, when discussing the implications of velocity and force magnitude, there is a perspective that describes how small, fast, and lethal formations—relying on precision and speed rather than mass—can turn the flanks of the future. This potential offers an optimistic outlook for future military strategies, demonstrating that effective tactics can be employed even with limited resources.[155]

Regardless of perception, momentum and culmination embody duality and an interconnected logic that must be understood and positioned within the specific context of a study or operational estimate, independent of character. Ultimately, grasping the significance of this duality requires contextual awareness, whether one perceives oneself as an operator striving to fit reality into a predefined [linear] framework or as an anticipating operator seeking opportunities in a reality characterised by constant change [nonlinear].[156]

This concise yet insightful examination of the concepts of momentum and culmination uncovers a consistent physical and linear pattern, highlighting a gap in previous research that this thesis seeks to address. Such understanding allows us better to navigate the complexities of military operations with greater insight.

[151] The logic of dislocation, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 66-76; for more about dislocation, see Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age.* p 61-65; Leonhard, *Fighting by Minutes.* p 57; and Liddell Hart, *Strategy.* p 326f.

[152] See Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age.* p 107f.

[153] Biddle, *Military Power.* p 47.

[154] The Entropic effect of depth, see Biddle, *Military Power*. p 47.

[155] To turn the [Time-flanks]; see Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age*. p 109.

[156] Linear- non-linear, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 189f, 192; for additional, related reasoning, see Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead*. p 27.

Armed with these perspectives of critical value to Operational Art *and Depth*, let us decrease the abstraction level further and continue the review.

Depth in greater depth

In this subsection, we revisit the explicit topic of Depth after discussing the closely related concepts of momentum and culmination. This involves exploring existing research more deeply while continuing to highlight previous studies focused on physical factors such as extensive geographical areas and access to substantial military resources concerning an opponent or a coalition of them. Conversely, while addressing this challenging research landscape, efforts are made to identify methods that may be accessible to the typical audience for this thesis. However, it is important to note that this state of research presents challenges not only for actors with less physical advantage but also signifies an evolution relevant to those possessing significant Depth. Hence, the expanding range of modern weaponry and countermeasures drives this evolution for medium and major powers, as well as their contemporary adversaries, who often possess the capability to strike at the entire friendly formation.[157] Consequently, as Luttwak and others suggest, the differences between Forward and Rearward— referring to physical areas, distances, and defensive buffers— are becoming less significant, though not completely irrelevant.[158]

However, the difference remains striking when compared to Soviet military science, where, as Sakvin explains, space, alongside time and speed, was regarded as a supplementary force.[159] This development in military science highlights the shifting terrain and the necessity for adaptable strategies. That said, let us continue to examine the issue of Depth:

In the first article included in this thesis, 'Re-thinking Operational Depth', a more accessible review of current research on Depth is presented, formatted within the constraints of a research article. It outlines five primary trajectories that dominate the research field: Forward and Rearward Depth, Opportunity and Denial, Movement and Momentum in harmony, Depth through Deep Operations and Forward defence, resources and momentum. Additionally, it highlights a common flaw noted in previous research, which this thesis aims to address from a broader perspective: the excessive focus on geographical and physical concepts that require extensive resources, making them unattainable for actors who do not possess these assets in sufficient quantities. In this subsection, building on the previous points, we

[157] For a near real-time example, see Graham Scarbro, 'Iran-Israel Conflict: A Quicklook Analysis of Operation Rising Lion', *U.S. Naval Institute Proceedings* Vol. 151/6, no. June (2025).

[158] See Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 158f; see Adamsky, 'Through the Looking Glass'; and Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View*. p 115ff.

[159] In this regard, see Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View*. p 119.

undertake a more thorough and comprehensive review than is possible in the aforementioned article.

Forward – Rearward, Offence and Defence

Revisiting the opening words of this thesis, we turn our attention back to de Jomini:

> 'The theater of operations of an army embraces all the territory it may desire to invade and all that it may be necessary to defend'.[160]

Emerging from an era when an operational level had yet to be defined, this linear representation provides valuable insight into the enduring relationship between offence and defence, as well as forward and rearward, that dominates research related to Depth.[161]

It also hints at how interactions among various areas in the operational theatre can reveal insights about the nature of an ongoing operation; Shimon Naveh explains: '…the quantitative relationship between front and depth indicates whether the nature of the operational deployment is offensive or defensive'.[162] Drawing on Van Creveld, uncovering this relationship will indicate whether a practical need for physical features to support, or even multiply available strength effectively, is required.[163]

Soviet soldier-scholar Sakvin discusses the topic from a Soviet perspective, arguing that effectively leveraging territorial size and operational distance, alongside time and speed, can serve as a factor that enhances force.[164] While his argument addresses the opposing view typical of the actor discussed in this thesis, King Leonidas I and his 300 Spartans offer a perspective that more closely aligns with the primary audience, despite its antiquated origins. Therefore, the Spartan King and his men skilfully utilised the limited terrain available to them, preventing the Persian attacking force from effectively deploying its full strength.[165] This historical example underscores the essence of Depth: the ability to compensate for a lack of mass with intelligent use of terrain. This naturally leads us to the Forward–Rearward understanding of Depth, which formalises this idea within a broader operational framework.

[160] Jomini, *The Art of War.* p 75.

[161] Forward- rearward, see Benjamin M Maher, 'The Origins of Operational Depth in the First World War' (Fort Leavenworth, Kansas, 2016); for more related to this interplay, see Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare*. p 95; Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age.* p 80ff; and Luttwak, *Strategy.* p 147-157.

[162] Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence.* p 17; for closely related reasoning, see Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead.* p 53.

[163] Manoeuvre warfare, gaps and making the most of natural obstacles; see Van Creveld, *Airpower and Maneuver Warfare.* p 8ff.

[164] Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View*. p 119.

[165] See Fuller, *De Avgörande Slagen [The Decisive Battles of the Western World].* p 57-67; and Paul Cartledge, *Sparta- En Odödlig Historia [an Immortal History]*, ed. Per Nyqvist (Stockholm: Santérus Förlag, 2012); for more regarding implications of the terrain and topography during large operations, see Engberg-Pedersen, *Empire of Chance.* p 32ff, 44f.

The Forward-Rearward [linear] understanding of Depth refers to a perception recurring in previous research related to Depth, and so also in this thesis.[166] It covers several aspects: primarily, it offers an easily comprehensible perception of Depth that is logically linked to the duality of conquering and defending. The forward side is something exploited at the opponent's expense (conquer), while the rearward side is exploited and enjoyed at your own expense (defend).[167]

In examining the connection between these imagined spheres of the operational theatre, momentum and culmination clearly draw attention based on the ideas described earlier. Furthermore, when doing so, we often encounter the Deep Operation and, conversely, Defence in Depth.[168] Richard Simpkin describes them as two arcs on a continuum rather than opposites.[169] As explained by Christopher Tuck, the Deep Operation emerged during the latter part of the First World War as a means to disrupt the enemy's ability to bring fresh reinforcements to the front, while subsequent applications sought to create shock and disorder.[170] Conversely, he contends that defence in depth originated a few years earlier as a German [dispersing] strategy aimed at becoming less vulnerable to the overwhelming firepower of the enemy's artillery attacks.[171]

Besides the Forward/Rearward, linear, and resource-intensive approach, Charles Crow suggests that opportunity and denial can provide an alternative perspective to clarify the linear link between tactical and operational depth. He argues:

> *'…when the attacker crosses the threshold between tactical and operational depth, a decision point has been reached. The attacker must decide how to respond to the opportunity presented to him, while the defender must adequately respond or face total destruction'.*[172]

Though still positioned within a clearly linear framework, this duality seems more abstract than its Forward/Rearward counterpart. Consequently, it is expected that this conceptual pair will attract a larger audience, including those without the Depth required for defensive manoeuvring. Thus, the simple vocabulary used invites a

[166] For closely related reasoning, see Maher, 'The Origins of Operational Depth in the First World War'. p 67ff; for more information on the forward/ rearward division, see Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 284.

[167] Offense- Defence, Conquer- Defend, see de Jomini, *The Art of War.* p 75; see also Biddle, *Military Power.* p 195; and Clausewitz, *On War*. p 105, 363, 357ff, 365, 379f, 390f.

[168] See Wilson Blythe Jr, 'The Conduct of War; Re-Emergence of Russian Military Strength Warrants Study of Soviet Operational Theory in the Interwar Era', The Officer 91, no. 1 (2015). p 67f; more on deep operations and exploitation of success from the same context, see Soviet Field Regulation of 1944 as described by David Glantz in *Soviet Military Operational Art*. p 29ff.

[169] The interplay between offence and defence elaborated in the context of the Cold War with resource-intensive Soviet and Nato concepts. See Simpkin, *Race to the Swift*. p 99.

[170] Infiltration Tactics and Depth in Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare.* p 72, 85f.

[171] Emergence of Defence in depth, see Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare*. p 68f.

[172] Crow, 'Tactical and Operational Depth'. *Abstract.*

broader range of expressions and innovative ideas that can expand or bypass the binary of the operational theatre, which is problematic when resources are limited.

Depth- in pursuit of Cognitive effects

From the perspective of the interaction between offensive and defensive ideas, the Forward/Rearward approach is easy to understand, and its logic can be smoothly incorporated into analysis, doctrine, or operational planning. However, the division has additional layers; the importance of the home turf is one of them. Robert Pape explains: '…the defender's homeland territory is normally much more valuable to him than to any assailant […] Since targets of coercion are normally willing to accept higher costs and risks than are coercers, potential assailants are likely to be deterred from even attempting coercion unless they possess superior military capabilities, which can protect them from the victim's retaliation'.[173] This strategic insight, when applied to the problem at hand, suggests the existence of a potential Depth multiplier in favour of the defending party,[174] pending the fact that sufficient space is available to conduct an effective defence in depth in the first place.

While illustrating the relationship between offence and defence, Deep Operation and, conversely, Defence in Depth represent broad Depth-building activities, not only physically but also cognitively. First, let us examine their potential cognitive effects on enemy decision-making and then move on to explore practical implications for disrupting and dislocating enemy systems. For example, as previously articulated by Van Creveld, operating and appearing deep within the enemy's disposition offers the defender a frightening experience.[175] Moving further in the same direction, we encounter Liddell Hart arguing that an attack 'close to the rear of the opposing army has more effect on the minds of the enemy troops, a stroke farther back tends to have more effect on the mind of the enemy commander...'[176] Drawing on these statements alongside an elaboration by Luttwak, we find that the deep operation and the forward defence concept may be depth-producing methods practical for less fortunate actors in terms of available geography and sufficient hardware, provided the right context exists. Conversely, 'Defence in depth' or 'elastic defence' is not.[177]

[173] Robert A Pape, 'Coercion and Military Strategy: Why Denial Works and Punishment Doesn't', *The Journal of Strategic Studies* 15, no. 4 (1992). p 427.

[174] In this regard, see Martin Van Creveld, *More On War* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017). p 20.

[175] For closely related reasoning, see Van Creveld, *Airpower and Maneuver Warfare*. p 18f.

[176] Danchev, 'Liddell Hart and Manoeuvre'. p 34; see also Liddell Hart, *Strategy*. p 331.

[177] See Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 158ff.

However, unlike Cold War West Germany or Israel,[178] if the necessary territory is available (which is crucial to note since it does not apply to the primary audience of this thesis), a defence-in-depth strategy might be effective. Operationally, this may involve giving up ground to buy time, pushing the adversary toward their limit (culmination), or engaging them on broader flanks while coordinating counterattacks.[179] Conversely, the Deep Operation may serve various purposes. One of these, as Naveh argues, is to disrupt key nodes in the adversary's system, potentially causing paralysis or the destruction of operational harmony.[180] In this regard, John Boyd argues coherently:

'Disrupt the connections and centers that provide cohesion [...] thus severing the link between his brain and limbs'".[181]

More ambitious employments may strive for complete encirclement, destruction and defeat throughout his Depth,[182] while less ambitious objectives may constitute an attempted disorganisation of the adversary's rear- its momentum-providing *power base*.[183] In the same context, we encounter what Luttwak calls 'Interdiction as a substitute for Depth'.[184] Essentially, engaging the adversary's resources in the rear with long-range weapons, pending their availability.[185] When carefully executed with cleverly chosen targets, the effects of such operations can potentially disrupt the adversary's fighting system or even dislocate it. Even this 'less ambitious' approach can serve as a powerful means of creating Depth by hampering the ability to manoeuvre resources, bolster defences, or mount counterattacks.[186] An alternative purpose could resemble the bite-and-hold style operation, where a lack

[178] During the Cold War, the West German government considered defence in depth to be a non-acceptable concept. See Luttwak, *Strategy.* p 151; see also Operational Depth and Complexity in Biddle, *Military Power.* p 49, 192.

[179] Exhaust yourself while walking the unknown ground; see the reasoning in Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 142f, 163; see also the relationship between space and time elaborated by Vego, *Joint Operational Warfare.* p III-57ff; Defence in Depth and preparations for counterattacks, see Biddle, *Military Power.* p 69ff; see also territorial self-defence in Hew Strachan, 'Conventional Defence in Europe', International Affairs 61, no. 1 (January 1985). p 29f.

[180] Operational harmony, see Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence*. p 17f, 19, 218f.

[181] Boyd, *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 118.

[182] Expected effects by breaking the front into the operational depth of the adversary. Referring to Soviet Operational Art during WW2, see Isserson in *War of the Future*. p 217f; and David M Glantz, *The Soviet Conduct of Tactical Maneuver: Spearhead of the Offensive* (Abingdon: Frank Cass and Company Limited, 1991). p 14, 31ff;

[183] See House, *Combined Arms Warfare in the Twentieth Century*. p 53ff; see also Biddle, *Military Power.* p 40f, 62.

[184] Luttwak, *Strategy.* p 160..

[185] Ibid. p 148f, 160ff; for an elaboration on similar means [stand-off], see Rodman, *Combined Arms Warfare in Israeli Military History.* p 74f.

[186] Luttwak, *Strategy.* p 158-162; see also Biddle, *Military Power*. p 40f; or to pre-empt enemy defence, see House, *Combined Arms Warfare in the Twentieth Century*. p 242.

of physical Depth compels the actor in question to generate Depth by capturing territory from the adversary.[187]

Segmentation of the Operational Theatre

The Forward/Rearward division of Depth also acts as an analytical segmentation of the operational theatre into offensive and defensive areas, potentially conveying purpose or ambition. Besides serving as an analytical tool, it functions as a cognitive measure, indicating the direction of projected energy — that is, where it originates from and what requires protection.

Emerging from World War I, this understanding of Depth materialised by synchronising the penetration of enemy lines with areas categorised as forward and rearward Depth.[188] Expanding on this reasoning, Maher explains how the broader idea of Operational Depth and its clear aims of projecting Depth forward require a Rearward Depth to maintain momentum.[189] A strong Rearward Depth during this period entailed significant logistical support for ammunition and reserves in strategic locations, facilitating the advancement of the second phase of Depth, the forward dimension.[190] Building on this historical perspective, scholars have since developed additional frameworks to conceptualise and categorise operational space, allowing for a more detailed analysis of Depth beyond simple forward and rearward divisions.

Further investigation of prior research uncovers more methods for categorising physical theatre and its analytical aspects related to Depth. Referencing Graham Williams, one way to do this is by using the Contiguous/Non-Contiguous labels. To clarify these labels, we can focus on physical Depth: simply put, contiguous Depth refers to the area bordering what someone perceives as their territory or operational space. In linear terms, this translates to either 'in front of' or 'behind'. Conversely, the non-contiguous Depth lies beyond, in adjacent areas, [191] thus representing either a Depth onto which one projects something (hostile) or a Depth that absorbs or consolidates strength (for instance, an allied, non-adjacent state). These two perceptions add several layers of complexity, including bilateral relations, issues of territorial integrity, and more abstract aspects like deniability.

[187] Capturing territory from an Israeli perspective, see Finkel, 'The Occupation of Territory in War'; Bite-and-hold, see Biddle, *Military Power*. p 42; for more related reasoning, see Avi Kober, 'The Rise and Fall of Israeli Operational Art, 1948-2008', in *The Evolution of Operational Art: From Napoleon to the Present*, ed. John Andreas Olsen and Martin Van Creveld (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011). p 169f; for more related to Bit-and-Hold, see Van Creveld, *The Sword and the Olive*. p 253; see also the acquisition of geographical bargaining chips in Levite, *Offence and Defense in Israeli Military Doctrine* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1989). p 91f.

[188] See Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 284; and Maher, 'The Origins of Operational Depth in the First World War'. p 67f.

[189] Maher, 'The Origins of Operational Depth in the First World War'. p 67.

[190] Maher, 'The Origins of Operational Depth in the First World War'. p 67; for similar reasoning related to the Second World War, see Culmination and Reversal in Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 20ff.

[191] See Graham Williams, 'Striking the Balance between Contiguous and Noncontiguous Areas of Operation at the Division and Corps Levels', *MILITARY REVIEW*, November-December (2021): 104–111.

In U.S. operational concepts, as Thomas Mirto and others explain, another physical (linear) division can be observed in the ideas of Rear, Close, Deep, Support, and Consolidation. These concepts are used to make a clear conceptual and analytical distinction when addressing the problem at hand.[192] In 2005, similar notions were clarified in NATO doctrine as terms intended to mark the physical location, while the purpose of operations, Jim Storr explains, should be described as *sustaining, shaping,* or *decisive*. [193] Similar to the basic Forward/Rearward- or Contiguous/Non-Contiguous labels, the Rear, Close, Deep, Support and Consolidation divisions can be relevant not only for practically partitioning the physical theatre related to operations but also as a cognitive tool during operational planning or design.

In Israel, we find another way of dividing the theatre, essentially constituting a merger between geographic location (proximity to civilian centres) and the level of threat. Using the 'three circles', Andrea Grillo explains the contemporary perception: The First circle includes terrorist threats, which means threats from armed individuals or groups conducting attacks within Israel. Although the threat from neighbouring states has diminished, the Second circle now encompasses armed non-state (terrorist) entities such as Hamas, Hezbollah, Houthis, and Islamic Jihad—organisations that pose a significant risk to the security of Israeli inhabitants. The Third circle involves non-contiguous areas, like those described above, mainly those that do not border, meaning countries or adversaries like Iran and Iraq. Here, it should be noted that Iran's alleged ambitions to develop nuclear weapons, its ballistic missile arsenal pointed at Israel, and its effort to arm proxies threatening Israel have made it the natural focus and representative of the Third circle.[194]

Further examination of existing research uncovers other physically oriented, though less linear, perspectives on Depth-sustaining activities that may involve a struggle conducted successfully without rigid formations, provided that some defensive territory can be utilised. If so, territorial defence and awareness of the terrain can be leveraged as an opportunity to facilitate dispersion and a nonlinear modus operandi, i.e., while drawing on Naveh, an operational framework *without fronts or rears*.[195] Further elucidating the logic of this operational modus, Strachan explains: 'The whole country becomes a hedgehog, its prickles individually no more than pinpricks, but cumulatively presenting an all-round defence against any assailant'.[196] In other words, as explained by Luttwak, under suitable conditions, small units dedicated to point defence, spread across as many vulnerable targets as possible, can form an

[192] Thomas Mirto, 'Army Operational Framework, Organizing the Force for Battlefield Success', U.S. Army, Center for Army Lessons Learned, 2019. https://usacac.army.mil/sites/default/files/publications/17988.pdf; Williams, 'Striking the Balance between Contiguous and Noncontiguous Areas of Operation at the Division and Corps Levels'; US Army, *FM 100-5 Operations*.

[193] See Jim Storr, *The Human Face of War* (London: Continuum UK, 2009). p 102f; the current Nato-context division is Rear, Close and Deep: see NATO AJP-3.2, Allied Joint Doctrine For Land Operations Edition B Version 1, 2022.

[194] Andrea Grillo, 'Israel Security Threat Assessment', Deep InSecurity, no. May 20 (2024). https://www.deepinsecurity.com/israel-security-threat/#4-current-israeli-"circles-of-threats."

[195] See Shimon Naveh, 'Between the Striated and the Smooth', *Cabinet Magazine*, no. 22 (2006).

[196] Strachan, 'Conventional Defence in Europe'. p 29f.

effective, Depth-preserving modus operandi for those less physically fortunate. However, while avoiding giving the adversary larger and more evident formations to engage, such an approach also sacrifices frontal combat strength.[197] Nevertheless, in this context, it is important to emphasise that this method, although potentially requiring less military strength, would still need some geographical defensive Depth. As Meir Finkel explains, this approach remains out of reach for Israel and the IDF, the specific case discussed in this thesis.[198]

Harmony, Multiplication and Reserves

As we have learned, not all actors can employ the absorbing approaches outlined above, as they may require *some* space to be temporarily evacuated.[199] However, when available and effectively utilised, leveraging the Rearward Depth offers a powerful means to gain an operational advantage by thwarting the adversary's success and potential culmination.[200] Yet, it remains uncertain whether such a modus would dislocate or effectively disrupt the attacker.[201] Nevertheless, as Simpkin argues, the potential to create a picture of emerging defeat in the adversary's mind is a powerful strategic asset to all actors, regardless of available resources.[202]

Building on this psychological dimension, some scholars contend that the campaign emerged as the central element of Operational Art and the main strategic objective. According to Naveh et al., battles and manoeuvres sought to exploit freedom of action (or operational harmony), while preventing the enemy from gaining the same advantage.[203] Further examining operational harmony in pursuit of Depth, Multi-Domain Operations (MDO), as described by the U.S. Army, emerges as a contemporary and powerful concept for those who are physically fortunate:

In simple terms, if properly employed, MDO can generate Depth through the integration of capabilities across different domains, allowing forces to target key weaknesses of the adversary. In line with this, Depth enables operational commanders to disrupt or undermine the operational coherence of the enemy while creating advantageous conditions for friendly forces.[204] In other words, MDO offers

[197] For closely related reasoning, see Luttwak, *Strategy.* p 148-152, 154.

[198] Finkel, *On Flexibility.* p 64.

[199] For example, the Israel and the IDF. With a geography too small for defensive manoeuvring, see Finkel, *On Flexibility.* p 64.

[200] See the Diminshing effect- and Culmination point of the attack, in Clausewitz, *On War*. p 527f, 611

[201] Dislocation and Disruption, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 66-76; for more about dislocation, see Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age.* p 64; and Liddell Hart, *Strategy.* p 326f.

[202] See Simpkin, *Race to the Swift.* p 224f.

[203] Freedom of action, see Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution*. p 44; for more related to operational harmony, see Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence*. p 21; and Boyd, *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 9.

[204] See U.S. Army, 'The U.S. Army in Multi-Domain Operations 2028'. See also U.S. Army, 'Army Multi-Domain Transformation: Ready to Win in Competition and Conflict', 2021. For a near real-time example of MDO, see Scarbro, 'Iran-Israel Conflict: A Quicklook Analysis of Operation Rising Lion'. For more related information, see Darya Dolzikova and Matthew Savill, 'Operation Rising Lion: The First 72 Hours'. RUSI Journal, June 16 (2025); Or Yissachar, Moran Alaluf, and Elie Pieprz, 'Operation 'Rising Lions': Removing an Existential Nuclear and Missile Iranian Threat'. David Institute for Policy and Strategy, June 13 (2025).

a resource- and capability-intensive perspective aimed at disrupting enemy attempts to achieve the desired operational harmony.[205]

When assessing MDO or traditional operational concepts aimed at force multiplication, a crucial aspect of Depth that correlates with the general Forward/Rearward perception (and the connection to momentum and culmination) is the availability of reserves.[206] Whether it is available or not depends on context, space and disposition. Regardless, it remains a factor of timeless importance to consider. From a defensive perspective, if blessed with sufficient space and resources, it can serve as the Depth-trump card that can erase any attacker's advantage. Steven Biddle explains: 'The longer the flanks [of the attacker], the greater the troop diversion this requires, and the longer the advance, the longer the flanks. If the defense is deep enough, eventually any attacker can be halted by this ever-increasing overhead cost'.[207] Conversely, while on the attack, available mobile reserve formations will be crucial to engage the enemy throughout its entire Depth to collapse/paralyse any attempts to organise reinforcements and counterattacks. Bruce Menning elaborately describes the logic and combined effect of the Deep attacks and agile reserve formations: '…a catastrophic disintegration of their entire defense system […] by blasting and crushing a path through the tactical zone then inserting a powerful mobile group for exploitation into the operational depths'.[208] Although these Depth-focused ideas and effects were extensively developed by the Soviets nearly a century ago, the fundamental logic remains relevant today, subject to the availability of sufficient resources.[209] Thus, from a U.S. Army doctrinal standpoint: '…depth remains a critical part of operational art because it shapes how a commander balances risk and opportunities. Depth requires a balance of "tempo and momentum" to provide a synchronized result'.[210]

As we approach the end of this review, we encounter Francois Jullien, who offers a different perspective on the issue of reserves, potentially more valuable to the main audience of this thesis. In doing so, he considers the issue from a less linear perspective, focusing on anticipation:

[205] Operational harmony, see Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence*. p 13, 16f, 21; Disruption, to break up the glue that holds things together, see Van Creveld, *Airpower and Maneuver Warfare*. p 9; see also Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver*. p 73f.

[206] The U.S. Marines Forces Reserve provides operational depth to commanders, see Rex C McMillan, 'Ready to Go-Now', *The Officer*, no. Winter (2016). p 44.

[207] Biddle, *Military Power*. p 70

[208] Menning, 'Operational Art's Origins'. p 9.

[209] Soviet Depth-centred concepts of Deep battle/ Deep Operations- still relevant, pending that sufficient resources are available.

[210] Maher, 'The Origins of Operational Depth in the First World War'. p 2.

'…the general "holds himself in reserve and waits for an opportunity" […] [once the enemy's door is open] "you spring through as swiftly as a hare, and the enemy is no longer able to resist" …' [211]

However, the fact remains that offensive enterprises striving for such ambitious effects tend to be seen as less relevant when the physical resources for full exploitation are insufficient. Thus, as Isserson argues, '**Following the breaking of the front, the breakthrough should be developed into the operational depth**, where the most decisive maneuver into the flank and rear should lead to the enemy's complete encirclement and destruction'.[212] Consequently, he clarifies that if the subsequent echelons or required reserves are missing, breaking down the door is pointless since no one will proceed through it regardless.[213]

These considerations on the role of reserves and the interplay between anticipation and sensitivity to emerging potential and structured planning highlight the complexity of Operational Art. Considering the problem outlined in this thesis, previous research on Depth highlights both challenges and potential solutions. Building on these insights, the next section revisits two key aspects of Operational Art—linearity and nonlinearity—before synthesising other essential findings from earlier research. This synthesis sets the stage for the next chapter, which develops the theoretical framework for the study.

Conclusion: Bridging Evidence to Theory

The Linear and the Nonlinear

As noted in the introduction and reiterated in this chapter, two broad traditions or approaches to Operational Art (and Depth) are apparent. One approach associates linearity with the perception of projecting possible future developments into a preconstructed (idealised) framework. The other relates to nonlinearity, which involves anticipating and exploiting the potential that emerges from the evolving situation.[214]

[211] Reserves to exploit opportunity, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 70; and reserves as a feature to deal with uncertainties, see Lonsdale, *The Nature of War in the Information Age.* p 171f.

[212] Isserson, *War of the Future*. p 218 (emphasis in original)

[213] Isserson, *The Evolution of Operational Art.* p 66, 67f; for related reasoning, see Biddle, *Military Power.* p 41

[214] Differing outlooks, Projection vs. Anticipation. See Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead*. p 27f. For additional background, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 189-192. See also: Shimon Naveh, Jim Schneider, and Timothy Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution*. p 8, 30.

In this section, along with the third article, *From the Linear towards the Circular*, I clarify and summarise their operational logic to foster better understanding and dialogue about the empirics, while also enhancing communication between the reader and the author.[215] The second aim of elaborating on these traditions is that they can help us challenge existing (linear) explanations and old truths more constructively.[216]

In simplified terms, these perspectives can be viewed as representing a cognitive dichotomy, with two ways of perceiving war and operations that, according to some, tend to vary across different regions of the world.[217] However, deviations from this generalised tendency do exist.[218] Based on his systemic view of the world, subject-authority Fritjof Capra describes this duality positively as between '*...Eastern wisdom and Western science...'*[219] Simons and Simons, on their behalf, almost echo the similar relationship between linearity and nonlinearity as that between *Science* and *Art* or between *objectivity* and *subjectivity*.[220] I personally have substantial experience (30 years of service) from military perspectives that supports the view described by Capra, as do others.[221]

Other researchers, such as Hamid Kbiri, dismiss this (orientalist) categorisation as portraying a negative stereotype: an outdated and ineffective Eastern style of warfare compared to a superior and advanced Western counterpart.[222] Ofra Graicer, on her behalf, uses the dichotomy in a positive sense, contrary to Kbiri and other sometimes negative orientalist messages.[223] She does so by using classic board games for her comparison. Essentially, she links the intricate game of chess to illustrate the preferred linear approach of Western armies. Conversely, the nonlinear behaviour of non-Western armies is exemplified by the game of Go, which is played on a smooth theatre.[224]

Israeli soldier/scholar, Shimon Naveh explores the connection between linearity and nonlinearity through the perspective of urban operations. He explains how a smooth approach without clear boundaries can foster creative manoeuvres by

[215] While these reference points are notions occasionally emerging in research on Operational Art or Military theory, often without a description of their meaning, this section and its brief elaboration, in concert with the latter three articles, provide a small, although additional, contribution.

[216] Doing so can challenge our biases and reveal hidden opportunities and new associations. See Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 232, 245.

[217] see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy*. p 189f; see also Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead*. p 16-28; and Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 180ff, 197ff;

[218] A deviating example: Russia. A part of the world, commonly referred to as the East, generally engages in operational ways that are typically considered to reflect a linear behaviour. However, some hybrid engagements could suggest otherwise.

[219] Fritjof Capra, *Patterns of Connection* (Albuquerque: High Road Books, 2021). p 36.

[220] Murray Simons and Samuel Simons, *Contextualizing Military Design Thinking,* Archipelago of Design, https://aodnetwork.ca/wp-content/uploads/2022/02/Contextualising-Military-Design-Thinking-v8.5.pdf p 9. (see the attached figure.)

[221] For example, see Chanelle, 'Western Philosophy vs Eastern Philosophy: What's the Difference?'. *Katsura Suzuki*, March 20 (2023); see also Stanislav Grof, East and West: Ancient Wisdom and Modern Science (New York: State University of New York Press, 1984). p 3-21;

[222] Hamid Kbiri, 'Military Orientalism: Contrasting Western and Eastern Ways of War', Imperial Journal of Interdisciplinary Research 3, no. 6 (2017). p 1-3.

[223] For an example outlining this skewed orientalist debate, see Barkawi, Tarak, and Keith Stanski. *Orientalism and War* (Oxford University Press, USA, 2013).

[224] Graicer, Two Steps Ahead, 25.

surrendering control. Conversely, he describes how a linear (striated) approach tends to favour control at the cost of innovative manoeuvring.[225]

Generally, regarding military operations, the nonlinear approach relies on emergence (the appearance or revealing of previously hidden elements) and constant movement (being in continuous motion without a fixed endpoint). In contrast, the linear approach emphasises stability and conformity.[226] Continuously building on these previous points, Depth can thus be regarded as a feature with attributes fluctuating between two perspectives: one is the traditional, linear, and resource-oriented (Forward/Rearward) perception that has dominated previous research.[227] Conversely, we observe the opposite: the nonlinear, comprehensive *(project- absorb -manoeuvre)*,[228] perspective initially introduced in the first article of this thesis, '*Re-thinking Operational Depth',* and subsequently elaborated upon and employed throughout the following three articles of this compilation.[229] Examining the linear perspective first helps illuminate the conventional assumptions and limitations that the nonlinear approach seeks to overcome.

Linear

The linear, *striated,* and *sequenced* approach to Depth and military operations characterises the *following* perspective: in other words, a functioning logic that strives to conform to prevailing paradigms, traditions, doctrinal ideal models, and habits.[230] It utilises reverse engineering in its sequenced attempts to control reality, evident in how the operation is conducted.[231] Its functioning logic involves projecting the operational reality into a pre-constructed framework, through which it is understood and then managed. This thesis challenges this conforming operational philosophy and does so with support from Fuller (and others); thus, '"War is a science so imperfect that, in general, no rules of conduct can be given...'[232]

[225] See Shimon Naveh, 'Between the Striated and the Smooth', *Cabinet Magazine*, 22 (Nov 2006).

[226] Goal or consequence- Ideal model or potential, See Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy*; also Capra, *Patterns of Connection*. p 35-40; conformity vs. creativity, see Pollack, *Arabs at War*. p 591f.

[227] For linear and Forward/Rearward perceptions, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* 31f, 89f; also Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. 82; and U.S. Army, 'FM 100-5 Operations'. p 16; and Maher, 'The Origins of Operational Depth in the First World War'.

[228] See Ekholm, 'Re-Thinking Operational Depth- a Source of Power'; Ekholm, 'Wizards of Depth-Israel's Area of Operations and Lessons Learned from Its Depth Dimension'.

[229] The characteristics of the nonlinear perspective, extensively elaborated under the label 'circular' in the third article, '*From the linear towards the circular',* is partly employed in this section.

[230] See Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. 24; for related reasoning, see Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987). p 372f, 474f; Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 11, 34-42; Naveh, 'Between the Striated and the Smooth'.; Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution.* p 29ff; Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead*. p 37f; Gracier, 'Beware of the Power of the Dark Side'; Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 4-9, 71f, 84-87, 99, 122ff, 201.

[231] See Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 33f; and Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 173-178; and Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 81, 84; and Ben Zweibelson, 'Seven Design Theory Considerations', MILITARY REVIEW, no. November-December (2012). p 85.

[232] Fuller, *The Reformation of War*. p 24 (referring to Marshal Saxe); regarding the difficulties of theorising war, see Strachan and Scheipers, *The Changing Character of War.* p 535; in the same regard, see also Engberg-Pedersen, *Empire of Chance.* p 51.

Despite such critical perspectives, conventional views persist, and as Zweibelson asserts, 'rank beats logic almost always'.[233]

Nonlinear

The nonlinear approach characterised by anticipation represents a *smooth* and *evolving* perspective to Operational Art, revealing a *reproductive,* fluid and improvisational nature.[234] In contrast to linear conformity and reverse engineering, the nonlinear approach seeks anomalies and challenges the structured, striated space by embracing emergence, along with simultaneous folding and unfolding.[235] Expressed in nonlinear terms, Depth: '…has neither beginning nor end, but always a middle *(milieu)* from which it grows […] [it] operates by variation, expansion, conquest...'[236] Put differently, nonlinearity more explicitly relates to reality and the operational environment as a complex system that thrives on constant movement and emerging potential.[237] In this context, John Fuller elaborates on how the skilled soldier adapts to changing conditions by constantly seeking to exploit them with innovative ideas.[238] Moreover, the nonlinear approach significantly focuses on *understanding* identities, agendas and inter-actor relationships,[239] thus rendering it closely aligned with the systemic (SOD) approach to Operational Art (and Depth).

The bottom line

In summarising the perceived relationship between linear and nonlinear approaches to Operational Art, it is important to emphasise that these perspectives are artificial constructs representing simplified poles of understanding. However, they are not mere stereotypes; rather, they are based on well-founded assumptions derived from previous research, extensive fieldwork, and insights gained from 30 years of linear service in the armed forces.[240] These perceptions mark the endpoints on a sliding scale, between which a dialectic practice or mediating exercise is necessary to ensure operational efficiency.[241]

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[233] Zweibelson, 'One Piece at a Time'. p 368.

[234] For related reasoning, see Deleuze and Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*. p 371f, 474f; Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy : Between Western and Chinese Thinking*. p 11, 39.

[235] Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 129, 168.

[236] Depth in non-linear terms. See related reasoning in Deleuze and Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*. p 21; and Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead*. p 37f.

[237] For additional elaboration on the functioning logic, see Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 168; and Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 16ff, 33f.

[238] Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 103.

[239] For more, see Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution.* p 22.

[240] An occupational career that has been substantially characterised by features of linearity as described in this section.

[241] For related information, see Donald McIntosh, 'The Objective Bases of Max Weber's Ideal Types', *History and Theory* 16, no. 3 (1977): p 265ff, 269, 279

> …this is important because, without such recognition, one might get the impression that linearity equates stupidity and order while nonlinearity equates cunning and disorder...

Irrespective of the impressions, the argument presented here asserts that neither extreme on this imaginative scale should be regarded as an objective to embrace fully. Nevertheless, given the nature of previous research related to Depth and the discussions summarised here, the linear approach seems more appropriate for significant powers with enough physical space to contain their opponents through effective defensive manoeuvres. Conversely, the nonlinear alternative appears to offer a more effective starting point for entities lacking these prerequisites, such as the one examined in this thesis. For clarity, it is important to recognise that the linear [Forward/Rearward] perspective dominant in previous research also influenced this project. This influence is evident in the interview guide and the informative notes found in Appendices 2 and 3. Let us now decrease the abstraction and summarise previous research relevant to this thesis.

Previous research: Key takeaways

'Ground is man's natural element, and an infinitely complex one [...] War in the fluid media is ultimately concerned with the possession or control of ground [too]...'.[242]

This review emphasises how previous research on Operational Art and Depth primarily concentrates on significant physical assets such as geography and military formations, while often overlooking the concept of Depth as it pertains to smaller actors. This finding presents a challenge for the main audience targeted—namely, the range of cases that may benefit from this project—and links to the core issue of this thesis: managing limited physical space and resources while striving to create the Depth essential for successful operations against an adversary or coalition. Ultimately, a lack of Depth in this context renders the traditional physical viewpoints discussed in this review nearly irrelevant, highlighting the research gap this thesis aims to fill. At this point, it is important to remember that smallness or limitations in geographical space—or other resources—only matter in relation to something or someone—an adversary, in this case.

[242] Simpkin, *Race to the Swift*. p 57.

Regardless of the concept selected to explore Depth in different contexts or whether one prefers a linear over a nonlinear approach, certain elements remain vital. Momentum appears as a key Depth-related feature recurring in previous research, often alongside its counterpart, culmination. While this aspect is crucial from a broad operational perspective, where knowledge and understanding benefit all involved, not all factors hold the same importance. In this context, Simpkins's physical and [linear] recipe for Depth through mass serves as a notable example.[243]

Nonetheless, there are admirable examples that also serve the main audience. The difficult situation of facing effect-limiting obstacles within the friendly force structure highlights a key element related to the broader issue of limited physical Depth discussed in this thesis. Essentially, these cases illustrate how concepts centred on physical geography and resources can be re-examined in terms of intended cognitive effects rather than merely imitating traditional physical methods.[244]

> By embracing a nonlinear mindset centred on anticipation, one can better integrate into the constant flow where the potential is poised to be exploited.

By doing so, one can effectively challenge linear conformity to traditional models and explore alternative approaches that better align with available resources and contextual advantages.

In this regard, Ben Zweibelson is dead on target: 'Challenging how we think about planning will help liberate us from the bureaucratic March towards yet another conflict with the same favorite tools in hand'.[245] Similarly, if a cunning strategy is used as a cognitive solution to a problem, there is no explicit need to regard Depth as a physical measurement of distance or from the standpoint of available resources. However, it becomes easy to do so if that is what we are pre-programmed to perceive.[246] This elaboration logically leads us to consider freedom of action as a cognitive measure of Depth, a topic we shall revisit later.[247]

In conclusion, supported by this review, it can confidently be stated that while Depth is usually understood in physical terms, primarily relating to geographic space and substantial military resources, there is ample opportunity to represent it in different forms. However, this will require applying some imagination to deepen the systemic

[243] See Simpkin, *Race to the Swift.* p 114.

[244] The problem of predictability – doing what we know best. See Gray, *The Future of Strategy.* p 53). This resembles the same problem related to the military obsession with tradition, customs and imitation. See Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 24, 42.

[245] Zweibelson, 'One Piece at a Time'. p 369; for a related reasoning regarding how states' military and strategic cultures tend to affect the strategic and operational actions they engage in despite a varying character of challenges, see Hew Strachan and Sibylle Scheipers, *The Changing Character of War* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011). p 20.

[246] Paradigms, maps and biases, see Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution*. p 9, 29.

[247] For closely related reasoning, see the principle of opportunity and reaction in Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age.* p 258f.

understanding of the operational context. By adopting this perspective, the thesis emphasises the importance of developing alternative Depth concepts that are more appropriate for actors lacking the resources to effectively counter their adversaries using the linear frameworks common in previous research. This approach challenges the linear Forward/Rearward model, which is often associated with an idealised view of operational conduct and a reverse-engineering philosophy aimed at achieving specific outcomes.[248] A logical first step to do so involves the alternative and creative duality of opportunity and denial.

To address these issues and limitations, particularly the lack of discussions focused on Depth available for the physically smaller, this thesis shifts its focus to Israel. This approach allows for examining Israel as a paradigmatic empirical case and laboratory—a small territory that appears to demonstrate Depth characteristics, contradicting the common assumption that limited space leads to military defeat.[249]

To effectively carry out a comprehensive on-site investigation of operational thinking in an environment that offers limited defensive manoeuvrability while encouraging a concept-developing ambition, it is vital to establish a theoretical baseline centred on a relevant yet manageable set of factors. Therefore, two theoretical starting points (MT and SOD) are selected for their compatibility with the traits of cunning and strategic exploitation of vulnerabilities to disrupt operational logic and hinder the opponent's pursuit of operational harmony. Consequently, drawing on previous research, cognitive-centred, nonlinear methods that can generate Depth despite its physical absence are examined. Moreover, this choice and subsequent approach are further supported by broader evaluations of the IDF's historical performance, ensuring the methodological robustness of pairing these specific case parameters with the selected starting points and vice versa.[250] Let us now turn our attention to theory—the starting point for the development of a Depth concept that is more accessible when the available Depth is limited.

[248] For ideal models, linearity, and reverse engineering, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 32ff; see also Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement.* p 180ff, 187; and Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 118f

[249] The paradigmatic case, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 232f.

[250] For more information regarding case selection and Israel as a paradigmatic case, see *'Case Selection'*.

Theory

> 'In a state of weakness and insignificance, when prudence, judgement and ability no longer suffice, cunning may well appear the only hope'.[251]

This chapter discusses and expands on the theoretical starting points used when engaging with the empirical case, aiming to develop an alternative concept of Depth that is more accessible to those with physical limitations. It is important to note that these theories are intended as perspectives to aid understanding, rather than as normative or operationalised frameworks to address the challenge of creating and maintaining Depth when physical space is limited.[252]

Initially, the main theoretical framework is presented, emphasising two complementary perspectives that share a consistent rationale. Next, the framework is summarised, and the focus shifts to the issue of methodology.

Theoretical Framework: Points of departure

This framework, namely the two points of departure and their underlying logic, is utilised to outline a problem-solving approach concerning the issue of Depth. They are employed in this capacity because of their potential to act as effective mitigators when the physical and linear methods common in previous research become inaccessible due to limited physical space and/or resources in relation to an adversary.

The framework incorporates MT and SOD, two closely related and interconnected perspectives on Operational Art that are ideally applied together to address the challenge of limited Depth compared to an adversary or a coalition of them. Employing these points of departure has proven especially suitable when studying the Israeli case. This fact has been recurrently and profoundly validated during the operational arts training this author has received during the periods spent in the operational environment.[253]

The framework offers a way to address and understand the empirical case, with the goal of developing a conceptual solution to the limitations identified in the existing

[251] Clausewitz, *On War*. p 203.

[252] Depth in this context refers to the ability to project (and absorb) power and influence over a significant area, a crucial aspect of military strategy.

[253] The primary mentor that has been involved in conducting this training is the founder of SOD and Director of *Strategema*, the IDFs Generals Course, Brig.Gen Shimon Naveh, PhD. An especially intense period in this regard included the better part of April 2023, where the specific scope included the underlying logics of SOD and cunning intelligence along with practical, real-world examples. The other mentor that should be recognised in this regard is Ofra Graicer, PhD, co-founder of *Strategema*. Other contributing persons are recognised in Appendix 1.

research. As such, it acts as a starting point, serving as a cognitive filter subtly reflected through the research problem, project description, and interview guide used at the beginning of fieldwork.[254] Utilised in this manner, the framework operates in the background to sense-make and facilitate *understanding*, as opposed to operational indicators intended to *explain* a generalised or normative recipe for success.[255]

Armed with this framework and the baggage of ideas brought from previous research, the ambition is to transcend linearity and potentially explore nonlinear or *unexpected* approaches,[256] which is presumed possible when studying the specific actor in question. Doing so constitutes less of an exercise in massing force and more of a cognitive endeavour to find vulnerabilities, a task these outlooks are especially capable of.[257] Following this approach may sometimes require partially 'losing control' and adapting to the evolving circumstances to make the most of the situation; fundamentally, it is a nonlinear trait that may not be comfortable for all actors, depending on their preferred method and beliefs regarding Operational Art.[258]

However, at the right moment and with the necessary prerequisites, substantial effects can be realised with minimal investments, demonstrating the combined impact of these perspectives.[259] Returning to the story of Spartan King Leonidas, the Battle of Thermopylae stands as an example. This time, it is not primarily about exploiting the physical terrain as a power enhancer but rather as a feature that helps temporarily in dislocating the enemy's strength: denying the adversary the chance to deploy his military might, so that a decisive victory and subsequent entry into Spartan rear areas lead to a collapsing defence, which would otherwise be a reasonable outcome.[260]

That said, let us continue exploring the two points of departure that are believed capable of compensating for a lack of Depth in the physical and resource-intensive aspects that have dominated previous research on the topic. By doing so, we will familiarise ourselves with the essential characteristics and mindset that contribute to strength, thereby improving our understanding.

[254] The interview guide initially employed is provided in Appendix 2. The Project description is found in Appendix 3. The issue of central importance in this regard is the added cognitive perspective: a common denominator and a unifying thread that aligns the core meaning of the theoretical starting points.

[255] Understanding vs. Explaining, see Friedrich Kratochwil, 'Constructivism: What It Is (Not) and How It Matters', in *Approaches and Methodologies in the Social Sciences*, ed. Donatella Della Porta and Michael Keating (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008). p 94ff. The thesis' ambition to understand instead of explain is critical to acknowledge, especially regarding the second article, Wizards of Depth and the analytic table it develops.

[256] Elaborating linear vs. nonlinear as differentiating between linearity and crafty, indirect approaches, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 89f.

[257] For related reasoning, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver.* p 61, 107ff.

[258] To be carried along by the unfolding situation, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 26, 33, 39, 162; this is also an embraced feature of methodology and fieldwork, further elaborated in the subsequent chapter.

[259] For the notion of great effects from small investments, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 19.

[260] See Cartledge, *Sparta- En Odödlig Historia [an Immortal History]*.

Manoeuvre theory (MT)

Basically, what we discuss here is smart power rather than brute force, that is, a clever, unpredictable, and cost-effective approach, often sharply contrasted with attrition and mass. Instead, as Maimonides prescribes:

'"Come on, let us deal wisely with them"'[261]

That said, let us turn to ancient Sun Tzu and a couple of more contemporary thinkers sharing their thoughts on the subject: '"In presence of the enemy, your troops should be arrayed in normal fashion, but in order to secure victory abnormal manoeuvres must be employed"'.[262] Leaning on William Lind, Marc Jessup continues:

> '[*M*]*aneuver* war is the most promising tool for the side with fewer numbers and less weight of metal. While the side that has material superiority can choose freely between attrition or maneuver, the side whose resources are inferior overall can only prevail by successful maneuver'.[263]

Soviet General Isserson provides, in a way, a contrasting view closely connected to power projection. Still, from a time and a setting quite different from Lind's: '*Maneuver is a means, not an end, and does not yield a result without the subsequent destruction of the enemy*'.[264] Echoing the Soviet General, unfortunately, bloodshed and fighting are necessary from this perspective as well, although preferably to the minimum extent possible. Without it, Van Creveld explains, manoeuvre warfare would merely amount to endless shadow-boxing.[265]

In light of these examples, the main incentive to adopt this perspective is that it represents a strength-enhancing perception based on small investments and high revenues.[266] In other words, what is gained here in support of this project is the amplification of existing strength through indirect means: a cognitive exercise centred on brainpower to enhance physical ability while targeting the enemy's will.[267]

[261] Moses Maimonides, *The Guide for the Perplexed*. ed. M Friedländer, Second edition (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul LTD, 1904). p 393f.

[262] Sun Tzu et al., *The Complete Art of War*, 1st ed. (Radford: Wilder Publications, 2008). p 25.

[263] Jessup, 'Systems Competition'. p 57; William S Lind, 'Defining Maneuver Warfare for the Marine Corps', *Marine Corps Gazette*, no. March (1980).

[264] Isserson, *War of the Future*. p 217. (original in bold text)

[265] Van Creveld, *Airpower and Maneuver Warfare*. p 1f.

[266] See Angstrom and Widen, *Contemporary Military Theory*. p 84f, 113-119; see also Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver*. p 27-31

[267] See Danchev, 'Liddell Hart and Manoeuvre'. p 34; see also Fry, 'The Meaning of Manoeuvre'.

In simple terms, this essentially means using existing resources in new or different ways. Following the same strategic reasoning, a useful alternative would be to neutralise enemy strengths by making them obsolete or irrelevant.[268] If the potential of such an alternative were to emerge as subsequently exploitable during offensive power projection, it could provide a prolonged deterrent effect, given the very unpleasant [perplexing] experience of suddenly becoming irrelevant.[269] Therefore, a key feature of manoeuvre thinking is that the main aim is to influence the opponent's mindset. This idea is often linked to Sun Tzu, who portrays true strategic skill as the capacity to win without fighting: to take cities without attacking and to defeat nations without long conflicts.[270]

Moreover, the meaning of manoeuvre, as used in this thesis, is not only a potentially powerful depth enhancer but also includes a moral dimension related to sustainment, endurance, and combat economy.[271] Here, it is important to recognise that MT is not a magical silver bullet but rather something that aligns with limited resources.[272] Therefore, it represents a less wasteful approach to addressing issues of human sacrifice and material destruction by waiting for the appropriate circumstances before taking action.[273] In this regard, Liddell Hart elaborates: 'The soundest strategy in any campaign is to postpone battle and the soundest tactics to postpone attack, until the moral dislocation of the enemy renders the delivery of a decisive blow practicable'. [274] This rationale utilises the indirect approach, a philosophy and fundamental principle of MT often linked with Sun Tzu and contemporary theorists like Liddell Hart. It acts as the primary choice in situations where essential resources—such as geography, time, or military formations—are insufficient to establish the required Depth or achieve a broader objective. Again, as Marc Jessup asserts, it is probably the best approach to consider when a military actor needs to punch above its weight class.[275]

While the indirect approach has its merits, it is important to recognise that, historically, it has been the exception rather than the rule. The direct approach, its counterpart, has been the standard method of conducting operations.[276] That said, the indirect approach, which is fundamental to MT, has the potential to prevent the adversary from seizing the opportunity to unfold his strength, making it either

[268] Dislocation, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver*. p 66f.

[269] See, for example, the Egyptian experience described by Martin Van Creveld in *The Sword and the Olive : A Critical History of the Israeli Defense Force* (New York: Public Affairs, 2002). p 211.

[270] Sun Zi, *Krigskonst [The Art of War];* See also: Liddell Hart, *Strategy*. p 334ff; For similar contemporary ideas, see Leonhard, *The Principles of War for the Information Age*. p 77; Fuller, *The Reformation of War*. p 29f.

[271] Svechin, *Strategy*. p 275f.

[272] For closely related reasoning, see Svechin, *Strategy*. p 275f.

[273] Economy of Force, see Fuller, *The Reformation of War*. p 35; see also Liddell Hart, 'The "Man-in-the-Dark" Theory of Infantry Tactics and the "Expanding Torrent" System of Attack'.

[274] Liddell Hart, *Strategy*. p 147.

[275] Jessup, 'Systems Competition'. p 57.

[276] Liddell Hart's, *Strategy*. [p 145] and Tuvia Ben-Moshe's, 'Liddell Hart and the Israel Defence Forces - A Reappraisal' [*Journal of Contemporary History* 16, no. 2 (April 1981). p 383-387] provide a comprehensive understanding of the indirect approach in military strategy

irrelevant or significantly less powerful.[277] When used effectively, it offers a strategic advantage by skilfully leveraging the benefits that arise in your favour rather than relying on brute force.[278] These features showcase MT's strategic advantages by offering a way to counteract the physical strength of its competitors and potentially address the lack of physical space (Depth), making it a suitable choice for this thesis overall. Even more suitable is to have it form a complementary framework with SOD, which is the case here. Doing so, an ongoing systemic inquiry, subsequently mapping and outlining the functioning logic of the operational system, can reveal the potential links that may be exploited for maximum revenue based on the indirect approach.[279] Additionally, due to the unique features of the Israeli case, namely its physical smallness relative a vast, hostile region and the puzzling track record, this framework is considered to be especially appropriate, which improves the prospects for conceptual development.

In conclusion, the concept of manoeuvre, as discussed in this thesis, aims to address the issue of limited resources while pursuing Depth through cunning and efficient combat practices. Essentially, it seeks to maximise potential and achieve significant results from the evolving context, all while conserving resources. While MT serves as a starting point for conceptual development regarding Depth rather than a normative or explanatory tool, the following three perspectives act as useful cognitive aids and operational methods when Depth is lacking. These concepts are organised by ambition and impact, linking to the second perspective in the framework: SOD.

The peak level of ambition is illustrated by pre-emption, succeeded by dislocation and disruption. Robert Leonhard further explains their meanings and interconnections:

'Indeed the highest and purest application of manoeuvre theory is to preempt the enemy, that is, to disarm or neutralize him before the fight. If such is not possible, the maneuver warrior seeks to dislocate the enemy forces [...] rendering them useless and irrelevant [...] If the enemy cannot be preempted or dislocated, then the maneuver-warfare practitioner will attempt to disrupt the enemy...'[280]

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[277] See Dislocation- an economic means, in Leonhard, *The Principles of War*. p 255; for an illustrative example, see the Battle of Thermopylae described in: Cartledge, *Sparta- En Odödlig Historia [an Immortal History]*.

[278] Exploitation of emerging potential, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy*. p 25ff, 33, 89.

[279] For more regarding the harmonsing coupling of SOD and MT, see Jessup, 'Systems Competition'. p 57.

[280] Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver*. p 19f; *Disruption*: 'State of being split-apart, broken-up, or torn Asunder', as expressed by John Boyd in *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 135.

With these clarifying remarks, we now examine the accompanying outlook, SOD. This theoretical perspective effectively improves understanding of the operational system's logic. It helps to identify targets, obstacles, or weak points that can be exploited for maximum revenue. Furthermore, it aligns well with the aims of this thesis, namely, to develop a conceptual approach that goes beyond the linear frameworks we have seen dominating previous research. From an overarching viewpoint, SOD together with MT primarily acts as a cognitive-centred starting point designed to reveal and promote the exploitation of emerging opportunities, prevent the opponent from doing the same, or combine both strategies. In the next section, we explore its logic further.

Systemic Operational Design (SOD)

Drawing on John Boyd, what we discuss here is '…striking at those vulnerable, yet critical, tendons, connections, and activities that permit a larger system to exist'.[281] In other words, an indirect, target-producing activity in close harmony with MT. However, it is not something you do once: 'Design is not a single step; it is a developing awareness based on constantly changing circumstances and imperfect information'.[282] In other words:

> *'[a] 'dialectic deliberation' between conflicting perspectives to enable extensive reframing…' rather than a '…problem solving via linear reverse engineering of solutions'.*[283]

SOD represents the second starting point adopted to address the issue of limited resources when pursuing Depth. It is a cognitive exercise that enables operational strength to develop through inquiry and a deep understanding of the operational system's actors and connections by 'looking under the surface of things'.[284] Doing so, SOD preferably represents a view of the future (and Operational Art) through potential and anticipation, rather than something projected into a pre-constructed model.[285] Essentially, as its originator, Shimon Naveh argues, it is about operational harmony: '…break the continuity of the operational front and separate the formations from each other, thus preventing cooperation between them […]

[281] Boyd, *A Discourse on Winning and Losing*. p 58.

[282] Thomas C Greenwood and Frank G Hoffman, 'Evolving the OODA Loop for Strategy', Marine Corps Association, no. February (2025). n.p.

[283] See Jackson, *Military Design Thinking.* p 119.

[284] Tzu et al., *The Complete Art of War*. p 22.

[285] See Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 190; potential vs. anticipation, see Graicer, *Two Steps Ahead.* p 27f; for additional related content, see Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement.* p 4f, 99-104.

disrupts the basic operational mechanism (synergy)…'[286] Thus, through a cunning mindset, awaiting the adversary while carefully considering when to attack can make multipliers available by adaptation, Francois Jullien explain: '…one can profit from the exhaustion and lassitude of the enemy when he is worn out by thirst and hunger, when "his forward positions are not yet well established and the troops that guard the army's rear are still crossing a river." …In all these cases, whoever knows how to exploit the potential of the situation can easily win the day'.[287]

In other words, SOD is an operational philosophy closely aligned with the indirect approach—the cornerstone of MT that is widely adopted. However, it is crucial to understand that the nature of systemic design sharply contrasts with traditional military doctrine. This contrast includes both necessary and obstructive challenges for military enterprises.[288] Ben Zweibelson explains in detail: 'To properly apply design theory, a leader must appreciate that doctrine influences how our military prefer to think. Doctrine´s primary weaknesses are inflexibility, the inability to improvise, and resistance to any change that threatens the relevance of the organization that is the proponent for the doctrine'.[289] Rather than emphasising cause and effect, issues closely connected to doctrine, SOD relies on experimentation, characterised by motion, continuous evolution, creativity, and the non-repetitive application of force.[290] Put simply, SOD is reflexive. It focuses on accepting the anticipation of an ever-changing reality rather than trying to fit into a fixed one. Thus, when the prospects for a weak link in the enemy system are revealed as a result of ongoing events, they must be wisely exploited to ensure not only the desired effects overall, but also maximum return on investment, essentially the core logic of MT.

While highly focused on deconstruction, SOD challenges stability-driven [linear] military systems and restrictive paradigms, effectively illustrating the nonlinear, conceptual approach this thesis aims to exploit. Consequently, nothing within the military system is perceived as immune from destruction and replacement; Ben Zweibelson emphasises:[291]

'SOD would not permit any "sacred cows" to walk freely. When an organization requires game-changing innovation, everything must be open to deconstruction […] *Systematic* thinking seeks to break down complexity into simplified parts to link inputs and outputs'.[292] In other words, SOD relies on and requires an openness to the outside and, subsequently, a readiness to criticise the most deeply cemented

[286] Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence.* p 17

[287] Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 19; regarding the wise application of force, see also Maimonides, *The Guide for the Perplexed*. p 393f.

[288] The positivist nature of doctrine vs. the anti-positivist nature of design, see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 7, 69ff, 77f, 84, 162f.

[289] Ben Zweibelson, 'Seven Design Theory Considerations', *MILITARY REVIEW*, no. November-December (2012). p 82.

[290] Positivist doctrine and anti-positivist design, see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 7; For related reasoning concerning the connection between systems theory and constructivism, see Kratochwil, 'Constructivism: What It Is (Not) and How It Matters'. p 84ff.

[291] Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement.* p 116ff, 121f, 141f.

[292] Ibid. p 141, 142.

features of the prevailing paradigm. Without doing so, military designers will remain confined within the walls of tradition and doctrine, unable to go beyond.[293] This theoretical starting point is particularly valued as a potential method for those with fewer physical resources, encouraging a cognitive shift beyond perceived limitations to better utilise available resources with fewer constraints.

That said, the disruptive nature of SOD is not targeted directly at an adversary. Firstly, there is a strong emphasis on self-reflexivity to loosen the constraints and break the shackles and boundaries that restrict the commander's cognitive freedom of manoeuvre, thereby limiting their ability to act. This focus on self-reflexivity encourages deep and continuous introspection, which is essential for developing effective military strategies. Consequently, efforts to change the external world and the adversary are only pursued after one has transformed oneself, one's understanding, and one's worldview. Graicer, Dufort and Jones explain: 'Self-disruption assumes the principle that defense leaders should actively question what they think and know. They must then devise effective approaches to changing their core conceptual and operational fundamentals, transforming themselves and their organizations to create alternative ones'.[294]

Put more bluntly, SOD is fundamentally about mapping both adversary and friendly forces, and in doing so, it reveals the links—the relationships that may be exploited and transformed to ultimately function in your favour.[295] Ofra Graicer refers to degrees of freedom as a quality measure of your design.[296] Operationally, the degree of freedom can be understood as the non-restrained room to choose and execute the course of action that is deemed most effective. Moreover, a significant portion of this freedom is essential for enabling the rapid realisation of potential that arises during events.

However, embracing emergence is not always easy, depending on the starting point. Once again, we turn to Ben Zweibelson, who elaborates:

[293] For related reasoning, see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 81, 166f.

[294] Self-disruption as a central feature of Operational design; see Graicer, Dufort and Jones, 'What Is Strategic Design?'. p 340ff.

[295] The purpose of design, see Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, *The Structure of Operational Revolution - A Prolegomena*. p 95.

[296] Degrees of freedom, see Graicer, 'Self Disruption'. p 28f.

'Instead of acknowledging complexity´s adaptive, emergent nature, we use linear causality logic and reverse-engineered planning concepts to construct intricate campaign plans that flow backward from predetermined end states and cement them with preconceived actions set along lines of efforts. [And even though] An orchestra does not play music backward, yet we usually plan backward'.[297]

This type of indirect exploitation offered by SOD highlights a crucial aspect and advantage, particularly when there is insufficient space or weight in metal to compete with the adversary.[298]

Summarising the framework

What is the rationale for adopting these theoretical simplifications as foundational starting points in the analysis of the case study? Regarding the issue of relative smallness concerning physical Depth, the collaborative framework of MT and SOD provides an effective starting point for exploring and developing conceptual approaches to Depth beyond the linear Forward/Rearward perception that has dominated previous research. While using the term 'framework', it should be emphasised that it does not serve as a prescriptive or normative formula for creating Depth. Instead, these theories act as valuable theoretical foundations for conceptually developing a notion of Operational Depth and maximising its effects when geographical and material resources are limited. This cooperative framework involves applying MT's principles of manoeuvre and indirect approaches, alongside SOD's focus on systemic disruption of vital links and operational harmony, to confront the challenges posed by a lack of or limited physical Depth. Furthermore, these are also traits of increasing relevance to a wider audience, as contemporary actors typically can reach the entire disposition of their adversary.[299] In relative terms, a fact more beneficial to the physically smaller, while the inherent strength of physical Depth, traditionally enjoyed by the larger actor, becomes partly dislocated.

The main character trait here, seen as a common factor and starting point for a possible route to Depth, is the idea of disruption. This involves taking chances to engage, weaken, or outwit key parts of the operational system, potentially causing

[297] Zweibelson, 'Seven Design Theory Considerations'. p 85; for more related to linearity see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking.* p 7, 73, 162f.

[298] A mitigator when the weight in metal is lacking, see Jessup, 'Systems Competition'. p 57.

[299] Effects of actors gaining the ability to reach the entire disposition of their adversaries, see Adamsky, 'Through the Looking Glass'; See also Luttwak, *Strategy*. p 158f. see also Sakvin, *The Basic Principles of Operational Art and Tactics: A Soviet View.* p 115f.

the enemy's operational actions to become irrelevant and leading to paralysis.[300] Therefore, indirect engagement of targets—or systemic links that could potentially generate greater revenues than the effort involved—leads to the cautious assumption that this framework can serve as an effective theoretical starting point, which may be useful when attempting to develop alternative Depth concepts due to physical limitations.[301]

MT and SOD thrive on cognitive strength, both in implicit and explicit terms. Thus, cunning and prudence, rather than the immediate application of brute force, manifest the common denominator and the incentive behind the cognitive, auxiliary perspective employed in the thesis's articles.[302] Together, they offer a starting point for the operational issue, creating the essential understanding and subsequent objectives to be tackled through indirect methods and the prudent use of limited resources.

Ultimately, for this collaborative framework to function optimally as a starting point, it relies heavily on potential and anticipation, embodying inherently nonlinear characteristics, as illustrated by the butterfly effect and the word 'may' in the citation below. This underscores the importance of an open and flexible mind, capable of relinquishing control while awaiting the 'right' circumstances to exploit in the operational context: '…it postulates that a butterfly flapping its wings in China (a minuscule input) may result in a thunderstorm in Washington, D.C., rather than the anticipated clear, dry weather (a huge change in output)'. [303]

Armed with these powerful perspectives serving as a foundation for conceptual development, let us now focus on methodology and closely related issues.

[300] Disruption, dislocation and irrelevance, see Leonhard, *The Art of Maneuver*. p 66f; 73ff; more on dislocation as an operational objective other than destruction- an avenue to achieve shock and paralysis by engaging the enemy in depth. See Tuck, *Understanding Land Warfare*. p 86ff; see also 'collapsing the enemy rather than annihilating' in Adamsky, *The Culture of Military Innovation*. p 133.

[301] Engaging systemic links that could potentially yield larger revenues can also include restraining obstacles residing in the friendly areas of the operational system.

[302] Regarding cunning and prudence: 'Come on, let us deal wisely with them', see Maimonides, *The Guide for the Perplexed*. p 393.

[303] Thomas X Hammes, *The Sling and The Stone, On War in the 21st Century* (Minneapolis: MBI Publishing Company and Zenith Press, 2006). p 284.

Methods, Methodology and Design

The general outline of this chapter is as follows: First, the idea behind the project is introduced, followed by a section describing the research process and the data-gathering methods, including their possibilities and challenges. An explanatory reflection on the methodology and the design used is provided from a broad perspective. Afterwards, attention turns to ethical issues. This includes reflexivity, questions of research in sensitive and potentially hazardous environments, as well as controversial topics and matters directly related to the exploratory interview technique, all aimed at gaining a deeper understanding, answers, and new questions.[304] Finally, the methodological section is summarised by a concluding discussion concerning the iterative nature of research.[305]

As initially clarified, the nature of the project is reflected in the compilation package, which presents a series of four articles or essays: one theoretical, effectively supporting the review chapter outlined above; the other three are primarily empirical pieces, mainly written based on insights gathered during repeated periods of fieldwork in the Israeli operational setting over two years. The recurring nature of the research phases and the subsequent interplay between in-field periods and periods of reflection and desk research exemplify a deliberate research strategy founded on the belief that effective learning requires significant reflection and active engagement with the material.[306]

Iteration and the morphing world

Given the constant motion of the world and the operational environment, iteration is essential. In other words, it is the ongoing, dialectical process of exploring new answers and posing new questions.[307]

[304] See related reasoning in Ralf Helenius, *Förstå Och Bättre Veta [Understanding and Improve Knowledge]* (Stockholm: Carlssons Bokförlag, 1990). p 82f.

[305] This iterative process, which allows us to learn as we go, particularly regarding fieldwork, should reassure the reader of our approach's robustness and confidence. See Erica Townsend-Bell, 'Being True and Being You: Race, Gender, Class, and the Fieldwork Experience', in *PS - Political Science and Politics*, vol. 42 (Cambridge University Press, 2009). p 311.

[306] For more related to the insider/outsider dichotomy and the importance of moving out of the field to effectively interpret collected insights, see Delphine Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies', in *Routledge Handbook of Defense Studies*, ed. David J Galbreath and John R Deni (Abingdon: Routledge, 2018). P 44f; see also Andreas Håkansson, 'Vad Ska vi Med Föreläsningar till? [What Is the Purpose of Lectures]', *Högre Utbildning [Higher Education]* 7, no. 2 (2017). p 41.

[307] See Helenius, *Förstå Och Bättre Veta [Understanding and Improve Knowledge]*. p 82f; see also Bjørn Slettoa et al., 'Demystifying Academic Writing in the Doctoral Program: Writing Workshops, Peer Reviews, and Scholarly Identities', *PLANNING PRACTICE & RESEARCH* 35, no. 3 (2020): p 356; and Karen Gravett et al., 'The Development of Academics' Feedback Literacy: Experiences of Learning from Critical Feedback via Scholarly Peer Review', *Assessment & Evaluation in Higher Education* 45, no. 5 (2019). p 661.

Moreover, subscribed to the idea that the nature of warfare remains constant, while its character (like reality) is constantly morphing, shifting and evolving,[308] this thesis aims to understand the functional logic of the issues of attention rather than explain them. Choosing this path is based on two main reasons in addition to the evolving nature of reality: *first*, it departs from a personal view- and consideration of the functioning logic (or ill-logic) of the world and, particularly, human interactions; *second*, studying warfare empirically- in the real world, re-affirms contextuality as perhaps the most crucial factor to consider, especially when (or if) thinking in terms of transferability or [conceptual] ability to travel,[309] as '…security practices shift across contexts'.[310]

That said, contextuality and reflexivity are essential features of this field, and they are also the main reasons for studying things directly in the real world rather than conducting meta-analyses based on analyses carried out by others. Therefore, drawing on Emerson et al., I aim to maintain an undistorted understanding without introducing additional filters, while remaining alert and cautious about potential biases that may arise from my personal involvement.[311]

As later described in more detail, the thesis is heavily empirical and explorative and thus dependent on my ability to extract the proper meaning of the material, given the problem and scope approached.[312] Put differently, it is interpretive and, being such, it can quickly be criticised as unreliable.[313] The antidote to such a critique is increased transparency, which is achieved by providing the reader with the necessary insight into why and how a particular understanding was established or a specific conclusion was drawn.[314] At the bottom line, what you have in front of you comprises an explorative and transformative enterprise.[315] As such, it strives to deviate from linear attempts to control or reverse engineer warfare or military operations.[316] Instead, it adopts a nonlinear and evolving approach when exploring the issue of Operational Art, specifically focusing on the feature of Depth.[317] Armed

[308] Clausewitz, *On War.* p 87f. For more related reasoning, see Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 99ff; and Deleuze and Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*. p 21.

[309] Contextuality and transferability see Asbjörn Johannessen and Per Arne Tufte, *Introduktion till Samhällsvetenskaplig Metod [Introduction to Methods of Social Sciences]*, 1st ed. (Malmö: Liber AB, 2003). p 125f; see also Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 189; and Gerring, 'What Makes a Concept Good? A Criterial Framework for Understanding Concept Formation in the Social Sciences'. p 385, 389ff.

[310] Victoria Loughlan, Christian Olsson, and Peer Schouten, 'Mapping', in Critical Security Methods, ed. Claudia Aradau et al. (Abingdon: Routledge, 2015). p 24.

[311] The importance of Reflexivity, see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 41.

[312] In this respect, it is essential to master the culture from an insider perspective; see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 42f.

[313] Helenius, *Förstå Och Bättre Veta [Understanding and Improve Knowledge]*. p 84ff; Biggs, Tang, and Kennedy, *Teaching for Quality Learning at University*. p 207f, 213.

[314] For related reasoning, see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 48; see also Barbara Bassot, *The Reflective Practice Guide: An Interdisciplinary Approach to Critical Reflection* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2016). p 1ff, 79-92.

[315] See Benjamin Baez, 'Confidentiality in Qualitative Research: Reflections on Secrets, Power and Agency', *Qualitative Research* 2, no. 1 (2002). p 51f.

[316] For related reasoning, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 32ff; see also Jackson, *Military Design Thinking.* p 83f.

[317] Nonlinear and evolving. For closely related reasoning, see Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant, *Cunning Intelligence in Greek Culture and Society* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1978). p 46; see also Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design*

with imagination as the augmenting feature opposite to ignorance and blind obedience to the prevailing paradigm,[318] the idea is to increase understanding while broadening the perception of Depth.[319] Thus, through fantasy and imagination, we can actively create/design the opponent to function effectively as a mirror for self-scrutiny.[320] Like Fuller, when doing so, we salute the substantial deviation from the mainstream while avoiding what Van Creveld calls the repetitive and routinised.[321] With this conceptual perspective established, we now turn to the background and key factors that informed the inception of this research endeavour.

Research Background and Guiding Idea

Armed with imagination as the augmenting feature opposite to ignorance and blind obedience to the prevailing paradigm, the idea is to increase understanding while broadening the perception of Depth

The scope and perspective of the approach stem from an idea developed during service in the armed forces, complemented by years of war studies undertaken at war academies and the Swedish Defence University. Over time, interest in Depth has emerged due to three main aspects: one-third comprises a professional interest in Strategy and its practical manifestation - *the operation and Operational Art*; the other two-thirds depart from an emerging annoyance. The first of the annoying aspects concerns Depth, in the sense that it is a notion/ feature that militaries, politicians, academics and laymen alike frequently use as tacit knowledge without a common perception of what they refer to, but with an implied expectation that everyone knows what they refer to.[322] The second frustrating feature is that war studies during my time at the Swedish Defence University have been overly focused on the continental theatres of the Second World War, while, for example, the operational experiences of Finland, North Vietnam, Georgia, or Israel have been rarely studied in comparison. The following annoying reason, emerging over time, especially during Operational Art courses, is the linearity and ideal model/ doctrinal fixation[323]

Movement. p 4-10, 95, 99ff, 181ff, 199f; and Ekholm, 'Wizards of Depth-Israel's Area of Operations and Lessons Learned from Its Depth Dimension'.

[318] The importance of fantasy and imagination, as seen in Zweibelson's *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 3, 184f, 201f, 263ff; for a discussion more related to the paradigm, see Adamsky, *The Culture of Military Innovation*. p 20ff.

[319] To look at Operational Art and see other different- or other things. See Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 224.

[320] About imagination regarding design, see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 105

[321] Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 315; Van Creveld, *The Sword and the Olive.* p 61, 141.

[322] Regarding this problem, see John Gerring elaborating what he refers to as 'norms of ordinary usage [that] generally provide a range of terminological and definitional options, rather than a single definition; most concepts, perhaps all key social science concepts, are multivalent'. Gerring, 'What Makes a Concept Good' p 362.

[323] Doctrinal linearity focuses on predicable, positivist cause & effect; see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking*. p 7, 162f; for more related reasoning and further elaboration, see Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 4f, 180f, 247.

encountered through the templates and estimate models enforced on us as military students.[324] Sometimes, bordering on stupidity, but always to predictability, despite cautions raised by Fuller (and others):

> *'War is a science so obscure and imperfect that in general no rules of conduct can be given to it which are reducible to absolute certainties ; custom and prejudice, confirmed by ignorance, are its sole foundation and support'.*[325]

Briefly summarising, the main aim has been to examine the military aspect of Depth through an exploratory approach, using the Israeli case — an actor operating in a challenging environment characterised by its lack of physical Depth. Despite this limitation, this actor has amassed a military record that is almost paradoxical, suggesting that valuable lessons can be drawn from the case, considering its strategic and operational context.

The ambition to explore this paradox is clear in the last three out of four attached articles and partly in the first. Furthermore, a key methodological choice has been to examine things directly and gather personal insights and empirical evidence on-site within their functional logic and context.[326] Finally, a conceptual extension or broadening has been made based on a highly qualified assumption to increase the prospects of understanding how Depth can be created and maintained when the physical (temporal) terms dominating previous research are lacking. This move is executed by adding an auxiliary perspective to Depth [the cognitive], a common denominator based on the central characteristics and working logic of the employed theory.[327]

Research Design

Reducing the level of abstraction, we focus on more specific research design choices and a clearer, more direct presentation of the project. In doing so, let us start by reconnecting with the overarching research question and the two auxiliaries that will provide the detailed answers:

[324] See, for example, NATO, Allied Command Operations, *Comprehensive Operations Planning Directive [COPD]*, Interim V2 (Belgium: Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe, 2013).; NATO, Allied Command Operations, *Comprehensive Operations Planning Directive [COPD]*, Version 3. (Belgium: Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe, 2021).

[325] Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 24. (Referring to Marshal Saxe's 'Reveries upon the Art of War' [English edition, 1757]. p iii, iv); more related to the problem of theorising war, see Barkawi and Brighton, 'Powers of War: Fighting, Knowledge, and Critique'. p 138f.

[326] Benefits of fieldwork and contextuality, see Susanna P Campbell, 'Ethics of Research in Conflict Environments', Journal of Global Security Studies 2, no. 1 (2017). p 91; see also Yin, *Fallstudier - Design Och Genomförande [Case Study Research].* p 192ff.

[327] For related reasoning on concept extension, see Gerring, 'What Makes a Concept Good'. p 380, 385.

How has the lack of depth affected Israeli Operational Art and operational thinking?

And…

How is the lack of depth reflected in Israeli Operational Art?

How has it been resolved in IDF operational thinking?

Pursuing these questions, some highly conscious choices and decisions have been made regarding research design:

Firstly, the project should be viewed as qualitative in nature. This means it aims for a detailed description of a specific issue rather than a broader one with generalising ambitions. Secondly, it is exploratory. In this context, it engages with a foreign environment with an open mind and broad scope, where theories serve as a starting point to deepen understanding and facilitate potential conceptual development, rather than an approach focused on explanation and generalisation. These choices support the pursuit of answers to the research questions by examining Israel as a paradigmatic case. As Bent Flyvbjerg explains, a case that stands out: '[it] transcends any sort of rule-based criteria [and] sets the standard'.[328] The choice of this specific case under the paradigmatic label was made through a deep understanding of Operational Art, combined with the limitations identified in previous research and the relevant features of the theories applied. The consistent logic of these elements further supports the research's validity and more. Moreover, further drawing on Flyvbjerg, suggests that analysing this case from the paradigmatic perspective could greatly enhance the outlook for formulating a nonlinear Depth concept accessible to the primary audience of this thesis,[329] thus reflecting the main ambition of the thesis. More information regarding the case's status is presented in the next section.

Case Selection

It is easy to get the impression that this thesis is a case study from the outset, selectively chosen to engage with Israel and its defence forces, the IDF. While such an impression may be understandable, it is nonetheless incorrect. Instead, the thesis concentrates on examining the military concept of Depth within a limited geographical setting. It examines how the topic can be understood more holistically through a less linear perspective than the typical operational approach found in previous research on the subject.

[328] The paradigmatic case, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 232.

[329] Experience and intuition as means to judge whether a case can be interesting in a paradigmatic sense, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 233.

Considering this research aim, the thesis thus examines the case of Israel as a physically very limited actor with an operational track record that contradicts the common conclusion that physical inferiority leads to military defeat.[330] (At this point, it should be noted that there are, of course, other causes of defeat as well.) By deviating from the linear and physically centred features dominating previous research on Operational Art and Depth,[331] the ambition is to use this highly suitable environment as a laboratory.[332] Not for theory testing but to develop a Depth concept that is employable for actors suffering a shortage of Depth relative to their adversary, or potential adversary.

Potential alternatives

During the search for suitable empirical cases of physically limited actors with puzzling track records, specific demarcations were employed to narrow *and include* a range of possible subjects.[333] Beyond limited physical territory and contradicting track records, the search extended to locations beyond areas traditionally perceived as representing 'the West'.[334]

In doing so, Georgia and North Vietnam were considered but later dismissed. The former was due to coronavirus complications, and the latter was primarily because of its more complex accessibility, particularly regarding geographic location, linguistic requirements, and the need for cultural education. Although Finland is part of the 'Western family', it was still considered. Mainly because of its impressive conduct of defence-in-depth operations against the Russian aggressor during the Second World War and its ongoing, continuous preparations, due to its lack of Depth concerning a powerful and, once again, aggressive neighbour. Furthermore, cases like Singapore were seriously considered but dismissed chiefly due to increasing friction points, such as accessibility, language barriers, and the need for substantial cultural familiarity.

The Israeli Case, motifs and character

The final choice fell on Israel, a 75-year-old nation situated in a very complex and traditionally hostile environment, safeguarded by a national defence built around universal conscription, with a small standing force operated by conscripts and a

[330] In this regard, see Biddle, *Military Power.* p 190-193; *A case – a history with a point.* The case of something under study is in focus because of that something: Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 133.

[331] See Chapter 2, Previous Research; see also the first attached article, Re-thinking operational depth.

[332] See Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 232f.

[333] Regarding criteria for case selection in a single study, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 229-237; see also Yin, *Fallstudier - Design Och Genomförande [Case Study Research]*. p 62f, 104f.

[334] Drawing on Mezirow's work on transformative learning and perspective transformation, the active attempt to widen the outlook beyond the 'West' comes from a qualified assumption based on prior knowledge. I.e., a reflective enterprise that challenges my prior awareness and thinking, particularly their validity. See Barbara Bassot, *The Reflective Practice Guide.* p 88.

limited number of professionals. In addition to its military defence, Israel maintains a substantial and comprehensive total defence that promotes resilience and serves as a deterrent. Despite being a resilient actor with powerful allies, its population and geography are still relatively small, which highlights the need for short wars.[335] Accordingly, Israel relies on swift manoeuvring against systemically identified targets rather than prolonged attrition. Although the actor possesses limited or no physical Depth,[336] their operational record suggests that valuable insights may emerge from their agile and flexible approach to operational thinking,[337] which extends beyond mere aggressiveness, prevention, or pre-emption.[338] All of the above are character traits that make it stand out and qualify as a paradigmatic case, or a most important case —a case that stands out, defines its own category, and illustrates the issue of interest as clearly as possible.[339] Alternatively, as Kristin Ljungkvist puts it:

> *'…a most important case in the sense that it represents the most significant illustration of the phenomena of interest that we can find'.*[340]

In this regard, referring to the category of geographically small military actors without Depth that exhibit a paradoxical operational record.

Additional characteristics of high value

Essentially, Israel's threatened existence and complex prerequisites appear to have prompted alternative approaches and effective solutions that meet a higher standard. In this regard, Ångstrom and Widen elaborate: '…it is the lack of strategic depth due to its limited size that has led Israeli strategists to favour pre-emptive strikes, movement, speed, and a dominant offensive to avoid a costly war of attrition on their own soil'.[341] Although home-turf biased, Meir Finkel explains the reasons bluntly:

[335] See Ehud Eilam, *Israel's Way of War* (Jefferson: McFarland & Company, Inc., Publishers, 2016). p 121-150; and Ehud Eilam, *Israel's Military Doctrine* (Lanham: Lexington Books, 2018). p 39ff.

[336] See Eilam, *Israel's Way of War*. p 32f, 102, 114 for related facts and elaborations; see also Jean Loup Samaan, 'The Dahya Concept and Israeli Military Posture Vis-à-Vis Hezbollah since 2006', *Comparative Strategy* 32, no. 2 (April 2013). p 151.

[337] Eilam, *Israel's Way of War*. p 39ff, 168f.

[338] Eilam, *Israel's Military Doctrine*. p 42ff.

[339] See Kristin Ljungkvist, *The Global City 2.0. An International Political Actor Beyond Economism?* (Uppsala: Elander Sverige AB, 2014). p 100; see also Jörg Friedrichs and Friedrich Kratochwil, 'On Acting and Knowing: How Pragmatism Can Advance International Relations Research and Methodology', *International Organization* 63, no. 4 (2009). p 718.

[340] Ljungkvist, *The Global City 2.0.* p 100.

[341] Angstrom and Widen, *Contemporary Military Theory.* p 37; for a contemporary example, see Hayman, 'Operation Rising Lion: Achievements, Open Questions, and Future Scenarios'.

> 'Israel's geographical reality (a depth too shallow for defensive maneuvering); the intolerable social and economic pressures that would be caused by an extended war of attrition...'[342]

Moreover, Israel constitutes a crossroads between East and West, epistemologically balancing between linearity and nonlinearity, or between Western science and Eastern wisdom (as Capra puts it).[343] Israel has connections in both directions, with citizens coming from many parts of the world. Initially (during the start of the Cold War and first years of Israel's existence), this was reflected in what Avi Shlaim calls a non-identification logic (a concept that refers to maintaining relationships without necessarily identifying with the other party's beliefs or actions) while 'keeping all doors open'. [344] As such, it was presumed to potentially offer approaches to Operational Art beyond what some associates with 'the West'.[345] Moreover, and perhaps most importantly, due to Israel's limited access to the physical and temporal aspects of Depth and its track record, this case is assumed to encompass approaches to Operational Art and Depth, beyond the linear, reverse-engineered, ideal models dominating previous research,[346] which may be usable for conceptual development. I believe this to be a reasonable assumption, especially with support from John Fuller: '…every healthy nation which possesses the power to establish strong frontiers will attempt to do so, either by occupying natural features which will strengthen them, or by creating weak neighbours who dare not cross them'.[347]

Despite being founded on an ancient religious base, Israeli society and operational environment are notably open and display a flexible 'doer mentality' with significantly fewer traditional boundaries and military restrictions compared to Sweden. [348] This is especially relevant, not only from the perspective of a small military actor that must mobilise a strong community and consistently fight for national survival, but also for exploratory projects such as this thesis that seek solutions to complex issues outside the 'traditional box'.

Due to Israel's demographic mix of Ashkenazi (Jews of eastern European descent) and Mizrahi (oriental Jews) Jews and its Druze, Arab, Arab Bedouin, Christian and

[342] Finkel, *On Flexibility.* p 64; for more about Israeli limited Depth, see Eilam, *Israel's Way of War.* p 14ff; and Levite, *Offense and Defense in Israeli Military Doctrine.* p 33ff.

[343] Western science and eastern wisdom, see Capra, *Patterns of Connection.* p 36f.

[344] For more, see Avi Shlaim, 'Israel between East and West, 1948-56', *International Journal of Middle East Studies* 36, no. 4 (2004). p 658f; and David Rodman, 'War Initiation: The Case of Israel', *Journal of Strategic Studies* 20, no. 4 (2008): 1–17.

[345] 'The West' in generalised terms, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 189.

[346] Ideal models and linearity, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 33f, 189ff; see also Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 84ff, 99f, 180f, 200f; Science vs. wisdom see Capra, *Patterns of Connection.* p 36f; or as Aaron Jackson elaborates, *between positivism and anti-positivism,* see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking.* p 7. The linear approach also represents the Operational epistemology that dominates the environment from which this author departs —the Swedish Armed Forces.

[347] Fuller, *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 67

[348] This author's point of departure. A democratic nation sporting roughly the same population as Israel, with a long tradition of conscription; For relevant information regarding the Israeli doer-mentality and the informal society, see Shamir, *Transforming Command*. p 89, 195, 198; Luttwak and Shamir, *The Art of Military Innovation.* p 45-55.

Circassian minorities, there are many different perceptions on issues.[349] Therefore, almost everything is 'legal prey' as topics for discussion and intense dialogue,[350] which is especially noteworthy when seeking to transcend the shackles of established traditions, doctrines, and rigid paradigms.

Moreover, (although paradoxically) Israel, being *the* prominent successor of World War 2 Germany concerning mission command, flexibility, and combined arms tactics, also added to the list of positives as those character traits are closely aligned with *manoeuvre thinking* and the *design approach to Operational Art.*[351] I.e., the augmenting outlooks employed to widen the range of potential applications to Operational Art and Depth beyond the approaches that have dominated previous research.

Adding these features together offers enough incentives for this study, should voices be raised claiming its controversy.

Additional choices concerning Research Design

In practical terms, the research involves studying the operational thinking of Israeli generals, a group previously believed to possess valuable insights on the subject and, ultimately, to the research field. Consequently, the overall design adopts a qualitative and fieldwork-oriented approach, echoing Deschaux-Dutard: '…a very fruitful way of enquiring into the defence field […] [thus] "if one wants to know society, one first has to know it first-hand"…'.[352]

Being so, it includes aspects of deduction, induction and abductive reasoning,[353] with a shared intention of promoting a widened understanding while creating additional questions.[354] Although induction and abductive reasoning are the primary epistemological approaches used in most of the related articles, it did not just happen to 'end up this way'. Instead, it reflects a deliberate choice aligned with the employed theory, where empirical, real-world insights are sought to explore and

[349] The multicultural/ multiethnic/multireligious feature of the IDF, see Noor Dahri, *IDF Israeli Defence Forces: Ground Forces, Operations, Units & Command & Control* (Dehli: Vij Books India Pvt Ltd, 2022). p 2

[350] For further elaboration and an interesting example, see Luttwak and Shamir, *The Art of Military Innovation.* p 53f.

[351] See also Alon Paz, 'The Effort to Recreate the IDF: "There Is Hereby Established a Defense Army of Israel"', Dado Center Journal 2016; for more, see Luttwak and Shamir, *The Art of Military Innovation.* p 100ff; and Shamir, *Transforming Command*. p 82f.

[352] Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 43 (referring to Becker, *Les ficelles du métier: Comment conduire sa recherche en sciences sociales,* Paris, La Découverte, Coll. Repères Guides.)

[353] Abductive reasoning, see Igor Douven, *The Art of Abduction* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: MIT Press, 2022). p 34f; see also Igor Douven, 'Abduction', The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, 2021, https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/sum2021/entries/abduction/. For more relevant information regarding induction, deduction and abduction, see Aida Alvinius, Anders Borglund, and Gerry Larsson, *Tematisk Analys : Din Handbok till Fascinerande Vetenskap* (Studentlitteratur AB, 2023). p 13f, 21f.

[354] See Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 198f; and Helenius, *Förstå Och Bättre Veta [Understanding and Improve Knowledge]*. p 78-84.

chart unknown territories.[355] In other words, this approach has been prioritised over deductive reasoning and attempts to narrow and reduce complexity.[356]

However, this is not an 'all or nothing' choice. Like other aspects in this thesis, it is seen as a dialectical practice — drawing the best from both sides. That said, the first article outlines the broad trajectories of Depth identified in previous research on the topic. In doing so, it helps build the tentative definition that is later used throughout the thesis.[357] The three subsequent articles employ a mixed approach, favouring induction from the operational environment of the case of an actor, beforehand perceived to contain knowledge and insights vital to the problem approached if approached wisely.[358] This process is therefore carried out with the help of a tentative definition established early on, and later supported by a supplementary model. These two elements are crucial contributions of this thesis, effectively realising the aims of concept development.

The motif behind the single-case design, as opposed to other cases or several cases, focuses on the need for in-depth research, given the nature of the problem and the available time. Thus, due to the extensive time required to gain access to [military] environments that can support the quest of solving the problem and addressing the specific research questions,[359] it was decided that the project would focus on depth instead of width, being well aware of the additional benefits a dual- or multi-case approach could provide.[360] In other words, choosing two or more cases would mean that the time spent on contact seeking reduces the study's depth, which is undesirable given the research goal of developing a deeper understanding rather than producing a comparative analysis with generalisable results. However, as Bent Flyvbjerg and others suggest, a single case study can also contribute to understanding the broader class, too.[361]

Choosing the single case has enabled a thorough, practical engagement with the environment, its agents, and the various operational examples that make up the case. This method has supported five intensive research periods at the site of interest, allowing for deeper participation beyond formal interviews and providing ample time for reflection, reflexive analysis, and writing.[362] Ultimately, a strategy

[355] Systemic design and chartering of unknown territories, see Graicer, 'Self Disruption'. p 36.

[356] Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 197ff.

[357] This definition (project, absorb, manoeuvre) is presented on page 18 of the introduction to this compilation chapter.

[358] For more on case selection, *a case of*.., see Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 133ff, 140ff; see also see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 232f.

[359] Regarding access, see Eyal Ben-Ari and Yagil Levy, 'Getting Access to the Field', in Routledge Handbook of Research Methods in Military Studies, ed. Joseph Soeters, Patricia M Shields, and Sebastiaan Rietjens (Routledge, 2014). p 12ff; regarding access and implications of Gatekeepers see Björn Müller-Wille, 'Doing Military Research in Conflict Environments', in Routledge Handbook of Research Methods in Military Studies, ed. Joseph Soeters, Patricia M Shields, and Sebastiaan Rietjens (Abingdon: Routledge, 2014). p 41f.

[360] Different designs offer different possibilities; see Yin, *Fallstudier - Design Och Genomförande [Case Study Research]*. p 60-68, 76f.

[361] Generalisation from single cases, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 220; see also Alexander L George and Andrew Bennett, *Case Studies and Theory Development in the Social Sciences* (Cambridge: Belfer Center for Science and International Affairs, 2005). p 123f.

[362] Amanda Chisholm, 'Ethnography in Conflict Zones', in *The Routledge Companion to Military Research Methods*, ed. Alison J Williams et al. (Abingdon: Routledge, 2016). p 138–152; arguing for the importance of conducting Defence studies first-hand, see Reflexivity in Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 40-45f.

that emphasises concept development based on empirical insights regarding the issue of Depth when it is physically insufficient.

This ethnographic aspect of the project has been vital for understanding correctly, given the vastly unfamiliar cultural, societal, and communicative elements. While conducting fieldwork on-site, my aim has been to engage as fully as possible with the diverse Israeli society, experiencing and observing it directly. This may seem to go well beyond the specific scope of the project. However, I can confidently say that such engagement is necessary to grasp the underlying logic of how the society functions, which, in this case, is very open and closely connected to its armed forces.[363] The longer and deeper this engagement has been pursued, the more evident it has become that the Israeli identity and self-image considerably influence their behaviour, both socially and militarily. Gaining these insights makes it much easier to draw proper lessons from their operational engagements. Campbell elaborates on the necessity of profound contextual knowledge:

'…all scholars of violence, and particularly those who conduct […] ethical fieldwork in conflict zones requires that the researcher understand the lived reality of those experiencing violence, either as perpetrators or victims. To anticipate the benefits and harms of field research, including to the researcher herself, the field researcher needs to have sufficient knowledge of the rapidly shifting conflict context'.[364]

To support this ethnographic component, daily engagement with various Israeli media outlets and opposing sources, such as Al Jazeera, has been essential. Although time-consuming, this effort has been vital for understanding the ethos, political dynamics, societal logic, functionality, regional tensions, and ongoing debates evident in media outlets and social media platforms.

During the initial engagements, that is, before the environment became familiar, the shared language and knowledge regarding Operational Art served as an even more vital unifying element that aided understanding and communication.

Downsides and Alternative choices

Alternative options regarding design, given the potential offered by the specific case, may fall into any of the following categories. However, other reasonable choices may also be available: the misfitting case study, which aims to demonstrate that a specific instance does not align with a universal or general claim, or cases that diverge from common generalisations. A third category might involve theory-infirming cases that slightly undermine an established theory. Moses Knutsen exemplifies this with a case study where the strong theoretical link between democracy and peace does not hold. This thesis examines a similar link that also fails, but within a very different

[363] For more about this issue, see Van Creveld, *The Sword and the Olive*. p 273.

[364] Campbell, 'Ethics of Research in Conflict Environments'. p 92.

context – the connection between a lack of space (Depth) and military defeat.[365] A fourth alternative could be what George and Bennett refer to as a deviant case, meaning one that deviates from established generalisations,[366] while Yin, on his behalf, employs the notions of *extreme* or *unusual* when labelling cases that deviate from theoretical norms.[367] As we can see, there are many alternatives, and the best one will depend on the nature of the problem, the research goal, and, not to mention, personal preferences and beliefs about knowledge production. However, to ensure research quality, the need for transparency is equally important regardless of the choices.

That said, all such choices carry additional implications. Perhaps the most important in this context relate to scope conditions and applicability, meaning the characteristics that make the research valuable to other cases.[368] However, it is important to note that this thesis mainly emphasises Depth, which is closely linked to the research area of Operational Art. Therefore, Israel and the IDF are chosen to support the conceptual aims of this thesis, rather than serving as a testing ground for theory or as a focus area in itself.

Nevertheless, as a single case study involving an 'odd bird', some might argue that its findings have limited relevance to other contexts. Here, it is important to clarify that this thesis does not aim to prove anything; instead, it seeks to develop an approach that can conceptually assist other actors who lack the Depth needed to engage their adversaries through defensive manoeuvring. In this regard, Hans Eysenck offers both support and wisdom:

> *'"sometimes we simply have to keep our eyes open and look carefully at individual cases—not in the hope of proving anything, but rather in the hope of learning something!"'* [369]

Unlike the numerous positive features and operational highlights we have discussed regarding the chosen case, there is always a significant downside and limiting factor to consider when examining the Israeli context: the deeply rooted controversy and diversity in global opinion. Although this downside will be discussed further later, in basic terms, it demands a level of reflexivity that reaches an extreme compared to many other contexts or cases.

[365] Case selection strategies, see Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 139-144.

[366] George and Bennett, *Case Studies and Theory Development in the Social Sciences.* p 114f.

[367] Robert K Yin, *Case Study Research and Applications: Design and Methods* (Los Angeles: SAGE Publications Inc., 2018). p 49f.

[368] Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 139-144.

[369] See Hans Eysenck, in Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 224.

With these motifs, downsides, and considerations regarding case selection in mind, let us turn to the practical task of conducting fieldwork in this partly closed environment.

General blueprint: A retrospective

Initially, I conducted a theoretical study of the military aspect of Depth to enhance my foundational knowledge. At this early stage, two specific methodological choices shaped the overall structure of my work: First, I decided that the subject (Depth) would be examined from an auxiliary perspective to explore avenues accessible to actors with fewer physical resources, that is, beyond the main trajectories of previous research.[370]

The aim of this initial stage was to determine an angle of approach, which led to the tentative definition of Depth and, subsequently, the model presented in most of the articles. This model, a practical and conceptual contribution of this project, was utilised, evaluated, and refined during later fieldwork periods. The second part of this process involved a triangulation effort, aiming to explore the concept of Depth from multiple perspectives to develop a comprehensive understanding.[371] To do so effectively, the decision was made to use an alteration of the abstraction level to meet this purpose.[372]

Before conducting fieldwork, a substantial amount of reading was done to facilitate engagement with potential interlocutors immediately upon arrival. The idea was to use this initial empirical engagement to capture the insights needed to construct the first empirical article, '*Wizards of Depth'.* To do so effectively, an analytic framework was developed and used based on the work leading up to the first theoretical article. Initially, this tentative framework served as a basis for the pre-mailed project description and later as the foundation for the initial interview questions.[373] At this early point, the perception of Depth was described in the linear [forward-rearward] terms dominating previous research *and* in nonlinear [project-absorb-manoeuvre] terms along with the added cognitive perspective. Employing both was conducted with the purpose of *probing*, meaning to cast a net wide enough to reveal potential applicability before attempting to narrow the abstraction and scope based on emerging findings.

Later, it was confirmed that both perspectives are needed to some extent, depending on the context, the general complexity of warfare and the particular operational

[370] A stated prior, the cognitive perspective- *a common denominator* of MT and SOD, was added as an auxiliary presumed able to unlock new perspectives- and strength additives about the problem of a lack of physical Depth.

[371] See Larsson, 'Om Kvalitetskriterier i Kvalitativa Studier [About Quality Criteria in Qualitative Studies]'. p 350f; see also Donatella della Porta and Michael Keating, Approaches and Methodologies in the Social Sciences (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008). p 322.

[372] On p 92, an explanation text and an illustration of the altercation of abstraction are provided.

[373] See Appendix 2, *Interview Guide* and Appendix 3, *Project description.*

engagement.[374] This fact, i.e., the need for mediation or dialectical practices, represents an insight gained from fieldwork and a subsequent argument discussed in the three attached articles and the concluding section of this compilation text.

As an exploratory project, many elements were enveloped in uncertainty. Consequently, it was difficult to determine precisely what to encounter, more than reasonably, a different approach to Operational Art compared to my own point of departure. Nonetheless, as stated, it was during this relatively early stage that the decision was made to employ varying levels of abstraction to capture or 'triangulate' different Depth aspects.[375] The first article approached the subject from a broad, superficial, and easy-to-understand perspective. Then, the idea was to gradually increase the detail by moving from wide and shallow to deep and narrow. In hindsight, this logic has proven to be very effective and helpful throughout the project.[376] With that said, we leave the outline of the general blueprint and turn to the empirical case.

Empiric research- Fieldwork

Regarding methodology, the overall aim and purpose of this chapter and its subsections is to communicate the content of the thesis clearly and transparently, particularly concerning fieldwork and information-gathering methods. However, the journey from idea to conclusion has not been straightforward. Nonetheless, it has been possible to maintain the fundamental structure of the original conceptual blueprint, which has effectively served its purpose throughout. The detailed plan has required some adjustments and minor tweaks, especially due to challenges posed by the coronavirus pandemic and the subsequent travel restrictions. Nevertheless, the original issue has been pursued as planned and in a transparent manner ensuring a comprehensive coverage of the issue. Moreover, as expected, the selected case and its specific attributes proved effective in addressing the limitations of previous research, while also aligning well with the theoretical points of departure in use. Together, these features demonstrate the project's validity, both in terms of sound case selection and categorisation, as well as the suitability of the employed theories concerning the concept-developing ambition.

However, it is an exploratory and interpretive endeavour. Regarding replicability, it is uncertain whether another individual seeking answers to a similar enquiry would

[374] In this regard, the key notions are *Mediation or Dialectic practice*- the ability to oscillate between extremes- or different approaches as opposed to an active selection of either- or.

[375] For related reasoning concerning triangulation, see Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 132ff; see also Larsson, 'Om Kvalitetskriterier i Kvalitativa Studier [About Quality Criteria in Qualitative Studies]'. p 350f; and Yin, *Fallstudier - Design Och Genomförande [Case Study Research]*. p 125ff.

[376] Chapter 4 of this compilation text further elaborates and illustrates this move.

reach the same conclusions, as it depends on personal filters for sense-making.[377] Thus [as Cicero stated],

> *'We don't see things as they are, we see things as we are'.*[378]

Critical filters in this regard are knowledge, experience, and shifting ontological beliefs. Moreover, for a researcher entering this environment, where Strategy and its operational expressions have a very short shelf life, it presents a challenge when attempting to interpret effectively to gain insights, enhance knowledge, and subsequently develop concepts.[379] Therefore, a turbulent and rapidly changing environment is very different from a stable region like the Nordics. For a researcher trying to approach a problem within a stable framework, this can be problematic. However, for the Israeli operator, it is not; it is unremarkable. Consequently, they are trained to thrive in the constantly evolving nature of reality and, subsequently, in an emerging style of warfighting.

However, to do this effectively, one needs a kind of ongoing systemic inquiry, particularly a restless mindset constantly seeking anomalies.

Gathering of information and positioning

The main feature driving information collection has been professional curiosity, formalised by the defined scope and problem. As a result, it has been self-regulating in how it treats interlocutors and interviewees. Gaining access to their experiences and insights sometimes demands extreme flexibility. Echoing Markus Göransson, I strongly agree that you must relinquish a significant amount of control. Doing so, in many ways, breaks with traditional methods to conduct interviews and dialogues, because the reality studied often calls for flexibility beyond standardised approaches outlined in methods literature.[380]

Gaining this insight early in the project made adjusting expectations (such as formality and reliance on the interview guide) more manageable and better aligned with the practical (cultural) possibilities of steering the individuals engaged in

[377] Eyal Ben-Ari, 'Reflexivity: Potentially "Dangerous Liaisons"', in *Routledge Handbook of Research Methods in Military Studies*, ed. Joseph Soeters, Patricia M Shields, and Sebastiaan Rietjens (Routledge, 2014). p 34; see also: Yin, *Fallstudier - Design Och Genomförande [Case Study Research]*. p 56ff, 62 (revealing character).

[378] Cicero, in Barbara Bassot, *The Reflective Practice Guide.* p 79.

[379] Gray, *The Future of Strategy*. p 82; see also 'plans are merely a basis for change', i.e., the IDF slogan in Luttwak and Shamir, *The Art of Military Innovation*. p 103; also referring to IDF Maj. Gen (ret.) Izhik Eitan, Former IDF Central Commander. *Personal Interview,* 2022-08-31, Kerem Mahara, Israel.

[380] Markus Göransson, 'The Interview as a Cultural Performance and the Value of Surrendering Control', in *Doing Fieldwork in Areas of International Intervention: A Guide to Research in Violent and Closed Contexts*, ed. Berit Bliesemann de Guevara and Morten Bøås, 1st ed. (Bristol University Press, 2020): 49–60; to adapt yourself to circumstances, see Jullien, *A Treatise on Efficacy.* p 24f.

conversation. Drawing on Zoe Bray, a tangible example of such an adjustment is deliberately choosing engagements based on open-ended, semi-directed interviews, closely resembling what David Bohm calls the informal dialogue, ideally recorded but not always.[381] This highly considered move was made based on experience gained from several pilot engagements with interviewees in the field.

While settling for this slightly more open-ended, dialogue-resembling method, some closely related features of the semi-structured interview have been adopted when approaching the particular problem, especially in the context of the research environment's culture. Harrell and Bradley describe the character of information gathering well: 'The conversation can go in many directions, and will vary much by the respondent. The interviewer does not exert much control over the course of the discussion. They might follow explanations with additional questions based on the topics the respondent brings up, but the session would be relatively free-flowing'.[382] While Harell and Bradley described the variant employed quite well using the 'semi-structured label', the open-ended variant also provides a valid description of the method used, at least by Zoe Bray: '…they enable interviewees to say what they feel is relevant and important to them […] Respondents supply their answers without being constrained by a fixed set of possible responses'.[383] To some, this may seem too unstructured. However, here, it is essential to understand that the scope of research is known to the interviewee beforehand through a project description sent in advance alongside the first article of the series, which was published before fieldwork.[384]

During the pilot engagements, a concerted effort was made to utilise the interview guide provided in Appendix 2 in the aforementioned ways. However, it quickly became evident that its use was not helpful but restrictive; therefore, an adjustment towards the open-ended, dialogue-like alternative was adopted for ongoing use. We recognise the need for mediation here, as there is no one-size-fits-all project, not even from a methodological research perspective. What is relevant in this context are the diverging perspectives within the same methodological approach. Some features, as described earlier, are highly applicable to support this project. Others are not, such as the rigidity and limited flexibility reflected by Harrell and Bradley: 'In semi-structured interviewing, a guide is used, with questions and topics that must be covered. The interviewer has some discretion about the order in which

[381] For open-ended, semi-directed interviews, see Zoe Bray, 'Ethnographic Approaches', in *Approaches and Methodologies in the Social Sciences*, ed. Donatella Della Porta and Michael Keating (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008). p 309ff; see David Bohm, *On Dialogue* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2014). p 6-19; and also Brenda L Moore, 'In-Depth Interviewing', in Routledge Handbook of Research Methods in Military Studies, ed. Joseph Soeters, Patricia M Shields, and Sebastiaan Rietjens (Abingdon: Routledge, 2014). p 117f.

[382] Margaret C Harrell and Melissa A. Bradley, 'Data Collection Methods: Semi-Structured Interviews and Focus Groups' (Santa Monica, 2009). p 26.

[383] Bray, 'Ethnographic Approaches'. p 310.

[384] The before-hand sent project description, see Appendix 3.

questions are asked, but the questions are standardised, and probes may be provided to ensure that the researcher covers the correct material'.[385]

The kind of 'on-the-move flexibility' embraced can have ethical implications if handled recklessly, which will be discussed more thoroughly in the following section. Nonetheless, what is emphasised and respected in this thesis is the contributor's will. If she or he wishes to remain anonymous, that will be honoured, and if this is unclear in retrospect, a [mitigation-] method has been devised and applied. Similarly, nothing will be published that is shared in confidence and kept secret.[386]

The latter has been a subject of constant reflection during the project's field study periods, owing to the deep access I have gained.[387] Reflecting on these matters retrospectively, I can confidently reaffirm the concept of 'losing-control experience' described by Göransson. This term pertains to the researcher's experience of losing control over the research process due to the unpredictable nature of the field, a phenomenon I encountered during my field study periods.[388] Flexibility is critical when engaging this congregation, and the formal frame of the interview, along with the emphasis on filling forms of informed consent, as described in parts of the methods literature,[389] does not always function well in the studied environment. It sometimes raises suspicion and irritates, highlighting the need for a more flexible approach.

Positioning

Considering my role as a soldier and scholar in relation to the environment and the primary organisation I interact with (the Israeli Defence Force, IDF), the ability to adapt and fit properly within the research environment has proven to be a vital and prominent feature. With this ability, reflective questions such as identity, affiliation, solidarity, and ethics frequently arise. Erica Townsend-Bell describes this well:

> 'Identity forms your assumptions, affects the kinds of questions you ask, and the evidence you seek. If you ignore how your identities impact interpretation then you are arguably mis-specifying your research model'. [390]

[385] Harrell and Bradley, 'Data Collection Methods'. p 27.

[386] In this regard, see Baez, 'Confidentiality in Qualitative Research'. p 35, 42.

[387] For related reasoning, see Townsend-Bell, 'Being True and Being You: Race, Gender, Class, and the Fieldwork Experience'. p 314.

[388] Göransson, 'The Interview as a Cultural Performance and the Value of Surrendering Control'.

[389] Flexibility, No-harm and informed consent see Campbell, 'Ethics of Research in Conflict Environments'. p 91f; see also Martyn Denscombe, *Forskningshandboken [The Good Research Guide - for Small-Scale Research Projects]* (Lund: Studentlitteratur AB, Lund, 2009). p 197ff; For related reasoning see Göransson, 'The Interview as a Cultural Performance and the Value of Surrendering Control'. p 51-54.

[390] Townsend-Bell, 'Being True and Being You: Race, Gender, Class, and the Fieldwork Experience'. p 311.

What I discuss here is closely related to flexibility, ***but*** with high demands for *reflexivity*. In this case, it involves navigating and adapting in a chameleon-like manner across dual affiliations, as well as a continual shift between involvement and detachment, depending on what I consider to be optimal for each specific occasion. Drawing on Moelker, this sort of behaviour demands careful reflection. On the one hand, to sustain the trust the engaged interlocutors give, and on the other, it is to maintain independence to avoid going native.[391]

Returning to the formal aspects of things, such as interview guides and consent forms, it is important to recognise that these tools are not useless or redundant. On the contrary, they are crucial for mental preparation, protecting interlocutors, concluding post-interview tasks, and promoting reflexivity.[392] However, the emphasis here is on the importance of preparation to build the confidence needed to improvise when necessary. For example, if you are unexpectedly forced to leave your computer, phone, and other supporting tools outside the room, which has happened several times, there is a clear need to adapt and perform. The level of preparation is crucial, as you must deliver your best performance even when circumstances are far from the ideal conditions you have been trained for or prepared in.[393]

At its core, the process of gathering information and insights to support a solution to the defined problem and research question has relied on three main principles: open-ended, dialogue-resembling interviews, many informal discussions, and a thorough, personal understanding of the operational environment, sometimes guided but mostly not. This has been achieved through repeated periods of fieldwork, accompanied by significant reflection and reflexivity in between. That said, let us move on to elaborate on the entrance into the specific environment approached during fieldwork.

The material- the research environment and its challenges

Being an outsider conducting research within a closed organisation, such as the IDF, requires a heightened sense of awareness. The risk of receiving distorted or unrepresentative information is always present. However, developing deeper personal relationships can help mitigate this, and this thesis has extensive experience in managing such situations. Conversely, the opposite risk must also be considered: the danger of going native and blindly adopting the narrative spread by

[391] See René Moelker, 'Being one of the Guys or the Fly on the Wall?', in *Routledge Handbook of Research Methods in Military Studies*, ed. Joseph Soeters, Patricia M Shields, and Sebastiaan Rietjens (Abingdon: Routledge, 2014). p 109-114.

[392] Bray, 'Ethnographic Approaches' p 302f.

[393] Robert Yin elaborates on the need to handle daily life events in the field and prepare for frictions that can affect the interview. Although his language implicitly calls for more controlled procedures (positivist), his remarks are nevertheless vital for a research project focused on understanding, such as this one. See Yin. p 86-102.

a friend or compatriot.[394] When engaging Israeli generals (and senior civil equivalents), a mitigating factor is often put into action by default: a signature feature of the Israeli general (or admiral) is to be a free agent —an autarkic actor who knows how to act instead of waiting for orders.[395] Broadly generalising, they are groomed to function as independent vagabonds — individualised actors, constantly moving to ensure maximum freedom of action within their frame. There is no perceived 'party line' to which these persons are loyal. They are faithful to their nation and formations by assuring *freedom* within their area of operations.[396] Assuring such sometimes require manipulation and cunning action that would not always be welcome in Western, rigid military organisations. Shimon Naveh elaborates:

> *'[Generals] they write doctrine and apply doctrine, but they should also be the first to destroy it and create a new one [...] [thus] there is no place for doctrine at the General staff level. It is an abomination [...] the whole point is to maintain degrees of freedom...'*[397]

This fact, combined with a societal trait that favours dialogue and discussion, means that there are constant turf battles and often diverging opinions, which reduce the risk of being exposed and misled by a singular, distorted line of argument.

As a researcher, these facts make things easier and more difficult at the same time: *easier*, as in more exciting and more straightforward to recognise 'talking points' or convergent narrative features they might have been instructed to feed me with; *more complex,* from at least two aspects: I, as in much more challenging to generalise, frame and thematise converging-or collective opinions; II, due to the autarkic [independent] character of the interlocutors, means that there exists a sometimes a tangible interactor-rivalry which must be considered, not least when extending the network through contacts functioning as gate-keepers or door openers allowing access to this closed entity.[398]

Drawing on Susanna Campbell, fieldwork in a conflict environment has been conducted to support this thesis simply because it '*...is a crucial explanatory tool that connects global and local security issues...'* [399] Employing this tool effectively requires

[394] See Emerson, Fretz, and Shaw, *Writing Ethnographic Fieldnotes*. p 2ff; and Moelker, 'Being one of the Guys or the Fly on the Wall?' p 109-114; see also reflexivity in the sense of interrogation between oneself and the field, in Townsend-Bell, 'Being True and Being You: Race, Gender, Class, and the Fieldwork Experience'. p 314.

[395] To act instead of waiting for orders, see Luttwak and Shamir, *The Art of Military Innovation.* p 46.

[396] Degrees of freedom, see Graicer, 'Self Disruption'. p 28ff, 34ff.

[397] Gracier, 'Beware of the Power of the Dark Side'. p 34.

[398] See Denscombe, *Forskningshandboken [The Good Research Guide - for Small-Scale Research Projects].* p 103ff; for more on the gatekeepers' ability to steer my research as access is limited. See Müller-Wille, 'Doing Military Research in Conflict Environments'. p 41f. For more on the implications of gaining access, see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 42f.

[399] Campbell, 'Ethics of Research in Conflict Environments'. p 91.

you as a researcher to function as an 'auto-ethnographer', i.e., a participant-observer, constantly reflecting on how you change when engaging the environment and in dialogue with its agents.[400]

Entering the research environment and the elite congregation engaged can be tricky, especially in a military context, which is natural given the sensitive and sometimes secret nature of the milieu. However, with the proper [sensible] approach, equal portions of patience and flexibility, the 'good' gatekeepers can be found.[401] However, I am confident that the following four aspects have been helpful in establishing my network of contacts within the IDF and closely affiliated organisations: First, as someone from a liberal democracy, I belong to the same [western] family of nations as the Israelis identify themselves with. Second, enjoying the possibility to employ, exploit- and use my military background and the possible future use my research can contribute to has meant owning a positional feature that has helped me to fit in, get access to participate, and be accepted almost like a semi-insider;[402] Third, and echoing Ben-Ari & Levi, my ability to engage in discussions related to Operational Art provides me with additional credibility and subsequent acceptance as I master the same professional language as my partners.[403] Put differently, what is referred to here is what Brinkmann and Kvale call subject matter knowledge,[404] which has been essential in the Israeli military environment because of their emphasis, or promotion of practical experience ahead of theoretical knowledge.[405] Fourth, I am a flexible person with little need to show off. Therefore, I have no problem acting as the listener, allowing myself to 'be taught' by the interlocutors if the situation and the outcomes would benefit from it. However, sometimes this can lead to temporary self-deception about avoiding defending certain positions, which could harm the prospects of a good conversation and future insights.[406]

At the same time, the people involved are generally very frank, and I need to organise my thoughts to respond and argue positions if asked. Therefore, it is difficult to remain neutral in the Israeli setting; opinions matter, and you are assumed to hold one. This highlights the importance of thorough preparation and being ready to participate in discussions, which helps you feel confident and competent in your research.[407] While starting fieldwork, I quickly realised that the most effective way

[400] Ibid. p 92; for reflexivity, see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 40ff.

[401] Access and gatekeepers, see Ben-Ari and Levy, 'Getting Access to the Field'. p 13f; Denscombe, *Forskningshandboken [The Good Research Guide - for Small-Scale Research Projects]*. p 103-107.

[402] Accepted participation, see Bohm, *On Dialogue*. p 98f; see also Emerson, Fretz, and Shaw, *Writing Ethnographic Fieldnotes*; for additional reasoning related to the insider/outsider perspective, see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 42f; and Yin, *Fallstudier - Design Och Genomförande [Case Study Research]*. p 120ff.

[403] Ben-Ari and Levy, 'Getting Access to the Field'. p 11.; Ben-Ari, 'Reflexivity: Potentially "Dangerous Liaisons"'. p 32; to properly fit into the environment, see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 42f

[404] Svend Brinkmann and Steinar Kvale, *Interviews- Learning the Craft of Qualitative Interviewing* (Los Angeles: SAGE Publications Inc., 2015). p 133.

[405] In this regard, see Van Creveld, *The Sword and the Olive*. p 168f; see also Shamir, *Transforming Command*. p 82f, 198f.

[406] Defending positions, see Bohm, *On Dialogue*. p 7-13.

[407] The problem of remaining neutral- the environment will affect you; see Townsend-Bell, 'Being True and Being You: Race, Gender, Class, and the Fieldwork Experience'. p 313.

to gather the desired information from their experience and insight is to let the interlocutor feel in control of the conversation, maintaining it as a dialogue rather than a monologue, as the latter can cause the person I am speaking to lose interest quickly.[408] Ultimately, the key to successful engagement is being an active listener and open to learning from others, which fosters a collaborative and respectful research environment.

Before increasing the resolution from the perspective of gaining access, another challenge worth mentioning is time and the planning horizon. The perception of time or the relationship to it is highly cultural and differs substantially in the environment studied compared to my point of departure. Iteration and the morphing (constantly changing) world, as described earlier as the ontological coordinates of this thesis, also highlight the connection between time and planning in the Israeli context. What I mean is that long-term planning does not apply in the same way as it does in the environment I initially refer to (Sweden). From impressions gathered during five periods of intensive fieldwork, appointments are not as definitive as in Sweden. According to Israeli colleagues, this is due to the persistent uncertainty that life in the region entails. Frankly, you never know if there will be an outbreak of war next week. Nonetheless, for a Lutheran army officer thoroughly accustomed to temporal discipline, changing a plan decided well in advance almost daily was initially a significant annoyance.

Casting the net

'Getting access', in less abstract terms, has been achieved by 'throwing hooks' in multiple directions to engage with possible interlocutors based on their previous or currently upheld positions within the IDF and closely related research bodies. Practically, this has been achieved through various media, including email, WhatsApp, Telegram, LinkedIn, and, of course, telephone. Doing so has taken considerable time and patience, mainly because of the need for prior research to ensure that the agents who possess the 'searched for experience' related to my quest are identified. The desired next step has comprised enlargement of the network based on two different logics: first, by what is referred to as chain-sampling or snowballing, facilitated by door-openers and provision of contacts;[409] Second, a kind of probing is done by engaging accessible agents based on convenience in terms of availability.[410] The latter does not always yield the desired results, but sometimes it does, which is sufficient given the time invested.

[408] See Emerson, Fretz, and Shaw, *Writing Ethnographic Fieldnotes*. p 171.

[409] Gatekeepers, see Denscombe, *Forskningshandboken [The Good Research Guide - for Small-Scale Research Projects]*. p 103ff; in this regard, see also Müller-Wille, 'Doing Military Research in Conflict Environments'. p 41f; and Ben-Ari and Levy, 'Getting Access to the Field'. p 13ff.

[410] Alan Bryman, *Samhällsvetenskapliga Metoder [Social Research Methods]*, third (Malmö: Liber AB, 2008). 196f

A colleague's introduction established one of the first contacts, a very fortunate possibility, as this contact has remained a contributor and an essential helper. The remaining network has been established as an initiative of my own, with support from a few key contacts. This effort has primarily been based on the probing method, coupled with continuous cognitive mapping of the broader 'congregation' of elite interlocutors. The latter has proven to depend on 'on-site engagement' with these agents, not least in terms of seeing, feeling, and realising tensions — and, on occasion, inter-agent rivalry — which is crucial to sorting out what is of real value and importance.[411] Initially, this is done intuitively by comparing messages and posing additional questions, and later through deeper reflection, analysis and subsequent thematisation.

At this point, it is important to emphasise that the material, namely the individuals involved, often referred to as 'they', 'the congregation', or 'the Israeli general', is by no means a homogenous group but consists of highly individualised agents belonging to a large organisation. Consequently, these seemingly generalising labels can be problematic if you expect the claims made to represent the entire organisation. However, while no ambitions of generalisation are claimed,[412] the interlocutors engaged are argued to constitute a comprehensive congregation based on their service periods, diverse experiences, and the positions they have upheld in the past and present. Information supporting this claim is available in Appendix 1.

The probing effort, along with interlocutors who introduced me to other potential agents to engage, ultimately led to my establishing contact with the IDF Generals' Course-Strategema, located at the Dayan Base in Ramat Hasharon, northern Tel Aviv. In this institution, which operates under the authority of the head of the Israeli National Defence College, generals (and senior civil officials) designated for higher command or critical roles are trained to become cunning and autarkic operators capable of acting creatively instead of waiting for orders. The Strategema director and his compatriot were to become my recurrent dialogue partners, research contributors and door-openers. Acquiring this kind of access, Denscombe explains, means not only passing the eye of the needle but also being trusted with insight and access.[413] This kind of access not only makes research easier, but also requires highly conscious navigation to ensure that both the research objectives are met adequately while trust is maintained.

So, what do the door openers gain from this? From my perspective as a researcher, this effort can be described with many superlatives in my favour. However, what has been most striking about my Israeli hosts and several of their compatriots is their

[411] On-site participation, see Johannessen and Tufte, *Introduktion till Samhällsvetenskaplig Metod [Introduction to Methods of Social Sciences]*. p 119f.

[412] Giampietro Gobo and Lukas Marciniak, 'What Is Ethnography?', in *Qualitative Research*, ed. David Silverman (London: SAGE Publications Ltd, 2016), 103–120.

[413] To be trusted, see Denscombe, *Forskningshandboken [The Good Research Guide - for Small-Scale Research Projects]*. p 105; see also Moelker, 'Being one of the Guys or the Fly on the Wall?' p 114.

willingness and interest in exploring my project and engaging with it. This has cost them many hours, both in terms of preparation and by practically participating in ongoing dialogues on Strategy and Operational Art. These circumstances have led me to find myself in a very positive research environment. However, the more assistance I receive, the higher the demands on my reflexivity skills, meaning that I must critically and continuously reflect on my role and its meaning.[414] Am I being used? In what way? Is it acceptable, or should I adjust my approach? These questions have no definitive answers, as they depend on the context, personal insight, integrity, and the research objective.

That said, my professional responsibility is to reflect and ask myself: why are they putting all this effort in? When directly confronted with this question, it has been done for a combination of reasons: first, out of mutual curiosity and interest in what an outsider pursuing an exciting subject can provide in terms of different perspectives on Strategy and Operational Art; second, it is also part of a conscious effort to offer me as an outsider a comprehensive picture to bring back, not only from a military professional perspective but also from a societal one. A significant motivation for the latter is the fact that Israel is a somewhat isolated entity, constantly needing to build and maintain friendly relationships globally. The fact that Sweden is a small, yet modern and liberal actor with a notable voice on the international stage likely also contributes to this motivation.

This latter incentive raises warning signs, calling for caution and substantial self-reflection during all stages of related work: collection, analysis, and writing. To ensure effective handling of these issues, a substantial amount of field notes has been written throughout, ensuring the ability for retrospective reflection. Moreover, it has also required recurring discussions with supervisors and peers complemented by helpful feedback from outsider's review of article drafts. All of this aims to ensure an as objective and independent report as possible. The risks and implications of being used as a mouthpiece must be regularly assessed during the material processing and report writing. Finally, mutual interests and mastery of a common language (the operational) have contributed to what Townsend-Bell calls a proper fit in the environment.[415] To achieve this, being well-prepared to engage in dialogue on topics related to Strategy and Operational Art has proven to be essential. In this context, the latter involves discussing and examining different aspects. At the same time, being well-read does not necessarily mean being able to 'throw references' to literature, as doing so can even create a sense of contempt towards you. This is especially true if you lack practical experience in operational engagements. Therefore, what matters in this environment is practical experience—and second, the ability to engage wisely in dialogue. From my experience, the latter is very

[414] Reflexivity see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 41f; see also Ben-Ari and Levy, 'Getting Access to the Field'. p 16.

[415] Townsend-Bell, 'Being True and Being You: Race, Gender, Class, and the Fieldwork Experience'. p 311; for more about being an insider, see Deschaux-Dutard, 'Methods in Defence Studies'. p 40ff.

different from showing off your academic skills; rather, it involves arguing from your perspective while demonstrating a mature mind.

Having addressed the importance of practical engagement and informed dialogue, we now turn to the ethical considerations that underpin this research project.

Research Ethics

As described when outlining the information collection process, trust is critical,[416] and avoiding harm, humiliation, or even annoyance of the interlocutor or interviewee is imperative.[417] Although there are differing views on how to handle confidentiality and its significance in preventing harm to interlocutors or informants, for me, the information itself will never be so crucial that I would betray the person helping me with my research in a way that could negatively impact them in the future.[418] However, it must be emphasised that the decision on what to write or publish is made solely by this author based on a continuous reflexive process that considers all relevant aspects, not only the ethical ones. This is important to highlight as informal expectations regarding the research and subsequent publications may exist.[419]

Once again, echoing Markus Göransson, what has become very clear from my experience conducting dialogue-like interviews in the Israeli context is that instructions reflecting highly formal interview methods do not always work as intended in the literature. I realised early on that much more flexibility is needed in this cultural setting.[420] Because of this, reflexivity becomes even more important. Therefore, I must constantly reflect on the content of my writings and the ethical and moral implications of sharing personal information. A more effective way to do this is by using what Baez refers to as friendly critical informants — people who can help us think things through.[421] A more profound elaboration and description of a practical method developed and employed to support this purpose is provided in the forthcoming section, 'Mitigation methods'.

[416] See Thomson and Kamler, *Writing for Peer Reviewed Journals- Strategies for Getting Published*. p 122.

[417] In this regard, see Baez, 'Confidentiality in Qualitative Research'. p 42ff.

[418] For related reasoning, see Baez. p 44ff; see also Ben-Ari and Levy, 'Getting Access to the Field'. p 15. This

[419] Gatekeepers, Negotiations and Expectations, see Ibid. p 12-15.

[420] Göransson, 'The Interview as a Cultural Performance and the Value of Surrendering Control'. p 53f.

[421] Baez, 'Confidentiality in Qualitative Research'. p 54.

Controversial context

> '…many studies of the Israeli military that apply available social psychological theories pertaining to leadership, discipline or cohesion miss the wider political situation of a military occupation that influences the behavior of soldiers'.[422]

Ben-Ari's words highlight the deep discrepancies concerning the state of Israel, its relationship with occupied territories, and the prospects of a future two-state solution with the Palestinian entity. Whether acknowledged or not, these facts require careful consideration, particularly given the rising global polarisation following the ongoing conflict in the region, especially in Gaza, given the very high number of civilian casualties accumulating.

Due to this situation, I cannot simply relax and assume that the thesis's overall empirical phase concluded before the war began. I still need to recognise these tensions and differing opinions as additional layers of complexity that demand deeper and more dedicated reflexivity. Ignoring this could hinder a key aim of this thesis: to examine and learn from the Israeli operational environment, its lack of Depth, and its paradoxical track record. Therefore, given the global divide and the conflicting narratives surrounding this issue, some may argue that this project is ethically problematic because of the immense suffering caused by the ongoing war, which started on 7 October 2023. Although this thesis does not investigate the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, any such opinions are nonetheless acknowledged and supplemented through ongoing and thorough reflexivity; the research objectives remain to be pursued as planned.

What are the ethical implications of studying Israel/IDF as a paradigmatic case in relation to ongoing events and civilian suffering in Gaza?

It is reasonable to assume that doing so is problematic, at least for some individuals, as it will require detaching from the daily events flooding the media to adopt a broader perspective that concentrates entirely on Operational Art and Depth. However, for some, this may still be insufficient, raising questions about the ethics of concluding this project given the suffering occurring, and also in light of the severe critique and especially the genocidal accusations Israel has faced for its conduct during the Swords of Iron Operation following the 7th October assault by Hamas.[423]

[422] Ben-Ari, 'Reflexivity: Potentially "Dangerous Liaisons"'. p 33.

[423] While respecting the unprecedented casualties pertaining to the Gaza Campaign, the IDF's high ambitions regarding Just War should not be forgotten in the media storm that engulfs the current war. For related information, see The Times: 'The Former NATO Commander Investigating the IDF War on Gaza', *European Leadership Network, ELNET*, September 2024, https://elnetwork.eu/press/former-nato-commander-investigating-war-on-gaza/; see also: Marilyn Stern, 'John Spencer on Israel's Urban War in Gaza: A Technical Analysis', Middle East Forum, no. January 24 (2024); and Israel Defence Forces, IDF, *Our Mission & Our Values*. https://www.idf.il/en/mini-sites/our-mission-our-values/

Here, it is crucial to emphasise that this thesis does not investigate the Gaza War at all, from either perspective. Instead, it concentrates on Israeli Operational Art in a broader context. It does so unilaterally, explicitly excluding the Palestinian viewpoint, as none of the objectives or ambitions aim to understand or explain the conflict itself. Nonetheless, a key feature of a paradigmatic case is that it sets a standard, a notion that may be provocative in itself, perhaps especially in this context. Given this potential, it subsequently demands profound sensitivity, reflexivity, and active detachment from real-time events to enable effective research focused firmly on Operational Art, while steering clear of political debates or deadlocks concerning ongoing events. Thus, the issue at hand concerns Depth, and how Israel has managed to address its lack of Depth in a substantially hostile neighbourhood. Furthermore, that question requires a completely different scope than the Gaza War and the immense suffering taking place there.

Do current events also envelop the phenomenon I am studying in a dark or negative aura?

Unfortunately, this has been the case since the start of the current war, although the responses I am receiving fluctuate, mostly aligning with the real-time media picture and the broader narrative it constructs.[424] In this context, the comments I receive can vary significantly depending on the exact moment and the current situation between Israel and Hamas. We must also remember that many military concepts in use have been studied and developed through examples closely related to other tragic events. Notably, MT and combined arms employment, as well as mission command tactics, are all important military concepts still used operationally today, although their modern origins are closely linked to the horrors of World War II.

At the core, studying Israel and the IDF is controversial for many people, not least because of the extensive diversions caused and maintained by the Israeli-Palestinian question. Nevertheless, although it can be sensible and sometimes contentious, examining Israeli Operational Art and, subsequently, Depth offers many insightful perspectives to consider and develop. Given the scope and issues of this thesis, this underpins the rationale for this study, regardless of personal preferences or objections.

Therefore, in the face of turbulence emerging in the modern world, the wise approach for a soldier-scholar belonging to the armed forces of a geographically limited actor is to learn from others' experiences. Even for a NATO member like Sweden, a surprise attack from an aggressor would likely necessitate the ability to endure alone for some time while awaiting support from the alliance. When

[424] Having been asked to engage with various Swedish national media outlets on more than 190 occasions to comment on issues related to the ongoing war, I can confidently acknowledge that my project implicitly faces a shifting scale of grey depending on real-time events, although it does not even study the ongoing Gaza War.

preparing for this, an effective approach to the issue of Depth is needed.[425] Still, the Israeli case remains a highly contentious issue that divides people worldwide. Therefore, extreme caution and reflexivity are essential when discussing and commenting on the matter.

Interviews and Recordings, Notes and Transcripts

As an enterprise heavily reliant on empirical, firsthand material, effective management of notes, p.m., and interview data becomes essential. Where possible, interviews and conversations have been recorded and transcribed. The latter, a particularly time-consuming task given the often fragmented language, has been facilitated by an efficient software tool called Otter.ai.[426] This programme was suitable when the content discussed was not confidential and personal details were left out. When recording was not possible, due to reasons such as unsuitable surroundings or sensitive/secret material, simple paper notes have been the preferred method.[427] Following these non-recorded occasions, it has been essential to review the notes on the same day, or at least within the following days, to ensure that the contents align with your other impressions.[428]

During the recorded dialogues, notes were also taken. This maintains redundancy while offering a preferred, personal approach to learning, organising, and translating the spoken content into the project's logic. Post-interview reflection on the written notes rather than transcripts has been preferred when working with the material. This facilitates a better retrospective and connection to the situation and its context, which are vital for accurately understanding the content. That said, the effort invested in transcribing the recorded sessions is not wasted; it provides additional benefits: firstly, as it involves a time-consuming translation from English, often with a strong Hebrew accent, it encourages another round of significant reflection and a deeper learning experience; secondly, when transcribed into written form, it enables the use of NVIVO software to sort, categorise, and thematise the material. This has proven to be very helpful when trying to establish themes or locate specific arguments or quotations within the written aspects of the project.[429]

More than 50 interviews and several informal conversations have been conducted to support this project. These took place in various settings, including military premises (bases, headquarters), public spaces, former battlegrounds during field excursions, and often in the interlocutors' homes. Generally, each interview lasted

[425] On conducting urgent research of high quality that leads to valuable knowledge, see Swedish Research Council, 'Good Research Practice 2024 [God Forskningssed]' (Stockholm, 2024). p 12f.

[426] Implications of language and the fact that perfect translations are non-existent, see Müller-Wille, 'Doing Military Research in Conflict Environments'. p 48.

[427] Field notes, see Emerson, Fretz, and Shaw, *Writing Ethnographic Fieldnotes*. p 17, 48ff.

[428] Ibid.

[429] Virginia Braun and Victoria Clarke, *Thematic Analysis - A Practical Guide* (London: SAGE Publications Ltd, 2022). p 76-91; see also Alvinius, Borglund, and Larsson, *Tematisk Analys : Din Handbok till Fascinerande Vetenskap.* p 79-90.

between 1 and 1.5 hours, although some — especially those during excursions — were significantly longer. Before each interview, the interlocutor was briefed in advance about the project, either in written form via an informative note (Appendix 3) or verbally by collaborators and door-openers. Consequently, nothing was ad hoc; the interlocutor had decided well in advance what to share and how willing they were to do so, making both the interview and the time-sensitive task of transcription more relaxed and effective. On many occasions, the interlocutor reconnected with a theme, a title, or other cues prior to the interview, indicating how they intended to contribute within the scope of the project. Generally, the interviews were conducted in English; however, simultaneous translation from Hebrew to English was occasionally required, a service provided by close and trusted partners.

After fieldwork and information gathering, the process continues with analysing, sorting, and categorising material, both intuitively (analogously) and more systematically (digitally) using NVIVO software. As a result of this dual approach, with the scope, problem, and level of abstraction in mind,[430] it has been possible to formulate the various angles that make up the attached articles and commence the write-up. In doing so, a third software product, Grammarly PRO, has been used to address the limitations of non-native English skills, which have been repeatedly evident during the peer review of articles and seminar presentations of the attached writings.

Mitigation method(s)

Although the information I received was shared voluntarily during conversations, people can still communicate things they did not mean to reveal. Additionally, misunderstandings can occur, partly due to imperfect language. If, during the write-up, I notice that some information seems or feels inappropriate in terms of secrecy or sensitivity, I ask further questions to clarify.

Some individuals may question the effort made to protect those participating in this project while claiming that studying this environment and Israel's military conduct is ethically inappropriate. However, beyond generously contributing, these individuals constitute a vital source of knowledge and a prominent feature that makes this thesis unique. Moreover, everyone contributing to any research (this one in particular) should be protected, regardless of whether the broader issue is controversial.[431]

That said, a practical method to manage or minimise the risk of publishing content that could offend or be perceived negatively by any involved parties has been established: two of the most trusted and influential confidants have reviewed the

[430] The altercation of the level of abstraction has constituted a triangulating-resembling effort utilised to ensure a comprehensive coverage of the studied issue. See 'Funnel of Abstraction' in the forthcoming chapter.

[431] Protect contributing individuals from harm, see Baez, 'Confidentiality in Qualitative Research'. p 41ff.

article drafts before submission to various journals. This has been done to ensure that the final product accurately conveys the intended messages, reducing potential distortions caused by cultural or linguistic misunderstandings. This approach provides an additional layer of protection for participants and contributors by preventing misinterpretations that could misrepresent the issue.[432]

This method has been successfully employed during the pre-submission revisions of the last three articles, as well as after peer review, resubmission, and prior to publication. Additionally, the method illustrates the importance of having a trusted organisational insider who not only acts as a host or gatekeeper but also occasionally accompanies interviews. This approach allows for the possibility of conducting sensitive discussions retrospectively, ensuring that neither national security concerns nor the safety of participating individuals or gatekeepers/door-openers are compromised. It is also crucial for the door opener, as they risked their reputation by trusting me with insider information and introducing me to a group that would otherwise be inaccessible to an outsider.[433]

At this point, it is important to emphasise the opposite: reflexivity and my independence as a researcher. That said, explicit turf battles have been rare. However, a few have been addressed implicitly throughout article production. No matter how one approaches this, continuous reflexivity is required, as fieldwork, the environment itself and particularly, first-hand engagement with influential individuals *will* affect you.[434] This necessitates a reflective and reflexive exercise where I always have the last word while simultaneously considering that *I try not to bite the hand that feeds me.*[435]

The engaged congregation is not a homogeneous group in any way. Among the interlocutors, several issues create tensions that expose differing opinions, internal turf battles, and, at times, disagreements. When interlocutors occasionally do not wish to be cited as an official reference to a statement or the facts obtained, the source has been labelled 'anonymous', when this has been confirmed as acceptable by the source. Further elaboration on this topic shows that it is also vital to understand cultural differences in this area: in the Israeli setting, individuals admitting to being interviewed are, to a much greater extent, expected to recognise that if they agree to be interviewed, they will be quoted. This became clear when collaborators grew frustrated when repeatedly asked to confirm permission to quote or cite them in forthcoming [open] publications.

[432] Mitigation of the fact that perfect translations are non-existent see Müller-Wille, 'Doing Military Research in Conflict Environments'. p 48.

[433] Denscombe, *Forskningshandboken [The Good Research Guide - for Small-Scale Research Projects]*. p 103ff.

[434] Involvement and Detachment, trust and nativity, see Moelker, 'Being one of the Guys or the Fly on the Wall?' p 111ff.

[435] A dilemma that may arise in this regard concerns accurate disclosure of facts *or*- exposing the interlocutor to potential harm. See Baez, 'Confidentiality in Qualitative Research'. p 35f.

Now, let us move on from the methods section and focus on the report, specifically the findings presented in the thesis articles, followed by a summarising paragraph. However, before doing so, we should remind ourselves of the information provided in the first footnote regarding research ethics.

This chapter is a compilation that combines several contributing sections into a cohesive whole, as demonstrated by this thesis. Since this is a compilation thesis where the main body ("Kappa") aims to synthesise findings from four research articles, there are natural similarities and some overlaps between the main text and the articles. All material in this thesis, including the main body and the four articles, is the author's original work.

Report- Articles I-IV

This chapter outlines the compilation of articles and explains their relationship both to the thesis as a whole and to one another. From a content perspective, this is achieved in three steps. First, some general thoughts and remarks are provided to reconnect with the scope of the problem, while also offering sense-making comments to assist the reader. Additionally, a few notes on methodology are included as the inter-article relationship is described through what is called the funnel of abstraction. Second, each article is presented in an operationalised manner, focusing on its *introduction, method*, and *conclusion*. Finally, the core insights of all four articles are synthesised and summarised.

The attached articles and their relationship

When considered together, these articles form a triangulating effort focused on Depth. The primary feature used to explore different aspects of the topic is an adjustment of the abstraction level.[436]

The funnel of abstraction is designed as a visual aid to better explain the relationship between articles and how the level of abstraction shifts to reflect different aspects of Depth. It begins broad and shallow, with a theoretical piece that closely aligns with the review part of this compilation chapter. Then, the level of abstraction decreases, indicating a shift from the general to the more specific and tangible. Here, it is also important to remember that there is a cumulative aspect to this inter-article relationship too, where key features from one article are sometimes further developed in subsequent ones, which supports the overall investigation.

[436] Related to the purpose of triangulation, see Larsson, 'Om Kvalitetskriterier i Kvalitativa Studier [About Quality Criteria in Qualitative Studies]'. p 350f.

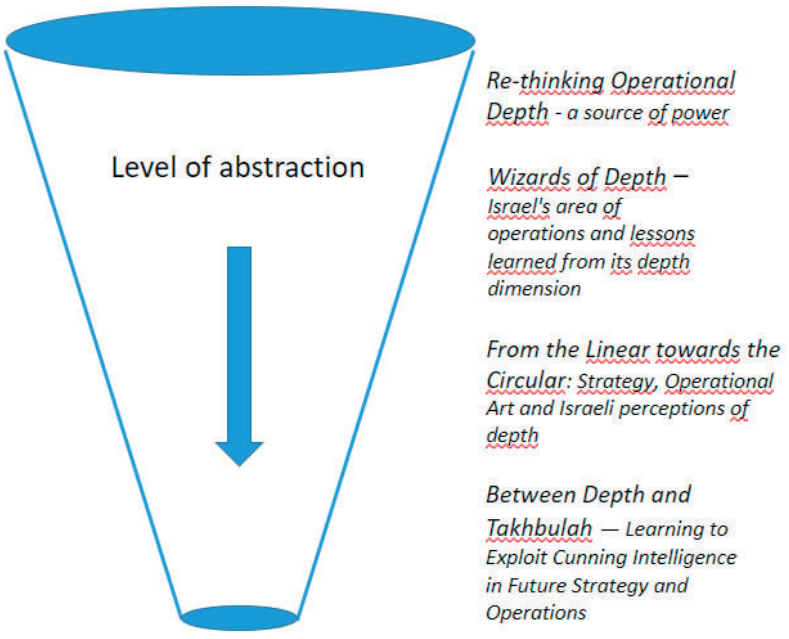


Figure 1. The Funnel of Abstraction: From the broad and shallow to the deep and narrow. (The author's image)

With this complementary, abstraction-altering relationship in mind, let us turn to the articles, starting with the first, where the core subject is approached with a broad scope but limited depth.

Article I

Re-thinking Operational Depth – A source of power

General Content

This article explores the urgent issue of the inferior actor problem, analysing how to manage the lack or minimal presence of physical Depth when facing a more capable adversary. This issue is especially pertinent in the current geopolitical context concerning asymmetrical deterrence, which refers to an inferior actor's capacity to dissuade a more powerful aggressor from attacking by maintaining a sufficiently high cognitive threshold.

So, how can an inferior actor achieve deterrence? The article explores this question by presenting an innovative approach to Operational Depth as a source of power or actor resilience that can be applied differently at various levels of warfare. This cognitive perspective, an auxiliary approach to Depth, allows us to exploit better possibilities from an inferior viewpoint beyond limited physical space- and resources; thus, '*…wars are won or lost in the cognitive, rather than in the physical, domain […] mastery of the physical domain of war is no longer sufficient'.*[437] This emphasis on the cognitive perspective offers a valuable lens through which to reconsider established assumptions, encouraging innovative and forward-thinking approaches to military strategy. This article suggests practical strategies better suited to modern conditions. By incorporating the cognitive perspective into Depth, it highlights a previously overlooked approach and provides an alternative pathway when there is limited geographical space or weight in metal, thereby promoting effective power competition. This research offers essential insights to help manage the complexities of modern warfare, ensuring you are well-prepared for future challenges.

Method

The first article in a series of four is a qualitative, theoretical piece. It is based on desk research, which examines the concept of Depth with a broad scope. It reviews previous approaches to Depth and subsequently identifies and outlines five main trajectories. Using these trajectories as reference points, the article explores real-world examples alongside the cognitive perspective to pursue and present alternative views on Depth. Methodologically, incorporating the cognitive perspective reveals a methodological shift that reflects the logic of a conceptual extension.

[437] Blackwell, 'Deterrence at the Operational Level of War'. p 46 (referring to Art Cebrowski).

Conclusions

The article concludes that Operational Depth can be influenced and expanded through cognitive strategies at all levels of war, with practical implications for modern warfare. It suggests that the division into levels should be ignored and that Depth should be seen as a flexible resource depending on the actor's available assets and skills. Moreover, with cognitive extension, the article supports a theoretical understanding of Depth, referencing asymmetric deterrence alongside an approach that goes beyond traditional aspects of manoeuvre warfare while remaining within the indirect approach and its multiplying effects. It finds that current methods in cyber and information domains create opportunities for near-peer competition without physically encroaching on the opponent's territory. Implicitly, it underlines the importance of self-image and constructivism in achieving effective results.

The article concludes that Operational Depth depends on an actor's ability to project power, absorb power, and maintain the ability to manoeuvre available coercive tools—or assets—along physical or cognitive, offensive, and defensive lines of operation. Using a boxer analogy, which includes a strong jab, a powerful hook, and enduring abdominals, the article clarifies this relationship while reminding us that a powerful hook, from the perspective of Depth, does not have to depend on physical strength.

Article II

Wizards of Depth – Israel's area of operations and lessons learned from its depth dimension

General Content

This second article in the series adopts a broad approach, arguing that Depth must be recognised as a societal construct that extends across all domains, going beyond strictly military perspectives.[438] Achieving this requires a comprehensive effort based on resources mustered by society, exploiting the relationship between state apparatus and war machine,[439] to achieve synergetic or multiplying effects needed when resources are limited. A critical resource in this regard is a resilient society where everyone knows how to contribute when required.

This empirical article, based on fieldwork, examines Israel's capacity to compensate for a deficiency in physical Depth while addressing the question: 'How does Israel, a

[438] See, for example, Multi-Domain Operations (MDO), U.S. Army, 'The U.S. Army in Multi-Domain Operations 2028'; Joint All-Domain Operations (JADO), Lockheed Martin 2023).

[439] See Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *Nomadology: The War Machine* (Seattle: Wormwood Distribution, 2010).

state with severe geographical/physical limitations, create and maintain its operational depth?' It specifically analyses the experiences from the 2006 war between Israel and Hezbollah to enhance the understanding of how Depth can be interpreted.

Because of the detailed demands of the operational environment, the article reduces artificial boundaries, such as those between civil and military contexts or different levels of warfare, making 'Depth' with or without a prefix interchangeable.

Method

This article adopts a qualitative approach, heavily relying on extensive fieldwork and interviews with practitioners in Israel. At the time of submission, four research visits had been completed. During these visits, the operational environment and societal culture were examined in great depth through guided staff rides, numerous elite dialogues, and exposure to intensive personal training in cutting-edge Israeli Operational Art with experts from the IDF's Generals course. To facilitate this study, previous research constructs an analytical framework—or presumed recipe for Depth. This framework, augmented by a cognitive extension of the subject, is subsequently applied to engage with around 20 operational actors (Generals), effectively sharing insights necessary to refine the framework through abductive reasoning. Furthermore, extracting additional insight from the Israeli Depth perspective requires balancing two different perceptions—or operational reference points. The article introduces the linear, reverse-engineered (forward-rearward) perspective of Depth, alongside the circular (project-absorb-manoeuvre) emphasis, highlighting emergence to achieve this goal.

Conclusions

The article concludes that Depth, usually understood in a linear way, is better treated circularly as a trinity that balances the abilities to project, absorb, and manoeuvre available coercive assets along offensive and defensive lines of operation. It offers a broader understanding of how depth can be perceived, especially when physical prerequisites are limited. This is achieved through a dialectical approach that mediates linear perceptions of Depth, dominating previous research with its proposed circular alternative.

The article finds that Forward Depth in modern Israel is mainly achieved through stand-off fires and a continuous, systematic disruption of hostile capabilities that pose a threat to the state. The political leadership prefers this method over ground manoeuvres, as it permits the immediate stopping of an ongoing operation if needed. This highlights the complex relationship between the democratic state and its war machine, emphasising the need for a more comprehensive approach to Depth, as

vital military capabilities can unexpectedly become 'off-limits' due to political restrictions.[440]

The Rearward Depth, largely artificial, relies on advanced technology. It offers essential early warning and features a sophisticated, multi-layered interceptor system designed to neutralise most incoming hostile munitions. Moreover, it heavily depends on strong and capable municipalities where individuals understand their roles in critical situations, thereby enhancing an important facet of cognitive Depth and exemplifying the comprehensive approach to Depth introduced in this chapter. Similar to the Israeli scenario, limited physical space can be beneficial, allowing quick shifts in direction of effort. However, the main concern is the expectation gap; when operational objectives differ from those of the population (or the international community)—often influenced by historical perceptions—the risk of cognitive culmination becomes substantial.

Article III

From the Linear towards the Circular: Strategy, Operational Art and Israeli perceptions of depth

General Content

This article explores Strategy and Operational Art, primarily based on extensive fieldwork conducted over more than two years. It examines the Israeli approach to warfare and operational execution, thereby enriching the study of Operational Art by providing significant insights into Israel's complex relationship with Depth—an essential and lasting element of national defence and military operations. The article explains how Israel, located in a challenging neighbourhood with limited physical Depth, requires a Strategic and Operational Art approach that goes beyond linearity, offering valuable insights and operational reference points. Building on the previous two articles, this piece further investigates Depth from a cognitive perspective. It also elaborates further on the circular definition of Depth [project-absorb-manoeuvre] alongside its linear counterpart, showing the two as different viewpoints of Operational Art.

Method

This article adopts a qualitative approach, mainly relying on repeated fieldwork and interviews (dialogues) with operational practitioners (generals) in Israel. Five research visits have been carried out, each lasting between one and three weeks.

[440] See: Deleuze and Guattari, *Nomadology: The War Machine*.

This includes ongoing email and text conversations with some dialogue partners on a weekly (or sometimes even daily) basis.

Drawing on insights from these fieldwork periods, this article uses thematic analysis to highlight key trajectories within a substantial body of collected material. The project has been predominantly ethnographic, with a strong emphasis on understanding the broader context and its nuances caused by cultural differences. Thanks to the author's dual affiliation, the on-site engagement can be described as a participatory dialogue, as defined by David Bohm. This dynamic arises from being recognised as a 'semi-insider'.

Two generalised approaches to Operational Art (reference points) are derived from previous research to establish a foundation for a deeper understanding of the evolving nature of Operational Art and Depth. Subsequently, these approaches are utilised to clarify the suggested shift indicated by the article's title.

Conclusions

The article, especially its empirical section, uncovers findings that emphasise various Depth features beyond traditional physical and linear measures: instead of kilometres, Depth is more accurately evaluated based on the available freedom to act without restrictions in relation to the adversary. Furthermore, it shows that the most hesitant actor and obstacle to increasing this freedom within a structured operational system is the blue side—the dominant paradigm expressed through tradition, organisation, and doctrine.

Furthermore, considering the empirical findings and the evolving, ambiguous character of contemporary warfare, the article argues in favour of leaning towards the circular direction on a sliding scale between the two operational approaches presented. This approach improves the understanding of Depth as a manoeuvring system, represented by the circular model — a deliberately abstract feature designed to encourage creative use of whatever means are available in context. While supporting movement in a nonlinear direction, the article advocates cultivating a mindset that actively seeks anomalies and changes rather than stability and conformity. This may illustrate the difficult choice between stability and movement, which is not meant to be an absolute dichotomy but rather recognised as a relationship requiring mediation:

Thus, most militaries (and human societies) aim for continuity and stability, as a life in motion is generally undesirable; after episodes of turbulence, we quickly seek to return to the familiar—stability. However, to be prepared and effective, it is evident that the need to continuously move and explore anomalies, rather than conform to stable solutions, is essential. This demands not only imagination and ongoing learning but also a constant challenge and possibly manipulation of the cognitive

paradigm to prevent emerging disasters. Considering these implications, the circular perception, the cognitive extension, and the findings of this article, a revised definition of Depth is proposed: 'a manipulation of space, within a conceptually framed system of manoeuvre (one's own system and the rival's) seeking to exploit potential in one's favour through learning and self-transformation'.

Article IV

Between Depth and Takhbulah — Learning to Exploit Cunning Intelligence in Future Strategy and Operations

General Content

Like the preceding three articles, this one discusses Operational Art, focusing specifically on the aspect of Depth. It examines the Israeli operational concept of takhbulah, a deceptive two-stage theory—or operational philosophy—that relies on the changing nature of reality. It demonstrates a practical method for challenging military ideal models and rigid paradigms, showing how adherence to emergence and strategies beyond perceived boundaries—often stifling creativity—can serve as an effective cognitive Depth enhancer by unlocking potential already possessed. Using material collected during fieldwork in Israel, the article deduces, presents, and elaborates on the underlying logic of this operational approach. It analyses four real-world examples through the lens of this theory, clarifying the logic while offering a tangible method to create or extend available Depth cognitively.

Method

This is an empirical article that employs a qualitative methodology. It relies exclusively on recurring fieldwork in Israel; therefore, it is also an ethnographic endeavour. The ethnographic perspective of this article has a cumulative aspect, particularly as this theory is closely linked to cultural elements that require time to understand. However, while utilising this cumulative aspect, it primarily draws on a three-week on-site operational dialogue with the head of the IDF Generals Course. During this period, several additional interviews and conversations were held with generals experienced in employing takhbulah operationally. In addition to the interviews, guided staff rides were conducted to make sense of the theoretical perspective.

Conclusions

Ultimately, takhbulah involves undermining, disrupting, or dislocating your rival or enemy. However, it always begins with yourself: you challenge and manipulate your own thinking, the prevailing paradigm, doctrine, organisation, tradition, and not least, your own biases. By breaking free from these constraints, you can align with the flow of reality and betray the opponent by acting differently, at least temporarily. Employing takhbulah is highly contagious; once you venture beyond the mainstream and conventions, you will invariably do so. Furthermore, 'This is how we do things', a common refrain in [traditionalist] military settings, serves as perhaps the greatest trigger and incitement for a takhbulanee to pursue an opposite or entirely different course of action. At its core, takhbulah—the cunning engine of SOD—offers a highly effective method: a cognitive Depth-enhancer capable of maximising existing resources through indirect, cognitive manoeuvring.

Summary

Adding the pieces creatively — turning 1+1+1+1 into more than 4

Beyond proposing the conceptual extension and the circular definition of Depth used throughout the thesis, the first article identifies five main trajectories of previous research. It serves not only as a foundation for discussion in subsequent research but also as a significant contribution and addition to the review section of this chapter. Moreover, it provides examples of how Depth can be created using *available* abilities rather than traditional ones. The latter highlights the feature of self-manipulation and raises caution against employing old solutions in new operational frameworks. Thus, salient features of the empirical papers that effectively exploit that 'you know that I know that you know. . . '.[441]

The second article introduces the circular perspective to Depth for the first time, alongside the linear and circular perspectives on Operational Art. These contributions are further examined and utilised in the following two articles. Furthermore, beyond tangible examples of Depth-creating measures, this second article strengthens the existing body of research presented in this compilation chapter, particularly through the analytical tool provided and iteratively refined.

From the third article, the abstraction becomes more focused, clarifying what constitutes Depth from a cognitive perspective and how it can be exploited, thus becoming less blurry and more tangible. The same applies to the two perceptions of Operational Art, particularly the circular approach, which is an emerging theme throughout this thesis. The elaboration on these operational reference points presented in this article makes a significant contribution to the previous research

[441] Alastair Smith and Allan C Stam, 'Bargaining and the Nature of War', *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 48, no. 6 (2004). p 787.

section of this chapter, where key aspects are illuminated. The article emphasises the importance of continually seeking anomalies rather than conforming to stable solutions. This approach effectively highlights the need for imagination, ongoing learning, and a constant challenge, which may involve manipulating the friendly paradigm to prevent potential disasters. It is acknowledged, based on this article, that strategy serves as a cognitive response to a problem in one's mind—a short-lived product that requires constant evaluation to adapt to an evolving reality. The operation embodies its practical expression; thus, the two are essentially the same, articulated in two different languages interpreted through Operational Art.

The fourth article and the theory examined serve as the centrepiece and cunning engine of SOD. As such, it makes three main contributions to the thesis: First, through its logic of self-manipulation and disruption, it adds to this project by providing a tangible method for generating Depth cognitively. It does so by encouraging the exploitation of the prevailing paradigm—i.e., what is traditionally considered to be beyond the permissible.[442] Secondly, by embracing the potential that emerges from the course of reality and following the flow, it shows how the circular perspective offered by this thesis can be put into practice. Thirdly, as a key feature of SOD, this article itself represents a significant and essential contribution—a return to the theory section in this concluding part.

Ultimately, these four components are designed to work together, demonstrated by the funnel of abstraction shown above. Using cumulative logic, the thesis depends on all of them to provide something more meaningful than if they were considered separately. Nevertheless, these parts, including this compilation chapter, can certainly stand alone, though never with the same impact as when they are combined. Therefore, as we have seen, insights and conclusions from one article lead to another, and the logic they provide when considered together, which will be evident in the forthcoming section. That said, let us move beyond this report section and focus on the added value that emerges when these findings are revisited and connected to the problem.

[442] For related information regarding the 'paradigm', see Adamsky, The Culture of Military Innovation. p 20f; and Naveh, Schneider, and Challans, The Structure of Operational Revolution. p 26ff.

Results and Main Takeaways

This final chapter captures the core of the report, as presented in the articles, in relation to the framed problem, research question, theory, and previous research. It goes beyond a simple summary; it represents the culmination of careful research and analysis that makes a meaningful contribution to the field of Operational Art. This achievement is realised through two parts, where the first focuses on addressing the research questions based on the information from the report and the attached articles. The purpose of the second part is to demonstrate the thesis's conceptual contribution in relation to the previous research outlined. Following these sections is a concluding discussion.

The research Q

At this point, it is time to close the loop by returning our attention to the overarching research question:

How has the lack of Depth affected Israeli operational art and operational thinking?

…and the two sub-questions that provide the specific answers:

How is the lack of depth reflected in Israeli Operational Art?

How has it been resolved in IDF operational thinking?

This overarching research question and its sub-questions, or auxiliaries, have been more than just a starting point for the exploration. They have served as a vital thread woven throughout the entire fieldwork journey, progressively delving into the complexities of Operational Art with a goal of developing concepts. The answers to these questions were extracted by studying the operational thinking of a comprehensive congregation of Israeli Generals.[443] The next section begins with the first sub-question regarding the effects of the lack of depth in Israeli Operational Art.

[443] See Appendix 1.

How is the lack of depth reflected in Israeli Operational Art?

> *'...the depth of the enemy. It's the most easy place to act because the enemy also sends the best troops to the front [sic.]'.* [444]

In response to this question, it can be confidently concluded that, in the Israeli context, particularly among the generals approached during the fieldwork for this thesis, a significant interest in the concept of Depth exists. This may stem from various reasons. However, based on the insights gathered during fieldwork in this operational environment, it is clear that this interest goes beyond the basic fact that people generally desire what they do not possess. By reconnecting not only with the problem and the shortcomings of previous research but also with the theoretical points of departure, MT and SOD, the findings in this environment regarding Depth show a strong emphasis on cunning, disruptive, and indirect approaches, as well as continuous adaptation in response to emerging threats and anomalies. In other words, the characteristics observed are distinctly nonlinear in nature.

This first sub-question is primarily, but not exclusively, addressed through the research and subsequent report provided in the second article, 'Wizards of Depth'. [445] However, the answer also depends heavily on recurring personal engagement with the operational environment through various activities, which create a cumulative store of impressions built over time. Alongside considerable reflection and reflexivity during extended periods away from the field, these impressions have supported the necessary interpretation and subsequent sense-making through an outsider's perspective.

Armed with these impressions, while attempting to answer the question, illustrates how the Israeli lack of physical Depth is mitigated by a comprehensive approach that encompasses all aspects of society, not merely the swift and agile military capabilities to strike deep into enemy territory with lethal precision. Essentially, what we discuss adheres to a functional logic similar to the circular perception developed in this thesis, i.e., to make the most of what you have at your disposal, sometimes by altering the existing game rules that constrain creative thought.

Transgressing the boundaries between the civil and military spheres, as well as between the frontline and homeland, essential components of Israeli Depth encompass far more than friendly regional forces, unoccupied areas in enemy territories, short inner lines, an advanced, multi-layered interceptor system with

[444] Anders Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular: Strategy, Operational Art and Israeli Perceptions of Depth', *Unpublished manuscript*, 2025. p 21.

[445] The article is enabled and augmented by an analytic tool or recipe for Depth reliant on the first article, Re-thinking Operational Depth.

early warning capabilities, and a capable reserve force. Perhaps more importantly, it includes a resilient and prepared populace that knows how to act when the alarm sounds and can withstand disappointment when military objectives are not achieved as swiftly as anticipated. We discuss vital features that enable operational momentum and, conversely, prevent culmination. Ultimately, all these boundary-crossing aspects of Depth mentioned above reinforce the validity of treating it comprehensively, which is manifested in this thesis by capitalising the D instead of dividing it with traditional prefixes.[446]

Conceptually, the Israeli lack of physical Depth has been mitigated by the preemptive strike (or war) and the traditional security anchor, which includes early warning, deterrence, and powerful armed forces capable of acting offensively and winning decisively.[447] Thus, essentially adhering to a functioning logic prescribed in the Sanhedrin 72a part of the Talmud:

If Someone Comes to Kill You,

Rise Up and Kill Him First

While many aspects of Operational Art and the specific subject of Depth encountered in the Israeli operational environment differ substantially from this author's (Western) point of departure, not everything does. Thus, as described in the third article, perceptions of Depth are not always that complicated: 'Operational depths relate to the depth that you know, the world depth is relative, relative to something; it is how deep, or it is how high […] So in operational depths, it is always.., in Israel we refer to operations that are in the enemy depth […] So when you are talking on operational depth, it is forces that aiding the main effort in the front [sic]'.[448] This refers to a concept that is, in many ways, quite similar to the traditional perceptions of Depth found in previous research related to the subject. However, what notably differs from earlier studies (and the point of departure of this author) is the physical focus on the Forward side of the subject and the cognitive emphasis on emergence and cunning to maximise revenue with the least investment; essentially, the core meaning of the theoretical starting points combined.

Thus, concentrating limited resources in the Depth of the enemy's formation is seen as much more effective and cost-efficient. Especially in cognitive terms, as repeatedly demonstrated in the articles. Therefore, as stated in the second and third articles, going 'straight to the end' is logical and much more effective. However, when doing so, the objective should be to aim for empty, non-contested locations and go

[446] Tactical-, Operational-, and Strategic Depth

[447] Here, two things should be noted: first, (as described on p. 4 in the introduction) this conceptual trinity often referred to as the security anchor has been complemented in recent years by a fourth cornerstone- *Active defence*; second, during a period of the 21st century, an emphasis to contain treats as opposed to achieving a decisive victory has dominated.

[448] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 14.

back towards the enemy front line, thus '…give the enemy the ability to feel the team's success and then come from behind [sic]'. The motive to do so is logical, as Depth is the easiest place to act because the enemy also sends his best formations to the front.[449] At the bottom line, Depth can ensure a lot more freedom than the front, and operations conducted in Depth of the enemy formation can have residual (cognitive) effects, even if they are small or even partly unsuccessful.[450]

Having analysed this more practical and conceptual first sub-question, let us now focus on the distinct contribution offered by the second.

How has it [the lack of Depth] been resolved in IDF operational thinking?

> *'Depth [is] a way of thinking […] the mutual degree of freedom that you and your opponent share…' And to increase your depth, you: 'steal potential from the other side'.* [451]

Having studied the operational thinking of various experienced Israeli generals over recurring periods, answering this second sub-question is not easily summarised in a single sentence. The words in the third article offer some important clues, but not all. Despite the challenges, if one attempts to craft a concise, single-sentence answer based on the insights and knowledge gained during the research for the thesis's articles, it would suggest that the lack of physical space compels the Israeli Operator to maximise freedom to operate as he deems appropriate in response to the challenge posed by the adversary and the evolving situation.[452] Put even more bluntly, the straightforward answer encompasses much more than freedom in relation to the adversary. It would imply that the lack of Depth has fostered a cunning mindset that continuously strives to disrupt *any shackles that limit* the range of possible operational courses of action. Recurring references to 'shackles' that obstruct the freedom to choose how to operate include institutionalised features such as the prevailing paradigm, namely, doctrine, organisation, regulations, and things traditionally perceived as correct. Essentially, thinking this way is seen as a result of not just a lack of space, but also of living and working in a fast-changing, turbulent, and complex (largely hostile) neighbourhood. In other

[449] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 21; Ekholm, 'Wizards of Depth-Israel's Area of Operations and Lessons Learned from Its Depth Dimension'. p 6.

[450] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'p 21f.

[451] Ibid. p 18.

[452] Closely Related: 'Degrees of Freedom' as a qualitative measure of design enterprises; see Graicer, 'Self Disruption'. p 29.

words, it is a state of mind that develops in response to operational needs. From the thesis's fourth article, we learn that:

> *'... freedom [is] basically from the existing conventions, from the doctrinal convention. The impact of doctrine is lethal. It can be very powerful when it comes to exercising action. But when it comes to reframing your understanding, of appreciation, doctrine is a prison, and you have to very much liberate yourself from its impact, from its shackles'. [sic.]* [453]

Looping back to previous research and the theoretical starting points, especially the characteristics of SOD, this remark highlights the ongoing tension between, on the one hand, doctrine—meaning regularities, cause-effect relationships, and sequential linearity. On the other hand, the features of *design*, namely, the focus on emergence and exploitation of relationships and boundaries upheld by the prevailing paradigm.[454]

Having engaged in more than 50 interviews, dialogues, conversations, tutorials, conferences and excursions with some 20 Israeli Generals, additional equivalents, and a range of prominent and insightful others,[455] several features have emerged recurrently. These features form essential aspects that support the single-sentence attempt to answer this research question. Therefore, to achieve maximum operational freedom as a cognitive substitute for physical space, a few signature components seem necessary.

Reflexivity – to think about thinking

Reflecting on one's own thinking is often discussed in interactions with members of this congregation. Seen as a deliberate cognitive activity, it closely aligns with the academic idea of reflexivity, which, in qualitative research, involves being aware of one's own thought processes and how they evolve over time—especially when undertaking deep and intense fieldwork in unfamiliar environments. Reflexivity, or thinking about your thinking as it is called in this Israeli military context, is a proactive approach that guards against ignorance and blindness to the need for change, thereby maintaining relevance.

A key feature often highlighted in this context is avoiding repetition or favouring specific modes of operation. In other words, operating in similar ways repeatedly is

[453] Ekholm, 'Between Depth and Takhbulah'. p 509.

[454] For related reasoning concerning this tension, see Jackson, *Military Design Thinking.* p 69-84.

[455] See Appendix 1. Several in this congregation have been engaged on multiple occasions over more than two years.

a big no-no, especially when it involves previously developed schemes or operational ideas that have demonstrated success. This is no witchcraft. Like boxers or wrestlers, armed actors will study their opponent before a bout and adapt based on previous encounters displayed by the opposition. According to this reasoning, the perception of the operation, that is, the practical realisation of strategy as repeatedly described by the involved group, is seen through the mental image of a one-time endeavour.

However, a general human desire to repeat positive experiences should not be underestimated; hence, a tangible threat to remain unpredictable.

Operate the system

> '…you need to understand the system: who is playing in this system? What are the interests of each player in this system? […] what you need to do to make the system working as you want, not as the enemy forced you to do [sic]'.[456]

Drawing on these words in the third article, ensuring a high level of freedom and non-repetitive use of force requires cunning action and mental effort. Not only must the hostile aspect of the interacting system be mapped out and its operational logic thoroughly understood, but also the logic of the system itself. The same applies to all other actors that may influence, limit, or enable the high level of freedom the operator aims for. All to remain able to operate in new ways relative to the track record, meaning *the expected*. Therefore, *all* related actors, including their drivers and agendas, must be thoroughly understood and their roles clearly defined. Thus, as emphasised in the third article: '[you] don't understand reality if you don't understand the system'.[457] An important insight often repeated in this context is that the blue- or friendly side often presents the most challenging opposition to manage. This is because of the effort to maintain stability, meaning the institutional boundaries within the current paradigm, doctrine, organisation, and tradition. These stability-maintaining elements can be viewed as essential unifying features, manifesting a shared set of familiar patterns. At the same time, however, these same aspects can trap the mind and stifle creative thinking by enforcing restrictions and taboo areas. Doing so starkly opposes the operators' striving for freedom to operate

[456] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 16.

[457] Ibid. p 15.

in creative and unrestrained ways, as they meet *unknown patterns emerging* in the constant evolution of the situation. Thus, at the bottom line, ideally, the operator- i.e., *the General*- commands more than the blue side in his attempts to betray the adversary. *He operates the entire system*.

A supporter and practical method to effectively operate the system is the Design Blow. Recurring in interviews and elaborated in the third and fourth articles, this signature feature exemplifies how the evolving, i.e., circular approach to Operational Art is embraced and strengthened cognitively: '[Give blow and] blow designs the system, and the re-designing of the system helps you understand correctly. And then create the necessary minor adjustments [sic]'.[458]

Essentially, provoke the system to reveal its functioning logic, then quickly adjust and operate.

Challenging and transforming your knowledge and biases

As the thinking and moving obstacle, the hostile system naturally creates friction of considerable magnitude — the very essence of the relationship between the antagonists — and a timeless aspect of war. Moreover, as repeatedly discussed, the friendly system also imposes limitations that restrict possible ways to operate. However, it does not stop there. Learning from the engaged congregation, an even more reluctant actor — often the most difficult to manage — is yourself. A closely related theme encountered several times during interviews, dialogues, and conversations about Operational Art is referred to as self-manipulation, accompanied by subsequent self-transformation. These issues have been repeatedly elaborated and described as things you must forget to become and remain an independent or *autarkic* operator. Put simply, the need to consciously abandon your previous operational experiences — especially any favouring of means and methods used during prior engagements, particularly the successful ones. This implication is exemplified in the second and third articles: 'When you have too much knowledge about a very specific thing, you are also your slave by your knowledge […] sometimes this knowledge and this experience doesn't help me [sic]'.[459]

A rule of the game generally presented is to constantly evaluate and transform the modus and/or organisational manifestation of the friendly force before even attempting to engage the adversary.

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[458] Ekholm, 'Between Depth and Takhbulah'. p 510; and Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 15.

[459] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 20; for related reasoning see also Ekholm, 'Wizards of Depth-Israel's Area of Operations and Lessons Learned from Its Depth Dimension'. p 2f;

This is the essence of *takhbulah,* the nonlinear operational theory and method to create Depth cognitively, which is elaborated on in detail in the fourth article.

Doing so requires an almost total rejection of operational stability while remaining in constant motion, which in itself manifests a recurring perception of strategy: 'Everything is for a short time, you can't make strategy to long strategy […] Strategy is now and after an operation, you have to check if the strategy is still actual, or you have to change it […] And if the strategy has to change, the operation […] have to adapt to the new [sic]'.[460]

Words and ideas related to this idea evoke the image of the General as a Vagabond: a restless soul, a nomad who is constantly moving, critically assessing his surroundings in a tireless search for anomalies and unknown patterns. In this context, a Vagabond is not a traditional wanderer, but a strategic thinker who is always on the move, both mentally and physically, to gain a deeper understanding of the operational environment.[461]

Manipulation, Imagination and Perplexity

Albeit a word with a negative, deceptive association, at least from a Western standpoint, what is referred to here is to exploit and make the most of [potentially] coercive tools already in possession by unlocking their accessibility. In other words, as described by the congregation engaged, a way to ensure maximum freedom and, subsequently, operational effect. However, as elaborated in the latter three articles, remaining operationally unpredictable often requires the manoeuvring of rules set by the paradigm, i.e., *the friendly system*. And doing so is often beyond controversial: '…the hardest thing is how to manipulate the blue side […] it's not the red side [sic]'.[462]

As extensively discussed in the articles and briefly outlined above, the primary entity involved is the blue (friendly) side. The specific targets include artificial boundaries that hinder creativity and the unpredictable use of force. The main obstacles repeatedly mentioned are tradition, institutionalised habits (no-go zones), and the implicit, general strive for stability and organisational longevity, as reflected in military doctrine, regulations, and bureaucratic structures.

To maximise the available freedom, namely, the attempted one-sentence answer to the question, two additional features have emerged to support friendly force transformation (and manipulation when needed). The first feature is imagination, i.e., the ability to envisage development other than ideal, given the current force

[460] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 15.

[461] For more regarding the Vagabond, see Ekholm, 'Between Depth and Takhbulah'. p 507, 518.

[462] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p. 19; for related reasoning, see also Ekholm, 'Wizards of Depth-Israel's Area of Operations and Lessons Learned from Its Depth Dimension'. p 6.

employment and favoured concepts. What is meant in this regard is an antidote to ignorance, thus, *the main threat* to the effective detection of emerging anomalies and unfamiliar patterns. Unfortunately, this is an area where otherwise unifying and stability-enhancing concepts, such as doctrine and tradition, become counterproductive by effectively fuelling feelings of self-superiority and, therefore, ignorance of signs that may indicate a drift towards irrelevance in the face of emerging threats in an evolving reality.

In this regard, perplexity is required as the serum to combat ignorance and blindness towards anomalies, which involves constant- and sometimes brutal transformation to remain relevant.

The meaning of perplexity in this context is best described as the intensely uncomfortable feeling you experience in your chest during a close call in traffic, or when, for some reason, you find yourself irrelevant in an awkward social situation. This level of discomfort is necessary to prompt self-initiated reevaluation and transformation, especially given the opposition created by investments aimed at long-term stability. Therefore, anything less than perplexity and the institutionalised paradigm will remain unaltered and continue to operate under the same logic. A practical way to induce perplexity in this context is to push cognitive boundaries beyond the obvious and familiar patterns. Doing so involves envisioning the adversary in ways that go beyond the known. This imagined portrait then serves as a rear-view mirror or observation post from which the friendly force is scrutinised, namely, an exercise heavily dependent on imagination to challenge the relevance of the prevailing paradigm.

Conceptual contributions

The discussion above highlights a key contribution of this thesis, namely, insights gained from firsthand, hard-to-obtain empirical data collected on-site within the Israeli operational environment. Beyond these empirical findings and conclusions, the thesis also makes several additional contributions in relation to previous research, supported by its theoretical starting points. This work is dedicated to the research field of Operational Art, particularly to the often implicit and vague body of research that deals with Depth, a term referring to the capacity to project, absorb, and manoeuvre available coercive assets along offensive and defensive lines of operation. The following subsections elaborate on the two primary, interconnected contributions this thesis makes to the field of Operational Art, thereby manifesting

the result of the concept-developing ambition: *the Cognitive approach to Depth* and the *Circular Model*.

A Cognitive Approach to Depth

Initially introduced in the first article and elaborated upon in the remaining three, the value and potential of the cognitive perspective to Depth have been continuously challenged, evaluated, and confirmed to date.

The cognitive extension to Depth represents a tangible contribution and addresses a research field dominated by overly linear and physically focused approaches to Depth and Operational Art. As demonstrated in this thesis, this linear and physical dominance exposes a shortcoming that is problematic for actors lacking the resources needed to effectively utilise the concepts and methods available in the current body of research. Here, we must remember that Depth and resources, whether available, absent, or limited, are only relevant *in relation* to an antagonist or aggressor, thus providing a clue to the universe of cases that may benefit from this research.

To address this issue, the cognitive perspective on Depth was incorporated to offer an analytical framework for investigation and a domain where operational effects are examined. This addition, which is seldom found in previous writings, is not based on guesswork. It is grounded in a well-founded assumption closely linked to the clever and indirect traits of MT and the cunning, disruptive logic of SOD. Consequently, two points of departure clearly illustrate how the cognitive effort enhances physical strength.

Because shrewdness and prudence, rather than brute force, constitute the common denominators of MT and SOD, it was carefully assumed that cognitive extension could potentially reveal means and methods to create or enhance Depth when the physical prerequisites for employing the traditional concepts found in previous research are absent. This assumption has proved highly valid, essentially accurate when engaging with the Israeli environment, which is repeatedly reflected in the report provided by the four articles. As examples of this contribution, we can consider operational ideas and approaches such as leaving surprises behind in enemy Depth or establishing presence and ambiguous presence in key areas of the operational theatre. In the second article, the issue is elaborated from the Israeli perspective, effectively demonstrating the power of the indirect approach against wisely chosen targets:

'…by using cyber warfare, by using decoys or using un-manned capabilities by using drones […] You can create the false notion of the enemy that something is wrong in the depth, something happening in-depth […] then you can find all the added values of depth operation without really physically creating something in the depth. [sic.]' [463]

Another prominent aspect and cognitive pathway towards Depth highlighted is the Israeli operational theory of takhbulah, which is explored in detail in the fourth article. Closely linked to the theoretical foundations used in this thesis, takhbulah offers a significant and distinct contribution to existing research, which is often dominated by linear thinking and substantial assets. Therefore, cognitively leveraging and utilising existing resources can offer a strength enhancement to actors facing a scarcity of assets and, consequently, Depth. Through its two-stage logic, which emphasises self-transformation to remain relevant in a rapidly changing environment, takhbulah embodies the core of the cognitive pathway towards Depth by maximising the impact of limited resources. Doing so basically exploits [a cognitive] aspect of Operational Art provided by Sun Tzu: 'He who only sees the obvious, wins his battles with difficulty; he who looks below the surface of things, wins with ease'.[464]

Considering recurring empirical findings that support the cognitive approach, such as independence, non-repetitive force employment, and blue force manipulation, the presumption of constant transformation is perceived as beneficial, despite the traditionalist stance in military organisations. Thus, the scope to manoeuvre the friendly system into a temporary, more efficient one might not seem obvious to an institutionalised insider. However, to a non-assimilated outsider, many things may appear irrational, indicating extensive possibilities for transformation. In this way, building or enhancing available Depth becomes a cognitive exercise, making the most of what you have.

[463] Ekholm, 'Wizards of Depth-Israel's Area of Operations and Lessons Learned from Its Depth Dimension'. p 7.

[464] Sun Tzu et al., *The Complete Art of War*, 1st ed. (Radford: Wilder Publications, 2008). p 22.

The Circular Model and Definitions

'...ambiguous as opposed to straight, direct, rigid and unequivocal. The ultimate expression of these qualities is the circle, the bond that is perfect because it completely turns back on itself, with neither beginning nor end, front nor rear...' [465]

In light of the research problem where insufficient physical resources hinder the development of Depth through the linear, resource-focused methods common in previous research, this thesis introduces an alternative called the Circular Model. This innovative approach reinterprets the concept of Depth as the ability to project, absorb, and manoeuvre existing coercive assets across offensive and defensive lines of operation. Building on the theoretical starting points and addressing the recognised gap, it represents a 'positive approach' that emphasises making the most of available resources rather than lamenting the absence of others:

In this context, Depth is viewed as an evolving feature—a function of three categories: [project-absorb-manoeuvre]—rather than a fixed asset explicitly tied to a spatial division of the operational theatre. These categories, articulated with language deemed 'just right' in terms of abstraction, foster creative thinking that transcends established boundaries, meaning beyond what is traditionally viewed as correct in the specific context.

The argument here advocates for a perception of Depth that is not only nonlinear *but circular*. Essentially, this means recognising Depth as a comprehensive power source that encompasses all available resources: an interconnected whole, a web of relationships rather than isolated entities, with no distinction made between, for instance, military and civilian aspects.[466]

Doing so, in operational terms, entails smoothing out an otherwise striated, or divided environment; essentially, as Shimon Naveh explains, a nonlinear approach deliberately sacrifices control to enhance creative manoeuvre, as opposed to the linear approach, where creative manoeuvre is sacrificed for control.[467] To do so effectively may imply the need for friendly force manipulation—deliberate actions

[465] Detienne and Vernant, *Cunning Intelligence in Greek Culture and Society*. p 46.

[466] Circular Depth- a label used to explain a conceptual development of non-linearity as expressed in the chapter covering previous research; Web of relations, see Capra, *Patterns of Connection*. p 308ff.

[467] Insights captured when exclusively tutored by the founder and director of Strategema, IDF General's Course, during fieldwork in April 2023. For related reasoning, see also Naveh, 'Between the Striated and the Smooth'; and Eyal Weizman, 'Walking through Walls', *Radical Philosophy*, no. 136 (2006). p 12f.

that remove obstacles created by tradition, doctrine, templates, and, not least, parochial minds.

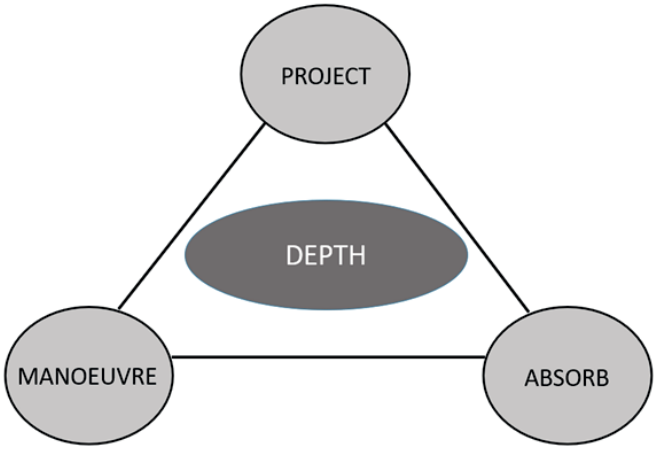


Figure 2. The Depth-model: A Practical Tool for Understanding and Generating Depth. This model is not just a theoretical construct, but a practical tool designed to facilitate adaptation to the evolutionary reality of warfare. It represents and encourages a non-conformist approach, urging the exploitation of whatever means available in a contextual and anti-parochial manner without being bound by traditional constraints.[468] *The authors' illustration: A Product of Expertise and Experience.*

Because of its simple content and appearance, the model is designed to be easily accepted by the mind, enabling it to organise and understand available resources and potential outcomes in new and unrestricted ways. Building on this idea, Depth is seen as a cognitive trait driven by imagination and, on the other hand, hindered by ignorance when one fails to see everything as a whole but instead as isolated parts influenced by egos. Contemplating the model in all its simplicity while simultaneously reflecting on the report of this thesis, Depth is preferably understood as the *unrestrained space for creative manoeuvre*.[469]

Put simply, while reconnecting to the theoretical points of departure, the core is not each individual part but the nonlinear interaction between the elements, which

[468] No sacred cows, see Zweibelson, *Understanding the Military Design Movement*. p 141; Vego, 'On Military Creativity'. p 84f.

[469] Although this model is not constructed with a template, it is worth mentioning that resembling ones exist, although not in the context of Depth. See, for example, the 'threefold order of conditions' in Fuller's *Foundations on the Science of War*. p 175f, 211; see also *move - strike- protect* in Leonhard's *Fighting by Minutes.* p 17ff.

reflects the dynamic and interconnected nature of the components that simultaneously encompass and address all aspects of the operational problem.[470]

The pursued product, [Depth], emerges from the middle, indicating that all three components are equally important, emphasising the need for balance regardless of the means or methods used to represent the three categories. Additionally, the model implicitly presents Depth with a contextual feature based on imagination and conscious creativity, while simultaneously urging caution against overgeneralising from one case to another. However, as Flyvbjerg argues, generalisation from a single case is not entirely impossible. Whether generalising or not, one can still gain professional insights from operational engagements that may offer ideas to be carefully adapted to suit the specific features of other settings. Therefore, the focus is on using, modifying, and applying assets already available within the particular context. To achieve this effectively, the theme tune spells manipulation, albeit with a noble intent that '…will help liberate us from the bureaucratic March towards yet another conflict with the same favorite tools in hand'.[471] However, from listening to Ben Zweibelson, we know, 'The first obstacle with proposing alternative modes of thinking is that we are often predisposed to seek a familiar idea or concept to replace the old one'.[472]

The proposed move involves liberation and operational freedom, which significantly impact the ability to outmanoeuvre adversaries in the short term. Conversely, it requires a more analytical approach essential for long-term defence planning, where maximising the effect from available resources remains central. However, it is important to recognise that this type of liberation and reinforcement of effects is not straightforward; it will likely face resistance from stability-focused institutions and demands proactive engagement and an open mindset. Nevertheless, overcoming the constraints that limit operational freedom may be the quickest way to strengthen operational capabilities and, in turn, increase Depth in rapidly deteriorating situations.

Moreover, being aware that the word manipulation has a negative and provocative tone, it refers to actions that work in favour of improved operational effect. However, parochial minds focused on inter-service rivalry and tradition may see what is important as something else. As understood by this thesis, what is particularly problematic and requires manipulation is the perception of the meaning of what is *available.* Systems theory-authority Fritjof Capra elaborates with bracketed emphasis added by this author: 'The ancient, western [linear] idea of knowledge, as an imaginative building centred on principles, laws and building bricks, receives increasing opposition from the evolving concept of systems: the

[470] Naveh, *In Pursuit of Military Excellence.* p 21.
[471] Zweibelson, 'One Piece at a Time'. p 369.
[472] Ibid.

building metaphor is being exchanged for a [circular] network-inspired ditto'.[473] From the viewpoint of a linear subscribing operational agent, an ideal-model supporter, tightly obedient to doctrine, organisation, and tradition, such opposition can probably provoke very uncomfortable sensations.

Supported by empirical findings, theoretical starting points, and identified gaps in previous research, this thesis ultimately advocates for a circular approach to Operational Art, particularly concerning Depth. This perspective stems from a complex operational environment characterised by unprecedented speed, unpredictability, and novel systemic combinations. Instead of reinforcing established rules within institutional confines, we should adapt and embrace the dynamic nature of reality, seizing opportunities presented by emerging circumstances. While this thesis aims to develop a Depth concept that is more applicable to those with limited physical Depth compared to existing literature, the proposed model can also be highly relevant for significant actors. As a result, without restrictive scope conditions, this approach can be utilised by virtually any actor seeking to identify and leverage existing resources in innovative ways.

…a nonlinear approach deliberately sacrifices control to expand creative manoeuvre, as opposed to the linear equivalent, where creative manoeuvre is sacrificed for control… [474]

At the bottom line, contrary to the linear perceptions of geographical space, Depth is preferably understood in terms *of freedom relative to the adversary*. With such a perception, Depth can be created cognitively when its physical manifestations are limited or absent. Based on the report of this thesis, i.e., the attached articles examining the Israeli operational environment, you can develop or strengthen your Depth by denying the enemy the same opportunity. Doing so effectively is very much a cognitive exercise that requires an open mind and a search for *anomalies* rather than an attitude striving to find incentives that *conform* to an ideal, or a prevailing defence concept. However, this is tricky business due to 'an "almost pathological desire to achieve certainty" in the notoriously uncertain environment of war, which leads us to linear thinking and analytical campaigning...'[475]

[473] Capra, *Patterns of Connection*. p 309f.

[474] An informative simplification regarding the relationship between linear and nonlinear within the context of Operational Art. A key insight captured when exclusively tutored by the founder and director of Strategema, IDF General's Course, during fieldwork in April 2023. For related reasoning, see p 53f "The Linear and the Nonlinear.

[475] Zweibelson, 'One Piece at a Time'. p 362.

Conclusions and Recommendations

Faced with the challenge of developing Depth in the face of armed adversaries when geography and resources are limited, this thesis has examined the operational thinking of an actor that lacks Depth in the conventional, physical sense. Practically, this has been achieved by focusing on Israel as a paradigmatic case, a real-world laboratory through which the research question is investigated, guided by two sub-questions:[476]

How has the lack of Depth affected Israeli Operational Art and operational thinking?

[…]

How is the lack of depth reflected in Israeli Operational Art?

How has it been resolved in IDF operational thinking?

This thesis advances the understanding of Depth in three key ways. First, it provides substantial, hard-to-get insights related to Operational Art and Depth from an actor with a track record of treating this physical shortcoming. Second, it contributes to the field of Operational Art and its implicit subsection, Depth, leading to the conclusion that traditional physical (and temporal) approaches to Depth should preferably be complemented by a cognitive perspective, especially when physical resources are limited and need enhancement. This view aligns well with MT and SOD logic, and it also enjoys extensive support from empirical findings and fieldwork insights in Israel. The cognitive approach to Depth has two aspects: (a) a sought *effect*, aiming to influence the adversary system, ranging from disrupting operational harmony to causing irrelevance, collapse, and paralysis; (b) a *method*, that is, a mental exercise pursuing new solutions to traditional problems by going beyond prevailing doctrine and the ruling paradigm, or as Vego puts it, beyond parochialism and institutionalised solutions.[477] Therefore, the third contribution, the circular model developed in this thesis, offers a conceptual enhancement when mapping and maximising available resources, 'unshackled' by previous knowledge and experience.

[476] For more information regarding paradigmatic case selection, see Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 230ff.

[477] Vego, 'On Military Creativity'.

Thus, by conducting operations differently, an adversary can be betrayed, at least temporarily, before the operational manifestation of the intended solution [strategy] requires reinvention due to a growing gap between how we ideally want the operational reality to function and what actually occurs. Israeli Soldier-Scholar Brig. Gen Shimon Naveh emphasises this discrepancy with a catching phrase originating from the London Underground in the 1960s: *Mind the Gap*.

> *'Not all people want to be liberated. Some rather take the blue pill and remain prisoners of their own mind (or doctrine). Those who do condemn themselves to a life of frustration, hunger and discontent'.* [478]

Thus, like it or not, reality is drifting, and if we ignore the need for constant adjustments, our beloved creation will become irrelevant. Recognising the discrepancy and acting accordingly requires reflexive abilities and, above all, a sense of *perplexity.* Learning from the engaged congregation of interviewees, it is clear that achieving the subsequent self-induced transformation is challenging without the highly unpleasant sense of perplexity. Without it, we will ignorantly continue to assure ourselves of our creations' excellence and, therefore, avoid change at all costs, which is beautifully described by my friend Ofra Graicer in the quotation above. A tangible example of the dangers that emerge hand in hand with ignorance is the refusal to transform after achieving success in operations. Thus, the moment you defeat your adversary, you also teach him how to win the next round of fighting. With this insight, creating effective methods to artificially achieve perplexity becomes crucial to ensure continuous transformation and remain relevant.[479]

With the rapid rise of drones and AI-enhanced Operational Art on today's battlefield, the need to remain unpredictable has grown stronger. These tools not only enable effective surveillance but, when combined, can also help identify patterns and anomalies before the serious effects of surprise attacks occur. Essentially, a potential antidote to ignorance, which aligns with another key feature related to cognitive Depth and its potential exploitation through the circular model. It involves being conscious of your thinking, or, as it is often referred to by the engaged group, *thinking about thinking.* Concluding this line of thought, it is found that '*Depth is to create systems. Systems of thinking'.* [480] Following this logic, continuously monitoring for potential discrepancies as they emerge involves constant movement and re-evaluation, being sensitive to changes and anomalies. Essentially, it is the exact opposite of slowing down to appreciate your creation. With this understanding, it

[478] Graicer, 'Self Disruption'. p 35.

[479] The most basic method would be a designated 'red team' attempting to expose vulnerabilities or cracks in the operational foundation. However, more sophisticated techniques may be required to induce a real sense of perplexity.

[480] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 14.

becomes almost impossible not to recognise the value of military doctrine and its extent in representing something positive in unifying terms, and when it shifts into a negative aspect in terms of predictability and the confinement of the creative mind. This product's Janus-faced and potentially lethal character is elaborated upon in the fourth article: Doctrine can be extremely powerful when exercising action, but it becomes a prison when it comes to rethinking and reevaluating your understanding of the operational reality's evolving logic. To remain relevant, this is *a prison you must escape from*.[481] This does not suggest the need to choose between doctrinal conformity and creative force employment. Instead, it highlights a critical duality—or dichotomy—that one must be aware of and navigate carefully, depending on the specific situation's characteristics.

As we have learned, contemporary wars are both won and lost in the cognitive domain; therefore, embracing the cognitive perspective as an adjunct to the physical when pursuing Depth makes perfect sense. Here, we find further support from Steven Biddle, who argues that:

'…material factors alone cannot explain capability as we have observed it over the past century…' '…[and] much of the literature has argued that military power plays a less central role…' '…[therefore] material wherewithal is a very poor indicator of real military outcomes, and materially inferior states are thus not usually likely to die off via military defeat'.[482]

Building on this argument and the report provided by the articles, the thesis has identified clear incentives to promote a nonlinear [circular] and evolving approach to Operational Art as an alternative to linear conformity. To do so effectively, the developed circular model acts as a helpful cognitive enhancer and tangible artefact, particularly when analysing the operational environment for constraints and potential, using a systemic approach. Undoubtedly, the model does not offer a silver bullet in a magical sense, but it certainly provides assistance to minds stuck under the burden of non-creative shackles.

That said, it is reasonable to question the choice of theoretical perspectives that aim to narrow the scope into something more tangible while offering a solid starting point for concept development. Consequently, theory has a significant influence on understanding, perceptions, and conclusions, even when it is applied in a non-operationalised manner without a clear goal to explain. Therefore, this thesis recommends that similar projects be carried out with different or even no

[481] Ekholm, 'Between Depth and Takhbulah'. p 509.

[482] Biddle, *Military Power*. p 190, 192, 193.

theoretical foundations, considering the wide range of valuable insights this paradigmatic case can provide for inspiration and concept development. As briefly illustrated in the second article, 'Wizards of Depth', such starting points could engage with deterrence and resilience, or even theories about strategic narratives. The latter, which examines the connection between the strategic message and its operational expression, has had and continues to have a significant impact on both external and internal audiences regarding the ongoing conflict in the region. In this context, it could probably be analysed as an example of Depth in its cognitive sense.

Furthermore, while supporting nearly all perspectives on Operational Art except those relying on black-and-white choices, the thesis also advocates for mediation, which involves developing the ability to effectively navigate and leverage the tensions that emerge between the linear (ideal) and the circular (evolving) approaches. This finding and argument are strongly supported by previous research, valuable insights from the attached articles, and, notably, this author's ongoing engagement with leading agents and mentors involved in the IDF Generals' Course, Strategema. The capacity to mediate and master the Forward/Rearward [linear] and the project-absorb-manoeuvre [circular] approaches to Depth becomes especially vital when confronting a complex operational theatre that combines contiguous and non-contiguous Depth, as both are theoretically outlined in the chapter covering previous research and practically demonstrated empirically by the Israeli theatre.

Nonetheless, the thesis views the linear, conformist perspective described and used as the 'old logic' of approaching the world in general and the military issue in particular. However, abandoning it is not advisable, mainly because it remains a key ideal with many loyal followers, making it an important reference point for operational epistemology and navigation.[483]

However, it is vital to remain open to different perspectives and engage in mediation to be effective in the fast-paced environment of modern warfare and operations. This becomes even more important when a smaller nation, such as Sweden, joins an alliance that follows a largely linear approach to Operational Art. Therefore, to be a truly effective contributor rather than just a conforming follower, one must manage dual roles: first, by sticking to linearity through operational doctrines and manuals; second, by acting as an anticipatory and nonlinear participant, embracing the idea that readiness and operational effectiveness are achieved only through continual questioning and dismissing the mindset that something is 'the way it has always been'. For military professionals, this latter stance demands courage, as they are likely to face hierarchical resistance and obstacles that could hamper career progression. Nonetheless, engaging in this reflexive process within military studies

[483] From a tactical standpoint, linear approaches are still perceived as effective points of departure during specific operational circumstances.

and Operational Art is essential, and it is our responsibility as academics and military practitioners to embrace this challenge.[484]

As we are about to close the conclusion part of this thesis, we turn to the following quote from Israeli Admiral Ami Ayalon, which effectively illustrates the three main contributions of this thesis: the Israeli perspective on the issue, the developed circular model—designed to maximise available resources—and the cognitive extension of Depth:

'…we are fighting, we are using cyber, we are using our spatial units- at sea or everywhere, in order to sometimes send a message, to hit economic achievements of the enemy, to create constraints on his ability to hit us. And there is a huge type of depth, because we are not doing it on the frontier, we are doing it somewhere else…' [sic.].[485]

With these words describing the evolving and comprehensive approach to warfare adopted by the IDF, we return to another recurring element of the Israeli experience and a circular argument in this thesis: *Strategy is a cognitive, short-term product, and its practical expression—the operation—is a unique event that cannot be generalised or replicated*. As illustrated by the quotation above, this assertion reflects a recurring view of strategy and Operational Art that this thesis strongly endorses. Thus, by deliberately executing operations in locations other than the frontline, it demonstrates a nonlinear perception of Depth based on the principle that the operational manifestation of strategy will vary depending on the potential emerging from the situation and the resources available for employment. As we have learned in this thesis, by manipulating the restraints upheld by the blue side, additional capabilities and thus strength can potentially be unlocked and made available to engage the adversary. Doing so essentially embodies the core logic of takhbulah, which has been elaborated in detail.

It also provides a concrete example of strategy translating into action through Operational Art, highlighting both the impact of the cognitive perspective and the singular, non-replicable nature of military operations. In this regard, manoeuvre theorist William Lind fully agrees with the empirical findings of this project: 'All patterns, recipes and formulas are to be avoided. The enemy must not be able to predict your actions'.[486] However, if we are ignorant or even arrogant about the fact that reality is constantly changing, our operational system will swiftly turn irrelevant, potentially leading to disaster. Thus, from the very point an operational

[484] For related reasoning, see Zweibelson, 'One Piece at a Time'. p 368.

[485] IDF Admiral (ret.) Amichay Ayalon. Former commander of the Israeli Navy and former Head of Shin Bet (Israel's internal security service), *Personal interview*, in his home, Kerem Mahara, Israel (2022-08-31, 1430–1530).

[486] Lind, *Maneuver Warfare Handbook*. p 7.

scheme (or doctrine) is formulated, it will begin to grow irrelevant, considering demands posed by the *rhei* of reality and a thinking adversary.

Nevertheless, if an actor (such as the primary audience of this thesis) lacks the physical space and prerequisites needed to either confront the enemy through defensive manoeuvres or to funnel echelons of reserves via a breach in the enemy's front, how should he proceed? A key insight and strong recommendation of this thesis is to utilise the resources available deep within the enemy's disposition. By doing so, limited resources are directed against carefully selected vulnerabilities, namely, links that enable the enemy system to function in harmony.[487] Typically, such targets include those potentially holding multiplying effects. Traditionally, this could consist of railway junctions, ammunition depots, or radar installations. What this means in practice tomorrow is, of course, context dependent and will be revealed by a profound systemic analysis, effectively mapping the territory to be navigated. Essentially, this signifies an indirect and disruptive Depth approach that aligns well with the theoretical foundations used and is widely supported by empirical evidence.

In this context, I recommend close monitoring and analysis of the developments of the Israeli Operation Rising Lion—designed to disrupt the Iranian nuclear threat.[488] This analysis would highlight many key aspects discussed in this thesis, both in real-time and retrospectively.

Towards the future via the rear mirror- *Re-thinking Operational Depth*

Looking back through the rear mirror at the initial problem, the annoyance that motivated the project, the state of previous research, the fieldwork periods (as manifested by the articles) and the results, let me conclude and answer how my perception of Depth has evolved in conceptual terms from beginning to end.

It all started with a linear, physically centred perception, often problematic for those lacking in these areas compared to the competition. Thus, an attempt to address this question at the beginning of the project would have involved the Forward/Rearward understanding, essentially akin to Jomini's words in the first sentence of this thesis: 'The theater of operations of an army embraces all the territory it may desire to invade and all that it may be necessary to defend'.[489]

However, such an early attempt would likely have had a more prominent 'rearward' characteristic—due to this author's fundamental starting point: a non-aligned entity,

[487] In this regard, a study of operations conducted by IDF 69th Fighter Squadron '*The Hammers*' is highly recommended.

[488] Hayman, 'Operation Rising Lion: Achievements, Open Questions, and Future Scenarios'.

[489] Jomini, *The Art of War.* p 75.

which until recently generally made discussions of offensive and especially pre-emptive operational options difficult.

With a year and a half, loads of literature and a published article up the sleeve, the answer to the same question would have been: '*an actors' ability to project power, absorb power and to maintain the ability to maneuver available coercive tools- or assets along physical- or cognitive, offensive- and defensive lines of operation'.*[490] This implies a less linear perception intended to inspire creative employment of limited resources already in possession. From that point, the [circular] perception became a loyal and productive follower, often discussed, complemented, or mediated with its linear counterpart. Later, as expressed in the report chapter of this compilation text, an attempted modified version was formulated: [Depth] *'a manipulation of space, within a conceptually framed system of manoeuvre (one's own system and the rival's) seeking exploitation of potential in one's own favour through learning and self-transformation'.*[491] Thus, essentially, an evolved perception, closely connected to the indirect nature of MT and the cognitive and non-linear features embraced by SOD.

Armed with the knowledge, insight, and conclusions this thesis has given me, an answer to the same question from this retrospective point would be:

> Depth is a perception- a cognitive construct residing in man's mind. It is dependent on abilities, friendly and adversary ones alike. Being so, it is highly contextual and reliant on imagination to extract maximal effect by ensuring that existing resources stand ready for employment in new ways, un-shackled by tradition and blue-force restraints.[492]

In support of imagination and Depth's creation, the circular model and the cognitive extension are available to complement, augment, or substitute for the Forward/Rearward perception that dominates current research. Therefore, with this evolved perception and these tools, a small actor like Sweden, equipped with advanced resources, can demonstrate a willingness to carry out Doolittle raid-like operations against larger opponents or aggressors, thus expanding its Depth cognitively by communicating:

> Ok, we cannot defeat you, but be advised, we will hit you where it hurts. It will humiliate you, and it will cost you- dearly…[493]

[490] Ekholm, 'Re-Thinking Operational Depth- a Source of Power'. p 388.

[491] Ekholm, 'From the Linear towards the Circular'. p 24.

[492] Thus, an extended perception related to the one presented at the beginning of the article: Ekholm, 'Wizards of Depth'.

[493] In the Swedish example, this would act to prevent land-capturing attempts in the very short time frame before the alliance can mobilise more significant resources. Again, a study of operations conducted by IDF 69th Fighter Squadron '*The Hammers*' is highly recommended.

Implications and Shortcomings

The preceding discussion delineates the results, conclusions, and provisional recommendations from a project with concept-developing ambitions derived from a single, paradigmatic case study that has prioritised qualitative depth and thickness over breadth.[494] As such, these results are subjective and do not aim to be fully generalisable in the academic sense. However, as Brent Flyvbjerg argues, a single case can definitely be used for generalisation.[495] Although the outcomes of this thesis are modest in this regard, it is reasonable to suggest they could contribute value to the military profession if considered in different contexts. Thus, borrowing ideas and drawing inspiration for adjusted implementation in other military settings are straightforward measures of self-preservation. In this regard, some of the results (and conclusions) *might* certainly be generalised to some extent.

At the same time, we must remember that generalisation and conceptual skills in a rigorous research context are entirely different from attempts to plagiarise or imitate other actors' operational ideas or schemes. That said, with twice the time and resources, it might have been possible to carry out a dual case study, allowing for some comparison and potentially producing results that could be marginally more generalisable in an academic sense. However, the intense labour and commitment needed to gain access to closed environments in other parts of the world should not be underestimated or taken for granted.

This project depends on a deep engagement with a foreign environment, which is, in many ways, quite different from my point of departure but also shares similarities. The open and lively society, the straightforwardness, and the eagerness to discuss complex issues encountered when engaging with the target community for this thesis have created a specific impact that has sparked my curiosity and desire to learn more. At the same time, this reality has required additional and deep reflexivity as an antidote to becoming 'too close' and, therefore, less aware of potential distortions and downsides of findings and received messages. However, when engaging closely, one will inevitably be affected in some manner, which will undoubtedly differ from person to person. Therefore, it is uncertain whether the thick description in this thesis would lead to the same conclusions if conducted by someone else.

The ongoing conflict in the region must also be considered as an additional implication for this project. Following the Hamas attack on 7 October 2023, the Levantine region was further ignited and thrust into a state of high-intensity warfare. Although the fieldwork phase of this project was essentially completed, it has introduced significant controversy into an already delicate situation and a question that has divided the world for many years and is likely to do so for a long

[494] The thick description, see Moses and Knutsen, *Ways of Knowing*. p 135.

[495] See Flyvbjerg, 'Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research'. p 220f.

time. It has become evident that the profound diversity in opinions has potentially strained my ability to develop arguments, draw conclusions, and make bold claims concerning Israeli Operational Art. Conversely, this sensitivity has prompted increased reflection and reflexivity on my part. Nonetheless, regardless of how this delicate issue is viewed, controversy remains, and there will (of course) continue to be individuals who question this study and, in doing so, overlook the original aim and purpose of attempting to address a gap in previous research and knowledge.

If I could turn back the clock to redo this project, I would change two things: I would begin with a more thorough probing effort from my home base using Zoom (etc.) before heading into the field. However, it must be noted that some of the key individuals involved agreed to meet me, partly because of my efforts and the challenges I faced accessing a foreign and closed environment. Showing this willingness demonstrated my determination and interest. Secondly, I would seek additional funding beyond the scholarship I secured for this project. All of this would enable longer and more frequent periods in the field — because, as anyone who has conducted exploratory fieldwork knows, that is where the real work happens, not in the library.

Appendix 1: 'List of interviewed'

Here, the engaged interlocutors, collaborators and facilitators are listed with accurate information as of February 2025. Since fieldwork was conducted recurrently over a two-year period, the positions upheld by these individuals vary, as shown in each specific reference. In support of this project, these individuals have been personally involved during the research periods in Israel. Some have participated on multiple occasions, both through interviews and in more informal dialogues, presentations, lectures, field excursions, and active support. Collectively, these engagements have resulted in 53 interviews and several additional informal conversations. A few more names are on the actual list, but due to personal preferences for anonymity, these have been omitted.

Ayalon, Amichay (Ami), IDF Vice Admiral (ret.) Formerly, Head of the General Security Service, ISA (Shin Bet), Chief of the Israeli Navy, and Commander of Flotilla 13 (Naval Commandos). Admiral Ayalon is a rare recipient of Israel's highest decoration, *the Medal of Valor*, which he received following *Operation Bulmus* or the Green Island Raid in the Gulf of Suez in 1969. (Ref: Wikipedia and information provided by Shimon Naveh).

Aloni, Nimrod, IDF Major General. Currently a member of the IDF General Staff, Commander of IDF Depth Corps and Israel National Defense College and Military Academies. Formerly, Aloni Commanded the 143rd 'Gaza' Division, a tenure that included Operations 'Guardian of the Walls' and 'Breaking Dawn'. Formerly, Aloni Commanded the Samaria Regional Brigade. (Ref: Wikipedia and information acquired from personal conversation).

A. N, IDF Colonel (res.). IAF Fighter Pilot. (Personal details intentionally omitted.)

Baidatz, Yossi, IDF Major General (res.). Currently Executive Director of The Center for Educational Technology (CET), Formerly, a member of the IDF General Staff and Commander of the Israel National Defense College and Military Academies. Previously, he has served as the head of the Israel Directorate of Military Intelligence (AMAN) Analysis Division. (Ref: Wikipedia and information acquired from personal conversation).

Brom, Salomon (Shlomo), IDF Brigadier General (ret.). Currently, a Senior Researcher (Emeritus) at the INSS. Formerly, Director of the Strategic Planning Division in the Planning Branch of the IDF General Staff. Former participant in peace negotiations with the Palestinians, Jordan, and Syria in the 1990s. In 2000, he was appointed deputy to the National Security Advisor, returning to JCSS at the end of his post. In 2005-2006, Brom was appointed as a committee member that examined the security strategy and doctrine of the State of Israel. (Ref: INSS Webpage and information acquired from personal conversation).

Diamond, Liad, IDF Major, Head of IDF Public Diplomacy, IDF Spokespersons´s Unit. (Ref: Personal conversation).

Eitan, Itzhak (Itzhik), IDF Major General (res.). Formerly, Commander of IDF Central Command and member of IDF General Staff, a tenure he held during the Defensive Shield Campaign in 2002-2003. During that campaign, he operated four divisions in urban operations and counter-terror operations. Before taking over the IDF Central Command, Eitan commanded three territorial divisions: the Southern Border Division, the Gaza Division, and the Judea and Samaria Division. Since 2017, General Eitan has served (among his reserve duties) as a mentor in the *Strategema* (IDFs Generals' Course). (Ref: Information provided by Shimon Naveh and from personal conversation).

Finkel, Meir, IDF Brigader General (res.). Currently Head of Research at the IDF Dado Center. Formerly, Commander of the IDF Dado Center. He commanded the 847th 'Chariots of Steel' Armoured Brigade during the Second Lebanon War. Formerly, Finkel served as the head of the Army Concepts and Combat Doctrine Department for seven years. (Ref: IDF Webpage and information acquired from personal conversation).

Finkelman, Yaron, IDF Major General. Currently Commander of IDF Southern Command and member of IDF General Staff. Formerly, head of the Operations Division at the IDF Operations Directorate, Commander of the 98th Paratrooper Division 'the Fire Formation', Commander of the Givati Brigade, Commander of the Northern Brigade in the Gaza Strip, and Commander of the Paratroopers Reconnaissance Battalion. (Ref: Wikipedia and information acquired from personal conversation).

Gofman, Roman, IDF Major General. Currently, the Military Secretary to the Prime Minister of Israel and a member of the IDF General Staff. Formerly, Commander of the IDF Ground Forces Training Centre, the Ze'elim Base, and former Commander of the 210. (Bashan) Division, responsible for the Golan Heights and the border to Syria. On the 7th of October, 2023, Gofman was seriously wounded during a firefight against Hamas. (Ref: Information provided by Shimon Naveh and personal conversations).

Graicer, Ofra, IDF Operational Arts Expert. Co-founder and active mentor of the IDF Generals Course, *Strategema.* Between 2000 and 2006, she was a member of the IDF Operational Theory Research Institute (OTRI). For the past 20 years, she has been training Senior Executives in strategic focus and operational efficacy around the globe. Her areas of interest include GAI, Cultural Intelligence, Special Operations and Grey Zones. Graicer is a world-recognised expert in SOD. She holds a PhD in Advanced Military Theory from Tel Aviv University. (Ref: Archipelago of Design, Webpage and personal conversations).

Hacohen, Gershon, IDF Major General (res.). Currently a senior researcher at the Begin-Sadat Center for Strategic Studies. Formerly, Commander of the 36th Armoured Division, Commander of the Military Colleges, Commander of the Northern Corps, Commander of the Division Commanders Course and Commander of the General Staff Corps. General Hacohen commanded the disengagement operation and the complete withdrawal from Gaza in 2005. (Ref: Reichman University Webpage: International Institute for Counter-Terrorism (ICT) and personal conversation).

Hagari, Daniel, IDF Rear Admiral. Hagari serves as a member of the IDF General Staff and head of the IDF Spokesperson's Unit. Formerly, he served as the Director of IDF Naval Operations and as Commander of Shayetet 13 Naval Commandos. Hagari holds a Bachelor's degree in philosophy and a Master's in diplomacy and security from Tel Aviv University. (Ref: Wikipedia and personal conversation).

Hayman, Tamir, IDF Major General (res.). Currently, Hayman serves as the Executive Director of the Institute for National Security Studies (INSS). Previously, Hayman served as Chief of the IDF Intelligence Directorate (AMAN) from 2018 to 2021. During his 34 years of service in the IDF, Maj. Gen. (res.) Hayman held a wide range of command positions in the ground forces, including operational combat experience in the security zone in Lebanon and the Palestinian arena. In 2015, General Hayman became a member of the IDF General Staff, serving as Commander of the IDF Northern Command and Commander of the National Defence College. Hayman holds a Bachelor's degree in Political Science and Economics and a Master's from National Defense College. (Ref: INSS Webpage and personal conversation).

Michael, Kobi, Professor INSS/IDF Colonel (ret.). Professor Michael is a senior researcher at INSS and a visiting professor at the International Centre for Policing and Security, University of South Wales, UK. During his time in the IDF, Colonel Michael primarily served in Unit 504 of the Military Intelligence Directorate. He also served as the Commander of the Israeli-Palestinian coordination apparatus in the Gaza Strip and the West Bank. Professor Michael has published widely (20 books and monographs and over 100 articles and chapters in books) and has been awarded several academic prizes. (Ref: INSS Webpage and personal conversations).

Naveh, Shimon, IDF Brigadier General (res.). Founder and Director of the IDF Generals Course, Strategema. Formerly, he served as the Director of the Operational Theory Research Institute (OTRI) at the National Defence College in Israel. General Naveh is a world-renowned expert in military theory, holding a PhD. He has a lengthy military background and combat experience from the IDF Paratroopers. During the Yom Kippur War, he commanded the Paratroopers' Combat Engineering Unit (Palhan). Subsequently, he Commanded the 450th Battalion and later the Gefen Battalion (the infantry officers' training course battalion at Bahad 1). During the First Lebanon War, he served as the Operations Officer (G3) of the 96th Division.

Later, he commanded the Valleys Regional Reserve Division, a formation resembling the David Division, which is now being (re-)established in the IDF. (Ref: Hebrew Wikipedia, (translated by Ofra Graicer) and personal conversations).

Or, Matan, IDF Lieutenant Colonel, Chief Executive Officer, Israel National Defense College. (Ref: personal conversation).

Ortal, Eran, IDF Brigadier General. Until recently, Ortal was the Commander of the IDF Dado Center, after which he retired from active duty. Currently, Ortal teaches Israeli Defense Strategy at Reichman University while serving as a senior consultant for strategy and technology at the Israeli Ministry of Defence. Brig. Gen Ortal holds a Master's in Security Studies from Tel Aviv University. (Ref: The Begin-Sadat Center for Strategic Studies, Webpage and personal conversation).

Preisler-Swery, Dana, IDF Researcher. Preisler-Swery is a senior researcher at the IDF Dado Center. She is an expert in Systemic Policy Design, consulting the IDF general staff and branch commanders. Preisler-Swery holds an MA in Security Studies from Tel Aviv University and is working on her PhD at Bar-Ilan University. (Ref: Reut Group, Webpage and personal conversation).

Shalom, Zaki, Professor/Senior Researcher INSS. Shalom is a research staff member at the INSS. He is also a Professor Emeritus at Ben Gurion University. Professor Shalom has published extensively on issues related to Israel's defence policy, the Arab-Israeli conflict, Israel's struggle against terror as well as the role of the superpowers in the Middle East. He holds a BA from the Hebrew University of Jerusalem and a PhD from Tufts University. (Ref: INSS Webpage and personal conversation).

Shelah, Ofer, Executive at INSS. Former Member of the Knesset Shelah, currently functions as the director of the Israel National Security Policy research program at INSS. Shelah served in the IDF paratrooper corps and, as a reserve company commander, was wounded in combat in Lebanon in 1983. He holds a B.A. in economics and English, magna cum laude, from Tel Aviv University, and an M.F.A. in English with a concentration in creative writing from New York University. In his 25-year career as a journalist, Shelah was a senior military and political columnist for Israel's leading newspapers and TV channels. (Ref: INSS Webpage and personal conversation).

Siman-Tov, David, Senior Researcher INSS/ IDF Lieutenant Colonel (res.). Siman-Tov is the deputy head of the Institute for the Research of the Methodology of Intelligence (IRMI) at the Israeli Intelligence Community Commemoration and Heritage Center. He has served in IDF intelligence for 25 years. Lt. Col. Siman-Tov has published widely on cognitive warfare, intelligence, and the cyber realm. (Ref: INSS Webpage and personal conversation).

Tamari, Dovik, IDF Brigadier General (ret.) Former chief of Sayeret Matkal, the 401st Armored Brigade, the 162nd Division and former IDF Chief Intelligence Officer. General Tamari enlisted as a paratrooper in 1954 and served in the 1956 Sinai War, the Six-Day War, the War of Attrition, the Yom Kippur War and Operation Litani. Tamari, who received *the Medal of Courage* for his service in Sayeret Matkal, holds a PhD in Military History from the University of Haifa. (Ref: Wikipedia and personal conversation).

Veruv, Itay, IDF Major General. Veruv is serving under the IDF Southern Command after concluding his tenure as a member of the IDF General Staff, Commander of the IDF Depth Corps (JCOM) and Commandant of the Military Colleges. Previously, he has served as Chief of Staff of the Ground Forces, Commander of the 143rd Gaza Division, Chief of the Infantry and Paratroopers Corps, Commander of the 55th Paratroopers Brigade and Commander of the Kfir Brigade. General Veruv holds a Master's degree in Military Strategy from the RCDS in the United Kingdom. (Ref: Wikipedia and personal conversation).

Wertman, Uri. A research fellow at the University of South Wales, a former research fellow at the Jerusalem Institute for Strategy and Security (JISS), and a former researcher at the Institute for National Security Studies (INSS). (Ref: EUCTER Webpage and personal conversation).

Yitzhak, Gershon (Jerry), IDF Major General (res.). Currently, General Yitzhak is serving as Deputy Commander of the IDF Northern Command. Previously, Yitzhak has served as Commander of the Home Front Command, The Judea and Samaria Division, the 98th Paratrooper Division, the 55th Paratroopers Brigade and Paratroopers Battalion commander. (Ref: Wikipedia and personal conversation).

Anonymous 1, IDF Official, non-specified.

Anonymous 2, IDF Official, non-specified.

Section 2, Exclusive/closed formats:

Below, a second layer of contributors is listed. These are individuals whom I have had the opportunity to listen to firsthand during presentations/seminars in exclusive/closed formats. The list could be made longer, but it is limited to the persons who have provided tangible contributions to the project.

ISDEF Crisis Manage Conference (Tel Aviv, 22nd of March 2022)

Gordin, Uri, IDF Major General. Currently Commanding Officer of the IDF Northern Command, and, during the presentation, Commander of IDF Homefront Command.

Ya'alon, Moshe (Boogie), IDF Lieutenant General (ret.). Former Minister of Defence and former IDF Chief of Staff.

Pardo, Tamir, Former Director of the Mossad

Danino, Yohanan, Former chief of the Israel Police

Alsheich, Roni, Former intelligence officer and chief of the Israel Police

Israeli National Defence College, International Program (Closed seminar, Dayan Base, 30th of January 2024)

Milshtein, Michael, IDF Colonel (ret.), served as the Advisor on Palestinian Affairs in COGAT (Coordinator of Government Activities in the Territories) and the Head of the Department for Palestinians Affairs in IDF Military Intelligence (AMAN). The presentation concerned the topic of Hamas- organisation layout and functioning logic.

Hagari, Daniel, IDF Rear Admiral, Head of IDF Spokespersons Unit. The presentation concerned the topic of Trust- Reliability, and International Legitimacy in the Gaza war between Hamas and Israel.

Harel, Amos, A leading Military and Defence analyst for the Israeli newspaper *Haaretz.* A reflective presentation concerning the Hamas attack of 7th October, the shock of it, and the implications it had and will have on Israeli society.

Appendix 2: 'Interview guide'

1. How do you perceive 'Operational'? Meaning/Main features?

2. When I say Depth, or in particular, Operational Depth (OD), what comes to your mind – how can it be **understood or perceived** from the perspectives formed by your experience and insight?

3. From what angles do you think OD can be measured- or considered?

4. How do you perceive 'Cognitive depth'?

5. If we employ the artificial division between 'Forward Depth/Rearward Depth', what aspects- or features come into your mind?

6. What aspects do you think are important 'depth-builders/enhancers' in the Israeli context, considering the limited physical Depth?

7. Which aspect do you think is the most crucial general aspect concerning Israeli OD?

8. Considering Forward Depth, what do you see/perceive as the most important feature within the Israeli setting? (Deep Ops, long arm, etc?) What are your reflections concerning Israeli Forward Depth achievements during 2LBW?

9. Considering Rearward Depth, what do you see/perceive as the most important feature within the Israeli setting? What are your reflections concerning Israeli rearward depth achievements during 2LBW?

10. What shortcoming concerning Israeli OD would be the first addressed, if you could choose?

11. What would comprise the biggest looming- or experienced 'operational trap' according to the Israeli (your) experience?

12. Let's consider *Momentum* and *Culmination*. On the one hand, what Clausewitz calls the diminishing effect of the attack- relative to what Jomini calls the inner lines and ability to shift- or concentrate the direction of the main effort. What are your general reflections in relation to the Israeli setting? Reflections of this duality about 2LBW?

13. Which aspect do you think is the most critical cognitive aspect concerning Israeli OD

14. How would you say your opponent´s weaknesses are perceived/analysed?

Appendix 3: 'Project description'

Operational depth – *scope of research*,

In my research, I view Operational depth (OD) as a martial source of power. Thus, something not exclusively military, but rather a combination of means available to project power, absorb enemy hostilities and the freedom to manoeuvre coercive assets to favourable positions. In a previous issue of Comparative Strategy, I define OD as "*…the ability to project power, absorb power and to maintain the ability to manoeuvre available coercive tools- or assets along physical- or cognitive, offensive- and defensive lines of operation…"*

Approaches to OD normally tend to focus on the physical- or temporal aspects of depth. My contribution also considers these traditional aspects. However, my main focus is rather the means, measures and effects when OD is built, maintained- or considered from a *cognitive* perspective.

Building on the above definition, the impressive ability of Israel to handle its surrounding environment clearly is very interesting from a generic actor perspective such as the Swedish, not least in times marked by rising threat levels, hence the devoted focus in my research. Till this point, I have been studying Israeli OD in relation to the action displayed during the second Lebanon War; thus, from my perspective, this engagement offers many of the unclear, messy- or complex features that tend to reflect contemporary warfare. The 2006 war, although very interesting in its own right, is not the main focus in itself, but rather the unique examples and ideas it provides. The lessons-learned aspects are thus especially interesting, mainly through their influence on how Israeli depth is constructed and maintained up to the present day.

My belief is that there certainly is a plethora of highly valuable aspects- or characteristics of Israeli OD that could be made to travel to other small states- or inferior actors who lack depth, such as Sweden, perhaps not in detail, but at least on a conceptual level.

Since the research engages with several theoretical areas, the below aspects could serve as indicators of my interests:

Forward depth – intelligence, offensive/deep operations (interdiction-disruption) and intended cognitive effects (Display penetrability, blacken, embarrass, destroy collective confidence, to actual dislocation of strength/weaknesses)

Rearward depth – ability to absorb, maintain resilience and support

Momentum – create and sustain, effective direction of effort, ability to concentrate/disperse (maneuver) available coercive tools along inner lines of operation.

Culmination – Prevention of, from the angles of physical, temporal or cognitive. Say-Do; reasonable objectives, expectations and acceptance of prolonged operations when needed.

Skill & knowledge, mission command and Doer Ethos – depth multipliers, speed- and effect amplifiers.

Best Regards,

Anders Ekholm

LtCol (SWAF, A)/PhD Researcher

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